

Phil 375 Aristotle: From Logic to Life

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 375 • Dr. James Orr

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Lecture 1: Aristotle's Life

At a glance — Orr opens the series on Aristotle with his life and intellectual background.

- 1.1** Welcome to Lecture 1, Aristotle: From Logic to Life. Why are we studying Aristotle? Why him? Why is he so foundational to Western thought? In this series, we're going to look at all of the different aspects of Aristotle's intellectual legacy. We'll consider his life, we'll consider his impact on philosophy after him, not just philosophy, but a whole range of different areas.
- 1.2** It'll become clear from that that an introduction to Aristotle is an introduction to philosophy. To understand his work is to understand the very foundations of Western philosophy. It's to have various golden keys that can help you unlock and understand different problems all through the history of ideas, particularly European ideas ever since him. Even when there've been these very self-conscious, aggressive revolutions against the Aristotelian legacy—which we see, for example, in 13th century Paris, and then we see again more aggressively in 17th-century England, and then throughout the Enlightenment, which styles itself and the new science as a repudiation of a lot of Aristotelian ideas.
- 1.3** But even in getting rid of them, the revolutionaries, as is often the case with revolutions, are shaped by the very ideologies that they repudiated. And so what has been called by one scholar, Aristotle's revenge, is now underway in philosophy faculties all across the West, particularly in the area of metaphysics, the technical area of philosophy that's devoted to the nature of ultimate reality—Aristotle invented that too. Metaphysics on the one hand, and since the Second World War, so this has been going on for several decades now, Aristotle's revenge when it comes to moral philosophy and thinking about virtue, thinking about vice, thinking about character, character formation in particular, the so-called turn to virtue was well underway in the late 1950s. We'll consider that legacy a little bit more in our final lecture.
- 1.4** So an introduction to Aristotle is an introduction to philosophy, but not just to philosophy. His range is unlike any other figure in the history of thought or the history of the arts. Perhaps the only one who comes close is Leonardo da Vinci in terms of the range of his talents, that kind of polymathic power, being at ease with so many different areas. But Leonardo da Vinci doesn't invent anything. He doesn't found new avenues of thought. Aristotle does, and we're going to be considering in the next few lectures each of those great foundational avenues of human thought that he opens up for the first time. We're not going to be able to cover all of them. He wrote about 150 works; only 30 have survived, and those 30 alone have had an explosive impact on shaping the Western mind.
- 1.5** So, in this lecture, we'll be considering his life, his historical context, his relationship with his great teacher Plato, his subsequent role as tutor to Alexander the Great, and

his founding of a new institution distinct from Plato's Academy called the Lyceum. We'll be looking at that in more detail in this lecture.

- 1.6 In the next lecture, we'll be looking at two disciplines that he founded: the first, logic. He founds logic. Now, of course, that's not to say that people before Aristotle were illogical in the way they argued, the way they spoke. No, but Aristotle is the first person to ask: How do we think? How do we reason? What are the actual nuts and bolts? What's the scaffolding going behind all thought? He systematizes it. He lays it all out, all the different rules.
- 1.7 We'll consider that in more detail in Lecture 2, as well as the philosophy of nature. He has a radically new way of thinking about the natural world. He's obsessed with the natural world. He's very much a scientist; he's a botanist, studying the weather patterns. Very different from Plato, who you might say, whose head is much more in the clouds, who's suspicious of what we can see and touch and smell, because that's constantly changing. The world of science, for Plato, is something that is fickle and unreliable. You might hallucinate about it, you might get things wrong. It's not like mathematics, not like pure thought, which is removed from the sensible world, from the physical world, the sensory world. Everything is bottom-up for Aristotle. He's looking at the bottom, he's examining nature as it is, and then trying to derive certain general principles, which develops into this extraordinary piece of intellectual and philosophical architecture when it comes to nature.
- 1.8 In Lecture 3, we're going to move even higher up, really, to the peak of philosophy when we look at his contributions to metaphysics. I say contributions to, but he founded it. He founded metaphysics. The word metaphysics in Greek, simply meta ta physika, means "after the physics." And I think it's quite plausible that when his works are being put together and classified in the great library of Alexandria, there was Aristotle's physics, ta physika, the stuff about the physical, about nature, the first work of physics.
- 1.9 And then, there's this other book, which is a little bit like a physics textbook, but it's asking not about matter and change, but about being itself, and that seems like a higher kind of physics. We're not really sure where to put this book, but let's put it meta ta physika. Let's put it after, next to the physics book. It's sort of like physics, but it's not like physics. The word metaphysics, as we use it today, goes right back to that which transcends physics, transcends the natural world, if anything does at all. So that's Lecture 3.
- 1.10 In Lecture 4, we're going to turn to ethics. Aristotle is the first person to write a systematic treatise on how to be good, how to be virtuous, how to think about the good life, how to think about what human flourishing is.
- 1.11 Takes us very naturally into the following lecture, Lecture 5, where we're going to look at Aristotle's political philosophy. He's the first person to write a systematic treatise on

politics. It's the things to do with the polis, ta politika, becomes known as the Politics. Now, of course, Plato had written The Republic and The Laws, two great treatises on imagining a perfect city and how it would fit together and so on. So it's not as if Aristotle is the first political philosopher, but he's the first person to approach it in a systematic way.

- 1.12 For example, as part of the Politics, he goes through 158 different constitutions. Talk about how he likes to examine the world first before drawing conclusions about it—158 constitutions, most of which are lost to us now, where he's sifting through and comparing and working out how to fit together a city-state, a flourishing moral community that starts from an understanding of what it is to be human, what it is to have families, what it is to be in villages and larger communities.
- 1.13 Then finally, Lectures 6 and 7, we're gonna be looking at two equally important contributions that Aristotle made. The Poetics: literary theory in Lecture 6—he's the first person to think about and write systematically about: How do we evaluate good art as good art? What is tragedy? What's the point of tragedy? What's the point of drama? What is poetry? What can poetry convey that pure philosophy can't, and so on and so forth?
- 1.14 And then, Rhetoric. In the penultimate lecture, we're going to be looking at his contributions to rhetoric. Again, the first person ever to write a systematic treatise on the art of persuasion, on how to persuade, how to present, how to marshal argument. And then, finally, as I said in the final lecture, we'll come into land by looking at the revival of Aristotle, Aristotle's revenge in 20th-century ethics and 20th-century metaphysics.
- 1.15 Before we dive into his thought, it's worth noting some of the general features of his thought. I've said already that he is very empiricist. The word empiricist means experience is the benchmark of what counts as real, what counts as most real and most knowable. That's the kind of reasoning he likes to do. It's an inference and a fascination with the natural world, a longing to classify it, to taxonomize it.
- 1.16 He's got a very ordered approach to philosophy; it's quite business-like compared to Plato, which is all conversations. It's all transcripts of dinner party conversations. It's a very, very different style. He's systematic. He thinks in systems. Everything's got to fit together. As we'll see, his position, his understanding of nature, has a knock-on effect to his understanding of human nature that's qualified a little bit. And that in itself has an understanding for how ethics is to be understood, because it's got to be anchored to the nature of whatever it is that's supposed to be flourishing. And that in turn has a knock-on effect to his theory of politics, and so on and so forth.
- 1.17 So he has to fit all of these avenues of human inquiry that he himself is single-handedly opening up into this extraordinary city where all the roads connect properly and don't

smash into each other. Instead, it's a coherent system. It's a cathedral of thought, you might say, that he's building.

- 1.18** It's worth now trying to get a sense of who this man was and how we think of him. Plato himself called him simply "the Mind," or "the Reader." So imagine, Plato himself saying that he's the guy; he's the guy we should call "the Mind." That's a little clue to his talent, his promise very early on.
- 1.19** Thomas Aquinas, 1224 to 1274, devotes much of the 10-million-word output that he produced towards either commentaries on Aristotle or attempts to baptize Aristotle into Christian moral theology or Christian metaphysics. When Aquinas refers to Aristotle, he never uses his name; he says philosophus, which is Latin for "the Philosopher." Aristotle had that status already. And that, by the way, is within just a few decades of him being rediscovered.
- 1.20** As we'll see in a later lecture, Aristotle is lost to the West for centuries, and he's brought back in very, very fast. So he's translated back in and gets back into the bloodstream of European thought very, very quickly, probably around about the second half of the 12th century, by 1200, 1215, just before Aquinas is born. It's beginning to not just be translated, but disseminated from Spain all the way up across the Pyrenees to Paris, across the Italian universities, and eventually to Oxford and Cambridge.
- 1.21** That has an explosive impact on European thought. It really founds the whole system of medieval scholasticism, which is the thought world that dominates Europe and Christendom, really up until the end of the 15th century, when Plato is rediscovered in Renaissance Florence in particular. And so you have a whole big Platonic push, too. Anyway, we'll go into that in more detail in due course.
- 1.22** So who is this figure? The first thing to point out is that he's not an Athenian. He's not from Athens. Nor is he even really from Greece, as it was thought of at the time. There was a lot of debate, we know, in the fifth century, in fact, as to whether the Macedonians—which is where Aristotle is from, Macedonia, north of the northern border of Greece—whether people from Macedonia should be allowed to compete in the Olympic Games.
- 1.23** The Olympic Games is effectively every four years; all the polis, all the city-states would put down their weapons, there'd be a time of peace, and they would compete in the Olympic Games. They were Pan-Hellenic games, that is to say, your qualifying criterion was that you were Greek, you were from a Greek polis, a Greek city-state.
- 1.24** For a long time, it was very difficult for the king of Macedon to get himself invited to these games or to be allowed to compete because they were seen as hillbillies. Their Greek was very rough; they couldn't really understand them. It was a classic confrontation, as it were. The Macedonians were seen as not particularly well educated, though increasingly talented on the military front and very good with horses.

In central Greece and in Attica, it's very difficult to raise horses, very difficult to breed horses. You haven't got any of the land and the fields to sustain a big horse industry.

- 1.25** So it's really with that development that the Macedonians build up their military power over the course of, well, really Aristotle's life. When Aristotle arrives in Athens, age about 17—he's born in 384, and he arrives in Athens around 367 BC. And remember, just to give you a sense of the dates: Socrates's trial and execution is in 399 BC. The Peloponnesian War rips apart the Greek world, really in such a way that reduces both its key players, Athens and Sparta, to almost nothing in the fourth century. That Peloponnesian War runs from 431 to 404 BC. That has a titanic effect on the Greek world, and it certainly weakens the great city-states of Sparta and Corinth and Athens and so on and so forth.
- 1.26** So Macedon in the north, which has been relatively untouched, completely untouched in fact by the Peloponnesian War, has been able to grow and start to eye up these weakened cities further south. Aristotle is coming from this emerging, increasingly confident and aggressive and expansionist power with imperial ambitions. He ends up somehow in Athens, where he immediately acquires the status of a *metoikos*.
- 1.27** As a *metoikos*, you might say he's got permission to stay as a resident foreigner. He's a resident foreigner, and that's what he will be throughout his many, many decades in Athens. He's not allowed to be an Athenian. His parents are not Athenian. He could not, therefore, contribute to the *ecclesia*, the democratic assembly. He couldn't serve on juries. There's a whole area of Athenian public life he was completely locked out of, which must have been, given the views that he developed, very subtle and sophisticated views on rhetoric and politics and ethics, you might have thought they could have at least made an exception for him, perhaps. But no, at various points in his career in Athens, as Macedon gets stronger and more powerful, he is held in more suspicion until, in the end, he has to leave Athens. In fact, he leaves Athens twice.
- 1.28** But he arrives, let's say, in his teenage years at the Academy. And so for the next 20 years, he is at Plato's feet. So from 367 BC when he arrives in Athens, to Plato's death, which, we're pretty sure, is 347. He's got 20 years of exposure to Plato, and particularly, we can start to understand which are the parts that he appropriates from Plato, which are the parts that he is reversing or overturning.
- 1.29** It's a big debate still in ancient philosophy: Is it Plato and then Aristotle? Are these the twin engines of European philosophy? Well, yes, that's true. Some people say, though, that it's more like a turbo engine. You've got to understand both of them together, that you can't understand Aristotle without Plato's influence, and it's Plato that is achieving the foundational insights that provide the enabling conditions for Aristotle to get going.
- 1.30** A very brilliant book on Aristotle by Lloyd Gerson, a very fine ancient philosopher, is called *Aristotle and Other Platonists*. So this is a witty title intended to hit back at the textbook philosophy approach, which is, once upon a time, there was Plato, he had

these unusual ideas and these various approaches. Then, there was Aristotle, and Aristotle overturned them all. And then, we can learn subsequent philosophy by comparing their two positions.

- 1.31** I think both sides are probably guilty of exaggeration. I think in the end it's quite obvious that, as we'll see, Aristotle is at least as committed to what we call Plato's Forms, the Forms hanging in Plato's heaven that I'll come on to explain, as Plato himself. It's just that he locates them differently. In fact, you might say that he locates a Form within every single living being, within every single substance. You might say he takes Form, Plato's idea of Form, even more seriously than Plato himself, whereas Plato has them hanging up there in his heaven, Aristotle brings them right down and sees them wired into every substance. So there's a lot that Aristotle picks up.
- 1.32** He's clearly worked very hard as a student, takes mathematics very seriously, but he's also got emphases and focuses to, that Plato seems to be entirely indifferent to, particularly what we would now call the natural sciences. In fact, you might say even on questions of the soul, although Plato has some extraordinary discussions on the nature of the soul in the Phaedrus dialogue and the Phaedo dialogue, and of course, Books VI and VII of The Republic. But Aristotle is the first to produce a treatise called simply *De Anima*, *Peri Tēs Psychēs*, *On the Soul*—what is the soul, and what are we talking about with the soul? But again, it's hard to see him have that interest and focus on what ensoulment is had it not been for his 20 years with Plato in the Academy.
- 1.33** So when Plato dies in 347, there's a succession crisis. Who's gonna take over? Who will succeed the founder to Plato's Academy? I should say that the history of this period, particularly around philosophers, is extremely flaky, as we might say. It's weak. We can't rely on very much at all, unfortunately. It's worth adding a rider to that, that the reason we haven't really got great sources, contemporaneous sources for figures like Aristotle and Plato and Socrates—whereas we do with the great leaders like Alcibiades or Pericles or Themistocles—the reason for it is that actually these people are pretty peripheral eccentric oddballs within Athenian society.
- 1.34** It's easy for us to think, when we think back to the glories of Greece, that we think of the philosophy. It might not be the first thing we think of. There's so many other things—there's the drama, there's the democracy, there's law courts emerging, all the wars, all the fun wars and myths and all of that. But philosophy would be up there. It's what founds reason and philosophical inquiry. It's so important for Western ideas. It's where Western ideas begin. So it's tempting to think that they were lionized in their own time and held with high regard, et cetera, et cetera.
- 1.35** But they weren't. They were seen as, broadly speaking, troublemakers. Socrates certainly was, as became clear when his own people finally shut him up in 399 by forcing him to drink hemlock on charges that suggest that he was seen as a mischief maker. Two charges against Socrates at the trial. One, that he's corrupting the youth. He's corrupting—what does that mean? Well, probably encouraging the jeunesse

dorée, the gilded youth of Athens from not being proud of being an Athenian and not staying focused on the business at hand, which was to beat the Spartans or rather recover from having been beaten by the Spartans in 399.

- 1.36** The second charge was introducing new gods. Socrates is introducing, he's destabilizing the civic religion, which is the organizing principle for Athens. That's what Athens is. Athens is the temple to Athena. It's saturated in the sacred, Athens, as was every other city-state. So, this is the context. They were seen as threatening and subversive, Socrates, but also some others, the so-called Sophists, these traveling teachers, traveling wise men.
- 1.37** The difference with Socrates—and this is something that he encourages clearly, that is downstream of the philosophers who emerge after him—is that he doesn't take payment for it. He doesn't see it as a service that's provided, which many of the other sophists did. The thrust of Plato's dialogues is a critique of this idea that you should be paying anybody. The pursuit of knowledge, the pursuit of truth, should be a mercenary enterprise. He's very suspicious of this. He thinks that it corrupts, and particularly allows demagogues within the ecclesia in the democratic assembly in Athens to get very, very good at saying, as Gorgias, one of the most famous sophists, was fond of saying, "I can make young Athenians argue that black is white and that white is black."
- 1.38** There's a great premium on this, of course, in the emerging democracy in Athens. Remember—to fill you in on that—there is no democracy, or nothing really like it, until it emerges in Athens in 508 to 507 BC, and it continues really all the way up through into the fourth century BC. But this period we're talking about 508-507 BC, all the way up to the defeat by Athens at the hands of Sparta at the end of the Peloponnesian War in 404, that is the golden age of Athens, the golden age of Greece. Y
- 1.39** ou might say it's the most golden age of any chapter in the history of human civilization. There are very few periods that come close to it. Maybe Renaissance Florence in the 15th century, maybe Vienna at its peak in the late 19th century, possibly Elizabethan London at the turn of the 17th century. But none of those periods really come close to the breadth or comprehensiveness of the achievement of Athens in that short period, 508 BC to 404 BC.
- 1.40** What we see—and this is before Aristotle's got going—we see the emergence of a mechanism of democracy. Not entirely like ours; it's direct democracy rather than representative democracy. But it is a full-blown, incredibly carefully worked out, democratic constitutional vision, which is modified and changed. Yes, there are all sorts of tensions, but you have a trend. What you have is a transition from a highly aristocratic society that is shaped—whose universe is shaped by the universe of the Iliad and the Odyssey and some lyric poetry. There's crude forms of law code emerging here and there.

- 1.41** But really, almost at a single stroke, this figure of Cleisthenes, there's a revolt against some tyrants of Athens, and as Cleisthenes puts in place this unbelievably well worked-out structure to elect an assembly of 10,000 citizens who would all have a vote, Athenian men—Athenian, that is to say, both whose parents were Athenian—men over the age of 23, could have a vote, would have a vote in this assembly of 10,000. Then, there was a smaller boule of 500, which is made up of chunks of 50 people who are sent by the different constituencies, by the different groups around Athens, to be part of the executive, as it were. So the boule is the executive.
- 1.42** And then, you have a prytaneis, a president at the top, and the president is president for 24 hours. Every 24 hours, they get a new president. The president is more like a chairman guiding the prytaneis, the presidency, which sits on top of the boule, which is the executive, which is itself all structured and voted on. All the big decisions are voted on by the ecclesia, by the assembly. This is a radical new approach, one that Aristotle himself would have found quite extraordinary. He's coming from a kingship. Macedon is a monarchy. Monarchies had basically faded out from the rest of Greece by that point.
- 1.43** Really, the battle that raged through the fifth century BC was between pro-oligarchy people and pro-democracy people. The pro-oligarchy people were the older, more traditionalists who remembered the ethos of Homeric aristocrats who were stepping out of Homer. That tended to be the tension. But Aristotle himself is coming from a monarchy, and he's looking at these big battles between democracies and oligarchies, and that explains, as we'll see, shapes a lot of what he has to say in his work on the Politics, which we'll look at in a few lectures' time.
- 1.44** So after his 20 years at the Academy, there's, as I said, a succession crisis. Aristotle was probably expected to succeed Plato. He's refused, and it goes to Plato's nephew—terrible nepotism here; it goes straight to his nephew, Speusippus. So Aristotle leaves Athens. And I think it was probably the correct decision not to make him head of the Academy. I think first of all, it would have limited the Academy's impact on the intellectual life of Athens and the Hellenic world. Why? Because Aristotle was a metic, not just a non-Athenian, but possibly not even Greek, not truly Hellenic. That would have been a plausible reason to be nervous about appointing him.
- 1.45** Also, at the time, this is 347, Phillip II is sweeping through the whole of Greece and reducing it to either a wasteland or demanding total subordination; that's only about 10 to 15 years away. Macedon in the 340s is already becoming a major geopolitical power, whereas it was just hillbilly country a few decades before that. It was not seen as harmless or threatening at all, but it probably was in the 340s. Philip II, in particular, is securing some astonishing military victories. So again, do we really want to make a Macedonian—even though he's been around, he's been with us for 20 years—do we really want to make this Macedonian with all the rumblings around going on up in

Macedon and the warlike noises we're hearing from Macedon, is it really a good idea to have a Macedonian in charge of Plato's Academy?

- 1.46** Remember, Plato comes from a very Athenian, very aristocratic family. It's a very high-born family. It would have been wonderful just to observe them talking. You've got the hillbilly from Macedonia, whose Greek, his accent would have been very strong, and this aristocratic, noble-born Plato, who is incredibly well-connected, very influential. Clearly, they got on very well.
- 1.47** So he goes into a self-imposed exile after 347. He teaches around the eastern half of the Mediterranean, particularly around Ionia, which is modern-day Turkey. It's probably around here that he starts his biological research, which would have been relatively limited in Athens. Anyone who's been to Athens, there's some nature there, but it doesn't have anything like what Aristotle discovered on his travels in these wilderness years in Asia Minor, in effect, is where he was. He traveled around. He traveled around the Greek islands.
- 1.48** Then, in the late 340s, just a few years after leaving Athens, he's asked to become tutor to a young 13-year-old boy back home. This 13-year-old boy turns out to be the king's son, Alexander. Philip has big plans for Alexander. He thinks he's gonna be a great man one day, and he was right. But he thought, "I need somebody to tutor him. I need somebody to shape him and to form him." And so for a number of years—it's difficult to get the years exactly right—but he spent probably not far off a decade from the mid-340s to the mid-330s when Alexander decided he had other things to be getting on with, like invading the rest of Greece, Attica, the Peloponnese, Persia, all the way up to Afghanistan. He wanted to go on to China, but his men got fed up and said, "No, we've had enough. It's time to turn back." But for seven or eight years, Aristotle would have been a counsel to a prince, a counsel to this extraordinary—not many figures one can say are historic figures, but Alexander the Great, I think very safely we can, in terms of the transformation that he brings about all across the known world at that time.
- 1.49** When Alexander is born, or before he starts to make his incursions into Greece, he will be a complete unknown in history books. Within 12 to 13 years, he's the most significant military commander of all time, only Napoleon probably beats him in terms of the frequency of victory. But when Aristotle dies, the world is speaking Greek. When Aristotle dies in 322—he was born into a world where speaking Greek and Greek culture was basically still quite parochial. Greece had lost a lot of its city-states all up and down Asia Minor to the Persian Empire, had been forced out of Egypt, forced out of Sicily. It didn't look great for Greek civilization. In the year that Alexander dies in 323 BC, the entire world is speaking Greek from the south of France and North Africa all the way east across Iran and deep into India and even Afghanistan.
- 1.50** So what we see in political thought is a shift from being a citizen of my polis, a citizen of my community—I'm first and foremost an Athenian, or I'm first and foremost a Spartan, or I'm first and foremost a Corinthian—to this idea that hold on, I speak a

language that is now spoken all across the known world, a world that is actually unfathomable to me, whose boundaries are inconceivable to me, but I'm told now that Greece, Alexander's successors, the Basileus, the kings, are now in charge, have just carved up the world into a Greek-speaking world.

- 1.51** This is what we come to know as the Hellenistic world, the Hellenistic civilization. So the influence of Greek, you might have your native language, but all educated people, whether they were in what was left of Persia, whether they were in what was left of Afghanistan, were speaking Greek, would be able to speak Greek.
- 1.52** After finishing up as Alexander's tutor, Aristotle returns to Athens for the last few years of his life. So around about 335 all the way up to his death in 323. In 335, he founds a new university, as it were. Plato is the first to found anything like a place of communal learning with the Academy in 387. But when Aristotle comes back to Athens, obviously, there was the thing about the succession 12 years beforehand, and he wasn't going to impose himself, no doubt, but also his thought had clearly evolved in such a way that it would have been confusing to see him as a straightforward follower and acolyte or successor to Plato.
- 1.53** So he starts his own gig near the grove that is by a gymnasium, and it's by the grove to Apollo Lyceus, Apollo in his wolf guise under his wolf aspect. Lykeios in Greek means simply "wolf," so the Wolf Grove, the area around Apollo, the wolf god—around there we'll call it the Wolf Place, the Lykeion or the Lyceum in Latin or the Lyceum, or Lycée, or Liceo in European languages. And so the Lyceum is founded and it persists. It carries on under good succession, solid succession.
- 1.54** There's a covered walkway we know in the Lyceum, which Aristotle would walk around as he spoke and taught. It was almost like the medieval monks or Anselm around his cloisters in Canterbury. This is what he did. To walk around in Greek is peripatein. To walk around is peripatein: patéō is "to walk," peripatein is "around." Peripatein is "to walk around." So this is called the peripatos or the peripatein. This is the surrounding walkway and that's how he would teach. That was the mode he would like to teach in.
- 1.55** That's why his subsequent schools after he died, for many, many hundreds of years, were called the Peripatetics: the ones who wander around the whole time, walk around in circles, talking. That's the Aristotle people, that's the Aristotle crew. That was their signature. So get your steps in if you want to be as good a philosopher as Aristotle. Solvitur ambulando is this lovely Latin phrase: things resolve themselves through walking, long walks.
- 1.56** So these final years of his life, from 335 to 322, are probably the most intellectually fertile, intensely fertile years, not just of his life, but really of the life of any human being. What he produced in that period is awe-inspiring, difficult to understand how he achieved it. One of the problems is that reading Aristotle is much harder than reading Plato. What we have with Plato is this beautiful prose. It's elegant, and it's done in the

context of a dinner party, or a drinking party, or some walk around the city. Plato is a brilliant dramatist. He's great with humor and conversation. He can build beautiful speeches. And the Greek itself, the quality of the Greek is unrivaled. Nobody wrote better prose, Greek prose than Plato. He really lifts Attic Greek from—if you read somebody like Thucydides, Attic Greek is very difficult, confusing, doesn't have any of the stylistic finesse that Plato then endows it with when he writes his dialogues.

- 1.57** With Aristotle, we don't have any of his polished material. None of his proper writings, as it were, have survived. What we've got most likely all the way through his 30-odd works—the reason we've got them is effectively students taking notes on his lectures. That's effectively what they are. That's why they are stylistically pretty bland. They don't have any finesse or ordering or structuring that we would expect from a mind like this. So it's easy to be unfair to him for this, but this is just how his work has survived. We do know from Cicero and others that the polished work, the work that he prepared for the world to read, was like a golden river, I think Cicero calls it, a golden river.
- 1.58** But that golden river is lost to us, at least for now, that texts are turning up all over the place, in particular, actually, recently in Herculaneum, some of the carbonized scrolls in the house of Philodemus, who was a late first-, early second-century Greek-speaking Hellenistic tutor to aristocratic families. We found his library. We've had his library as part of the excavations of Herculaneum. Partly through AI and partly through all sorts of impressive technological techniques, we're now able to read these carbonized scrolls for the first time in 2,000 years. There's bound to be a piece of Aristotle popping up at some point, and we'll just have to be patient.
- 1.59** What else is there to say about Aristotle's life? A couple of years before he dies, he leaves Athens for a second time, a second and final time, and moves to a place called Chalcis, which is in Evia, modern-day Evia, about 100 miles or so from Athens. Almost certainly, when Alexander dies in 323, there's a big anti-Macedon backlash in Athens and a celebration that Alexander has died. It's almost certainly that context that persuaded Aristotle. It was probably not safe for him to stay in Athens. It's rather sad. So he escapes and goes to his mother's family estate in Euboea.
- 1.60** He's alleged to have said, "I will not let Athens sin twice against philosophy." I want to believe he said that, but the biographies are much later, and it's not until later that these figures are really, as I said, seen in their proper historical context in terms of the impact and influence that they've had.
- 1.61** In closing, it's worth coming back to this question of the scale and breadth of his achievement. In the next lecture, as I said, we'll be looking at how he thinks about thinking, and that will help us to think about thinking. What are we doing when we're thinking? What are we doing when we're reasoning? How could we map all of this out? That was connected in his mind to nature, because he said that it's only once you've worked out how thinking works that you can start to think properly about anything else. That's the only way you can start thinking in particular about nature, the world in

which we find ourselves, and nature's responsiveness to our logical inferences into the way we map our structures of thought onto it in such a way that it yields truth, new knowledge, things that we can test, things that we can build and rely on.

1.62 The logic and the biology goes together, the two go together. There's the world of pure thought, like mathematics, and then there's the world of, should we say, pure matter or stuff, the concrete world that is constantly changing. Whereas Plato clearly prefers one world over the other world, that is to say the life of the mind over the life of nature, Aristotle wants to hold the two together. He's interested in both. So, that's logic and biology.

1.63 Then, we'll move on to thinking about psychology and ensoulment. We'll be thinking about metaphysics, which I mentioned earlier, too. Foundational works that I've touched on very briefly in ethics and politics, literary theory and rhetoric. But also, he's the first person to write about climate, about geography, about meteorology, about weather patterns, trying to understand them, geology, different kinds of rock. He classifies over 500 species, which is pretty impressive in that part of the world. The classification system of genus and the species—all of that he designs and builds.

1.64 He looks at comparative anatomy, comparative embryology, and really that whole system. His work in biology alone is unsurpassed until the 1400s, really until the Renaissance, until da Vinci and others. That is the way that all educated people, the most educated people on the planet, thought about the world of animals and nature; it was really conditioned by Aristotle's work in biology. And that's just his work in biology. We're doing half a lecture on that. Half a lecture is all we've got time for on that.

1.65 And then, even economics as well. In fact, I was working on a piece looking at Aristotle's criteria for what money is in the context of bitcoin and whether cryptocurrencies or stablecoins satisfy how many of the criteria of what Aristotle says money must satisfy in order to be good money. It might be. Actually, it's a very interesting, I'm going to develop this a little bit more. I think it's interesting. I think bitcoin might hit at least as many of Aristotle's criteria for what counts as good money as gold, and maybe one more, who knows. We'll have to look into it.

1.66 Just to bring things to a close for this lecture, as we look back on, we look at Aristotle's life, it was in some ways not a particularly eventful life: a lot of reading, a lot of thinking, a lot of walking around in circles, talking. One might say: What can we get from it? The German philosopher, Martin Heidegger, 1889-ish to 1976, once opened a series of very famous lectures on Aristotle by saying, he did this first lecture in about five seconds, he said, "Aristotle, he was born, he lived, he died. Now, let us turn to his thought."

1.67 There's a tradition in certain corners of philosophy not to be at all interested in the life of a philosopher. We're just looking at the thought of a philosopher. It doesn't matter who his mom was. It doesn't matter who he tutored. It doesn't matter where he was

from. What matters is: Is he right? Are they good arguments? But I think it's important for us to get a sense of the historical period, partly because it helps us to grasp the scale of his achievement.

- 1.68** Just think of that: a teenage boy, very barely fluent and certainly barely fluent in Attic Greek, arrives, immediately catches the eye of the most titanic intellect, certainly the Greek world had seen, and works with him for 20 years, is passed over, but accepts it apparently with grace, heads off to do a bit of fishing, classify some animal species and rocks and so on, and then gets a call from one of the most increasingly powerful people in the Mediterranean world, Philip of Macedon, "Would you come and tutor my boy?", which he does for eight years and then returns to Athens. Alexander would often send him exhibits, little things that he found on the battlefields. He would pick up these little bits of rock and he would get them shipped back to Aristotle to help him with his studies.
- 1.69** So I think a sense of his life is important to understand the scale of his achievement, but also it's important to understand the context in which he's writing in terms of the religious questions that he's tackling, where he stands in what chapter he occupies in the history of Western philosophical thought. Because this is a very intense period where different schools are opening up. Being able to understand how Aristotle relates to Plato, to Socrates, to a number of other philosophers as well, whose names will come up, is important.
- 1.70** But again, I think the thing to stress is the legacy of Aristotle, to understand the basic ideas of Aristotle. They're not actually that complicated. Some of them seem so obvious as to be common sense, but he was the first to state them as common sense and to recognize the need for us to articulate what might seem like common sense and to reflect carefully on it. So yes, to understand all these different ideas is to have this golden key, this open sesame for so many chapters, so many different areas, not just a philosophy, but of human thought itself, for many, many centuries downstream of him.
- 1.71** We might say that nobody really believes in Aristotelian biology anymore. Well, yes and no. I'll suggest that in the final lecture, Aristotle is coming back in some significant ways into the philosophy of biology and the philosophy of science. You might say that nobody really signs up to Aristotle's logic anymore. That's not true. Aristotle's logic still works just as Newtonian physics still works within a particular context.
- 1.72** What happened in the late 19th century—it wasn't until the 19th century that somebody comes along and says that maybe we could try a different system of logic from Aristotle. It had been tried a little bit before, but not in a major way. This is what Gottlob Frege and George Boole and Bertrand Russell achieved right at the end of the 19th century. It was, "Aristotle works well for this, but then there are other patterns of human thought that we want to be able to, and reasoning that we want to systematize that the Aristotelian system doesn't help with." So his logic hasn't been superseded; it's

still there, it's still the best account of the basic foundations of logic or one logical system that does work extremely well.

- 1.73** And then, with ethics and with politics, again, there's a lot of interest in Aristotle's ethics around questions of character and virtue. That's particularly dominated modern moral philosophy. People like Elizabeth Anscombe and Philippa Foot and Alasdair MacIntyre and Martha Nussbaum, Bernard Williams even, all take Aristotle very seriously.
- 1.74** And then, in politics, Aristotle's ideas do come back again and again. For example, he has a lot of fascinating passages about the nature of equality and inequality and how that's to be understood. It's very relevant to how we debate that question today. Debates around levels of ethnic diversity within the polis and whether that is subversive or whether it can enhance the polis. Questions to do with how you blend different models of ruling. Does it have to be either a monarchy or an oligarchy or a democracy? Are there ways of structuring the three in a way that blends them into a single constitution?
- 1.75** These ideas are very much with us both in, say, Britain, with our parliamentary democracy: we have a monarch, we have, or used to have at least, the aristocracy in the House of Lords, and then we have the demos in the House of Commons. Similarly, in America, you'll have the executive, the presidential role, the monarchic figure. Then, you'll have the congressional side of things, which will be the demos, and then you'll have the Senate, which is, at least I think until the beginning of the 20th century, an unelected body, but was there to represent the aristoi, the oligarchic complement. That idea of fusing those three tiers of society goes right back to Aristotle, really, before Aristotle and with Plato, the thought was you have to choose, you have to pick one of the three.
- 1.76** So we've looked at Aristotle's life, we've looked at the scale of his achievement and the durability of his achievement, and we're now ready to dive into the thought itself. In the next lecture, we'll be considering his contributions, his innovations in logic, his foundation of modern logic, and we'll look also at his philosophy of nature and how he understands the natural world, how he understands things like causation and essence and substance.
- 1.77** For all the reasons you mentioned him not inheriting Plato's Academy, it's surprising that he would be chosen as the tutor by the king. So I'm curious, is there any insights as to how that happened?
- 1.78** I think it would have been, by the 340s, Philip in Macedon is going to be aware that there's one of my people down in the heart of Athens, and he's making a splash. Things would have gotten back to him. Remember that the Macedonians are about to wipe out, they're about to invade, do a full-scale invasion of the whole of Greece south of Macedon, a pretty brutal one. Some of the cities, like Thebes, he razed it to the ground,

enslaved and massacred his way through Greece. This is 10 years before that happens, and this is his father, so this is Philip, not Alexander, but Philip would have been thinking, "I want this person. I've got these big plans, I want somebody who's going to be as well-formed as possible in the life of the mind."

1.79 But probably also, given what we know Alexander is pulling off by the time he's 17, 18, it's astonishing. His ability to manage a battlefield, as well as his physical courage—he'd always be in the front, the first charge every time. And so, again, yeah, I'd love to have been a fly on the wall in those tuition sessions because, do we see Aristotle's fingerprints on the life of Alexander the Great? Not really. All of the ideals that Aristotle holds up are almost the antithesis of—the great irony is, Alexander the Great, I think, every night he slept with a copy of the Iliad under his pillow. The Iliad was his universe, and that's all he thought about, and he wanted to be the next Achilles, but an Achilles who could get the glory and live a long life.

1.80 Of course, he doesn't. He has a lot of glory in him and a short life. He's dead at 34, and it's a great tragedy. We can't look into this period of history as well as we'd like to. But it is this great irony that Aristotle and the whole revolution in human thought that he unleashes which roughly speaking is if you want to understand the world, if there's an earthquake, we don't think of Poseidon like all the Homer junkies do, as it were. That's the wrong way of—and yet it's a very rational world for Aristotle. It's a world that effectively evacuates the Greek universe. It evacuates all of the gods and all of the supernatural explanations. A lot of the myths are now seen and exposed as myths by Aristotle's rationalist revolution, you would have thought.

1.81 Yet, everything we know about Alexander the Great suggests he was reading Homer, not his tutor. Right to the end, he wasn't the calm, moderate, virtuous Athenian gentleman that Aristotle imagines as being the moral exemplar. Quite the reverse. He was a thug. He was an appalling human being, Alexander, in many ways. The massacres, we don't hear about the massacres so much these days, but the wanton cruelty was extraordinary. So one wonders what happened, how Aristotle felt as reports came back to him.

1.82 But it wasn't a problem in the Athenian world because that was a decision that Philip of Macedon would have taken, and he would have said, "Look, you're out of Athens anyway. Rather than just snorkeling in Turkey,"—which seems to be what he was doing, all these fish that he—"why don't you come back and do something useful, like tutor my young warlord son, who needs a little bit of wisdom and counsel, wrestling with all these warlord thoughts in his basement? He keeps jabbering about how he's going to conquer the whole of the known world, and I'm very worried about him. Will you come and help?"

1.83 Talking about raising and being worried about children, I know that you mentioned that we were interested in the mind, and he was reduced to the mind since Plato, right? But I wonder if there's any information about his upbringing that made him so interested in

actually putting in the work and analyzing life and getting answers, because I really I think that we're lacking that in youth right now. I think that it would be—I understand that he was an exceptional mind, but I think the upbringing probably had a lot or some to do with it.

- 1.84** Yes. It's a very good thought, a very good question. I mean, I'm not a historian of Macedon. I don't know enough about the world of Macedon in the first half of the fourth century, the world into which Aristotle was born. But nothing good had come from Macedon before then. It really was just this faraway place, pretty inaccessible. They did their own thing. Occasionally, we needed to steal or borrow or beg some horses from them, but they do their thing. They kind of speak Greek, but it's so barbaric. We can't be seen with them at the Olympic Games.
- 1.85** So I would have thought the pedagogical context, the context of the intellectual formation in Macedon, was probably nothing close to what it was in Athens or in Corinth or in Thebes or any of the big established Greek city-states. I suspect that's why somebody sent him to Athens at 17. Maybe it was him, maybe he took himself there. It's a pretty long trip for a 17-year-old to make, and a pretty dangerous trip because there were wars happening all over Boeotia, all over basically the areas lying between Macedon and Athens.
- 1.86** So my suspicion is that he was plainly a genius, one of the greatest geniuses ever to be able to express his genius. No doubt that was spotted in some way in Macedon. What was the first thing they did? "Get out of Macedon. You need to go down to where the clever people are. You've got to go down to the Ivy League, go to the Ivy League, go to Athens. That's where you'll be happy. They'll sort you out there. They'll work out what to do with you there."
- 1.87** On the other hand, it's worth saying how important pedagogy, education, the formation of the young is to Aristotle in all his work. If you think about it, as we'll see in a subsequent lecture, he starts his work on the *Politics* by just saying, "What kind of beings are we?" Well, we're paired beings. Just for the basic end of bringing new life into the world, we need to be paired. And when new life is in the world, we need a household, we need protection, an *oikos*, and a theory of how to understand how to govern the household, the *oikonomia*.
- 1.88** But the house is vulnerable. We need to join together with other villages for the sake of protecting the children, forming them, educating them. And then, that's not quite enough. For the really solid long-term planning, you need to be in a city, or you need to be in some large, scaled-up community: a city-state or nation and so on. But it starts within the home. It starts with we've got these little people around, we need to protect them, and we need to form them and educate them.
- 1.89** So a lot of what the rhetoric is—when the Middle Ages come along, you have the so-called seven liberal arts, you have the trivium and the quadrivium. The trivium is the

first chunk of your university education in the Middle Ages, and that is Aristotle's logic: grammar, rhetoric, logic, all Aristotle. All Europeans, all educated elite Europeans from roughly 1200, 1250, up to 1500 and beyond in many places, would just do the trivium. Where do we get the word trivial from? "Oh, it's trivial." It means that's from the first part of the undergrad degree. Like sophomoric; it's trivial. It's from the trivium. That's all Aristotle.

1.90 And then, after that, you move on to the quadrivium, which is music, astronomy, geometry, and arithmetic, beg your pardon. So, yes, the quadrivium is music, astronomy, geometry, and arithmetic, and it's to do with how number was understood. That is all also very much based on Aristotle.

1.91 So he had things to say about education and forming the young. But his thought enabled the first universities to develop a whole curriculum around his thought. That, for centuries, is what formed our young, up until, really up until, I guess, the 16th, 17th centuries.

Lecture 2: Aristotle's Logic

At a glance — Aristotle's logic — the syllogism and the foundations of reasoning.

- 2.1 Welcome to Lecture 2 in the series Aristotle: From Logic to Life. In this lecture, we're going to be starting with logic. We're going to be beginning to think about logic. In our first lecture, we met Aristotle, the man, the Macedonian outsider who ended up in Athens, ended up exiling himself twice from Athens, and became one of the greatest systematizers of human knowledge, one of the most penetrating philosophers in the history of ideas.
- 2.2 What we're going to look at now, we're going to look at the foundations and the building blocks for everything that came after, the logic. This is not where most students are encouraged to start, but I think it's where we need to start because it's really with thought that, without thought, nothing else is possible. Without understanding thought, as Aristotle insisted we needed to, we're bound to go wrong when we start thinking about the world and doing philosophy.
- 2.3 So he develops a body of treatises, six altogether, which, taken together, are called the Organon. Organon in Greek simply means a "tool." You might think of it as a toolbox because there are actually six tools in Aristotle's Organon. Logic's a funny area of philosophy. It's both part of philosophy, and yet it isn't part of philosophy. Without it, you can't do any philosophy because it's about how you understand the whole thinking process. But Aristotle understood that it was what you needed. It was a tool. It was a very, very powerful tool for doing philosophy, an instrument.
- 2.4 So he develops this toolbox and applies it to the world, to reality in different ways. But the basic division that he comes up with is between logic, the world of thought and of mind, on the one hand, and, on the other hand, physics, the world of phusis. Phusis in Greek simply means "nature." So, ta physika simply means the things, the stuff to do with nature, nature stuff, "things to do with nature," ta physika. Ta logika, ta physika. You can think of these as the two great halves of Aristotle's cathedral of thought. These are the two great buttresses.
- 2.5 So, what is the Organon exactly? As I said, it's made up of six texts: the Categories, we'll come on to talk about those, the De Interpretatione, which is really to do with language and taxonomy, the Prior Analytics, which is the study of logic that one is engaged in prior to getting up out of the armchair and inspecting the world, a priori reasoning and logic. And then, there's the Posterior Analytics, which is the logic you do after you've got up off your posterior from the armchair and started inspecting the world. So that's really the logic that governs scientific reasoning, scientific inquiry and hypothesis. And then, there's the Topics and the so-called Sophistical Refutations, which are, well, the Topics are quite important, but we won't be discussing those so much.

- 2.6 These are the six works, the six ingredients, the six tools in the toolbox, taken together called the Organon. This would be really the only serious textbook in logic in all those different areas of logic for the next 2,500 years. And really, when you're doing introductions to logic today, you're still working through, in the early stages at least, the logic that Aristotle was laying down.
- 2.7 So, we can start to think about logic as really the laws of thought, that logic is really just the study of human reasoning and human thought, and the different patterns that we follow when we're reasoning about the world or just reasoning about something beyond the world, as we seem to be doing when we're reasoning about mathematics. Plausibly, there are certain laws that can't be laws of nature that are laws of logic, which Aristotle formulates. Bertrand Russell identified three laws of thought. Aristotle argues and articulates two of them and seems to, I think, implies the third.
- 2.8 The first is the principle of non-contradiction, the law of logic that says that X cannot be not X at one and the same time and in one and the same place. The same attribute cannot, as he says, at the same time belong and not belong to the same subject in the same respect. Something that is green all over cannot be red all over. That can't be thought of. Thought breaks down if that's contemplated, like contemplating a square circle.
- 2.9 So Aristotle says that whenever somebody says they think, they believe that, then, they don't actually understand what the words mean. That's his gentle defense of them. Nobody can actually think a square circle. If there's somebody who claims that they do, then they need a dictionary and they need to understand what square means and what circle is, what circle means.
- 2.10 But that's a law of thought. What makes that true? What makes that law true? Well, whatever it is that makes it true, it's not nature, because nature doesn't traffic in truths like that. There is no scientific principle that couldn't possibly be reversed or shown to be not quite true, or shown to be false, or shown to be true only in this possible world. For all we know, there's another possible world in which $E = mc^3$. That's not like thinking of a square circle. Maybe we don't understand all the physics and stuff, but there's nothing—that's just a law that describes this world, this spatio-temporal universe that happened to get lucky, happened to get the Big Bang set off by who or what knows who or what. That's a contingent truth, whereas the law of logic, a law of thought, is one that is just true no matter what.
- 2.11 The second law of thought is the principle of the excluded middle. This is what Aristotle says in the Metaphysics: "There cannot be any intermediate between contradictories. But of one subject we must either affirm or deny any one predicate." What's the idea behind this? Very simply, that truth is binary or bivalent, as philosophers like to say. Being true is a bit like being pregnant. It's either true or it's not. You're either pregnant or you're not. It's bivalent. It's one or the other. There aren't degrees of truth, degrees

of being pregnant, or the moment of becoming pregnant, as it were, is not divisible; it's one or the other.

2.12 The third principle is the principle of identity, which seems silly to have to state, but $A = A$. Just as $X \neq \neg X$, $X = X$. $A = A$. Everything is identical with itself. This becomes a very, very important idea later on. Effectively, you need it to do most logic, in fact. But the ones that Aristotle focuses on are the law of non-contradiction: $X \neq \neg X$ at the same time in the same respect. And the principle of the excluded middle, when we're talking about making a judgment that something is true, then we are saying that all other rival views are false, that it's one or the other, there aren't degrees of it.

2.13 So let's look into Aristotle's toolbox. The first text we would look at is called simply the Categories, *ta kategoreia*. The basic idea, what Aristotle tries to undertake here, is effectively a classificatory table. Think of it like a periodic table, almost, but of all of being, not just the elements, but all of being. Physical being, non-physical being, being itself. He starts with the primary category, which for him is substance—we'll talk more about substance and what philosophers mean by substance quite a lot over the course of the next two or three lectures.

2.14 Substance is the who, is the what. Think of it as the stuff that is independent, that exists in and of itself, and that has ways of being in the world, and the ways of being in the world is what we call properties. So you might say, apple, substance, can exist as an object that we recognize and think about, that grows, that has a process of natural formation that we can understand. That's a substance. And we could say that being red or being tasty or being crunchy are properties, are ways that the apple is in the world, the ways you could characterize it.

2.15 But at the level of metaphysics, there's this big debate as to how does being red hook onto apple, this apple, as a substance? What is it that being red doesn't belong to what it is to be an apple? Is there such a thing as being red—does it just float around? It's not an object; it's a way that an object is in the world. So where does being red come from? Where does being tasty, being crunchy, where do these properties come from, the things that hook onto or characterize substances?

2.16 Plato thinks they're Forms, up there in this heaven far away, up outside the cave of our ignorance. But we can get there eventually if we do enough philosophy and enough tutorials with Socrates. But Aristotle sees properties as wired into the essence of particular things. It's woven into the inner structure of a substance. It's embedded. There are no forms up there. Everything has a form, has its own form, that is wired into it as an object, and that is the reason it is what it is, and it is the reason it is how it is—I'll come on to talk a little bit more about that.

2.17 But the basic idea is that a substantial form, what characterizes the apple as an apple, is that it has an essence, the essence being an apple. That is what fixes the properties

that it ordinarily, that it ought to have, that most instances of that category would have. So that's the substance at the bottom.

- 2.18** And then, there are nine different ways you can understand different properties. Quantity: how many apples. Quality: all kinds of properties could be described about that, how it tastes, how it looks, etc. Relation: how it's related physically and conceptually—physically within a room or in the shop, or conceptually within the family of fruit. How you understand it biologically in that sense, place, time, position, state, action, passion. So all of these different categories, different ways that things can be in the world.
- 2.19** Take the phrase "Socrates is wise." The way Aristotle analyzes this is to say that "Socrates" is the substance, "wise" is the accident or the quality, the property, the kind of way that Socrates is in the world, a way that we can characterize Socrates. That's what "wise" is. And then "is," is just a predication. That's just attributing the being wise to that substance: Socrates, this man, this particular man. So that's the basic setup. That's the logical analysis of a phrase like "Socrates is wise" in terms of the parts, how that language is hooking on to the world, how it's hooking on to reality.
- 2.20** In the Categories, Aristotle draws this distinction. He says that there's two different ways of thinking about substance. There's the primary substance, which is Socrates, that guy right there, this substance, this particular substance. And then, he says there are also secondary substances, which primary substances can exemplify or exhibit. The secondary substance would be, in the case of Socrates, man, animal, living thing, more general categorial ways of understanding Socrates. You can predicate these of primary substances.
- 2.21** So you can't say, you can't predicate one primary substance for another primary substance. You can't say that Plato is Socrates or that Plato is being Socrates or has the property of Socrates. The two are completely distinct as primary substances. They're the most real fundamental things. But you could say that Socrates is the tutor of Plato. So you can, as it were, put a relational property between two substances, but you can't identify one primary substance with another primary substance.
- 2.22** This helps us to think about what things are in the world. So Aristotle says, you can ask a question of that strange creature in the corner. We can say, "What is that?" Well, it's a living animal. "What kind of living animal?", and so on and so forth. Nobody had really thought in this way before. And Aristotle says that we can do this for everything, everything in nature, but also everything in the world beyond nature, the world of thought, and of the abstract as well. So really, this metaphysics of substance is really the foundation of understanding the nature of being, the nature of what it is for anything to be.
- 2.23** A little bit more on the logic and how it works, and what he's trying to do by developing this toolbox. I think the first thing to say is what makes this so revolutionary, and I've

alluded to this before, is that it's the first attempt to formalize reasoning in human history. As I said, people obviously reasoned before Aristotle was around, but nobody had worked out a systematic account of how reasoning works and exactly what it is.

- 2.24** Plato's dialogues demonstrate extraordinary reasoning, absolutely, really brilliant insights and penetrating, enduring insights. But at no point in any of the dialogues is any attempt made to advance a set of rules about how we think, how we organize an argument, how we evaluate what counts as a good argument and a bad one. That's partly the context, partly Plato's decision, the genre, Plato's decision to write always in dialogue form. It just doesn't lend itself to the treatise-style approaches that we have in Aristotle's remaining work.
- 2.25** So what he does with the toolbox is he makes reasoning an object of study, a subject, if you like. He identifies the structures that make arguments work and that make them go wrong, and he creates basically a notation, a terminology that lasts two millennia. The building block to Aristotle's logic is what's called in Greek, syllogismos, which literally means "reasoning together," syllogismos. It's reasoning together because what syllogism is—in English, it's syllogism, S-Y-double-L-O-G-I-S-M—is a pulling together of different premises, different claims. What it is, as he defines it, is a form of speech, a discourse, in which certain things are stated, and when certain other things are stated, something else than what is stated follows of necessity. This is his definition. So let's break it down.
- 2.26** Logic, a syllogism is a form of speech, which, when certain things are stated—so certain things being stated, we would call those the premises of an argument; certain things are stated. Those are the premises that have to be defended. And then, out of that comes a conclusion that something other than what is stated. So it's not just a repetition of the premises; something new pops out of putting these premises together. This is the idea. And he says, interestingly, follows of necessity, must follow, must pop out in the way that it does. This is what's interesting.
- 2.27** You put two premises, two beliefs together: Paul likes red apples, and Paul is in a room with a red apple; therefore, plausibly, Paul is going to eat the apple. That plausibility argument is basically you put two premises together, and out pops a conclusion: it is plausible that. It is certain that it is plausible that. Paul will eat an apple.
- 2.28** The famous one, the one that Aristotle likes to rely on, is: "All men are mortal. Socrates is a man. Therefore, Socrates is mortal." So two premises. All men are mortal, premise one. Premise two, Socrates is a man. Those are the two pieces of the two premises coming together. Out of that flows of necessity, there is no possible world in which Socrates fails to be mortal. If it is the case that all men are mortal, and it is the case that Socrates is a man, then it follows of necessity that Socrates is mortal.
- 2.29** It follows necessarily. It's not up to nature. It's not something that we have to do some experiments on, or we can rely on Socrates coming to an end, dying one day. It's very

likely he's going to die one day. No, it's definite. If he belongs to this category, then this is a property that attaches to him of necessity. So that classic Socrates syllogism, here we have what's the different ways to analyze it.

- 2.30** What Aristotle helps us to think about when we're thinking about logic is two distinct criteria that an argument has to satisfy if it's going to be a good argument. The first is the soundness of the argument. The soundness of the argument relates to how well you can defend the premises of the argument. So all men are mortal. Socrates is a man.
- 2.31** You might say, "No, this conclusion does not pop out necessarily from the premises because I've met some men, it seems that there are some men who just won't die who live forever," or, "Socrates is claiming to be a man, but actually he isn't." It's an early example of gender dysphoria in fifth-century Athens, and he's just pretending. If you could defend those premises or you could attack the premises successfully in that way, then you've undermined the soundness of an argument. The argument is not sound. That's to do with the content of the premises.
- 2.32** The second way of thinking about an argument—and a good argument has to satisfy this criterion too—Is it valid? That is to say, we don't care about what the premises are. It doesn't matter for now. Let's leave that to the soundness team. But the validity team, what we're worried about is, if all these are true, and supposing all these are defended, does the logic work? Just does the logic work? All X are Y. Z is X. Therefore, Z is Y. We don't really care what the X's and Y's are. It's just, can we see the logic running through that? Whatever x is, whatever Y is, if Z is that, then Z is that; it follows. $Z = X$, $Z = Y$, because $X = Y$. And that's all you need to know. That's the validity.
- 2.33** An argument has to be both sound and valid. So, the logic's got to work, and the premises that are being fed into the conclusion have to be defensible, more probable than not. With logic, it's either false or it's not. An argument is either valid or it's invalid, because logic is like that. It's on or off, 1 or 0. It's right, or it's wrong.
- 2.34** On soundness, you can see there's going to be a hole, that's where the dispute's going to be. The disputes will tend to be around defending the premises. Particularly in public policy, you're dealing with statistics, you're dealing with past cases and trying to bring all that to bear. And so, obviously, with an argument that is claimed to be sound, that is going to almost always be a matter of dispute, and there'll be degrees of soundness in a way that there can't be degrees of validity.
- 2.35** Okay, we're getting through this quickly. It is the most important and probably least sort of stimulating area of philosophy: logic. This is why the poor logicians, they're always claiming, "Please, you philosophers need to study more logic, everybody needs to study more logic, and it's not our fault, it can be a little bit dull." But I don't think it is. It's what enables all philosophy, all thought to be possible, all philosophy to be possible.

- 2.36 So this was the system of logic that lasted all the way up to the 19th century, pretty much, We have a transformation in Aristotle's toolbox from the Prior Analytics, which discusses how syllogisms work, to Posterior Analytics, and this was his work of logic, which looks at what you do when you're not just doing reasoning, when you're inspecting the world, when you're trying to acquire scientific knowledge of the world.
- 2.37 Here, his focus is seeking what he calls an aitia, A-I-T-I-A, an aitia. The aitia is, in many of the standard 20th-century translations, that word's been translated as cause. And I think that's unfortunate, because aitia means something a lot more than cause. It includes cause, but first of all, it includes cause in a very different way from how we understand the concept of cause, at least as we've understood it over the last 400 years.
- 2.38 And secondly, because it also covers plausibly non-causal criteria. It also means explanation. Aitia really means explanation. And yes, for many scientists, every scientific explanation is a causal explanation. It's how X happened to Y and what happened. That's the nature of scientific analysis, you might say in some ways. But really, Aristotle is interested in causation, in the why, how we answer the question why. We need to know it's the right cause and we've got to be able to achieve a demonstration. Those requirements that are fed into the premises of a scientific argument, they've got to be immediate, they've got to be demonstrable.
- 2.39 And there may be certain principles, Aristotle says, that are just axiomatic, where you just turn your spade, principles that you can't justify by reference to other principles. These are just axioms of science. You might say that the principle of non-contradiction, the principle that X can't be not X at one and the same time in the same way at the same place. You might say that that is an axiom of thought, that is just something you can't prove, it is what it is. It's like asking why is $2 + 2 = 4$. It's seeking an explanation that doesn't need to be given, it's transparent.
- 2.40 So he maps out the whole of the logic involved in inquiring into the world and trying to come up with adequate explanations of the world. One question that always looms when it comes to scientific inquiry is that eventually you realize that you keep asking the question "why," but you're turning into the five-year-old child who's always asking, why, why, why, why, why? What worries Aristotle about this is: Does the five-year-old child suggest that the regress of explanations, the regress of whys, the ever deeper questions as to why, why, why, whether that ever comes to an end? Is it infinite? Does the demand for explanations just stretch back infinitely far?
- 2.41 Now, Aristotle thought that time stretched back infinitely far. So he thought the universe— and the rest of us did, the rest of the West thought that until the 1960s. Such was Aristotle's influence. So the Big Bang was revolutionary. Why in the mid-1960s? Because it was overturning Aristotle. For the first time ever, first time since the fourth century BC, the science seemed to be tilting towards the conclusion that

Aristotle was wrong. The universe began to exist; there was some moment, some impulse.

- 2.42 So there was infinite regresses that he was happy to deal with. So the idea that space and time go infinitely far back into the past. But when it comes to logic, infinite regresses are even more worrying. You've got an endless chain of demonstrations, like you never turn your spade when you're digging a hole, you just keep digging and digging and digging, searching for some foundation. Aristotle rejects that. He says, you can't keep writing checks saying, "I will give you the full explanation tomorrow." And then, tomorrow, you write another check saying, "This is a check. My promise to you is that I'll give you the full explanation next week," and so on and so forth. The metaphysical buck has got to stop somewhere. It's got to be a point where we can begin from.
- 2.43 The other alternative, in terms of justification, is you can, instead of trying to justify A by turning to B, by turning to C, by turning to D, and E and so on, infinitely far back, maybe we could think of A is justified by B, and C is justified by D, and D is justified by A. So what we've got is, rather than trying to dig a hole deep down at the ground, we've got this web of beliefs that support each other, even if we're not quite clear what the web is, whether the web is grounded in reality.
- 2.44 This is in modern philosophy called coherentism. The idea is that you fit the beliefs into your existing web of beliefs, and the ones that don't fit easily into the web are the ones you call false. And the ones that do fit easily into the web are the ones you call true. This comes from a worry, how could beliefs be grounded in the world? Beliefs emerge from processes of reasoning and of logic, not processes of physics and chemistry and stuff and laws of nature. It's a different thing. So how could the two be related to each other?
- 2.45 The coherentist says that they don't have to be related too much. We can have this web of beliefs, and if it enables us to cope with the world, then it doesn't really matter what the world really is. We just have this very cool matrix. We've got this great blueprint. That's good enough; it works for us. Stop asking awkward questions. That's the circular demonstration, that's the coherentist view. There's infinitism and then coherentism.
- 2.46 And Aristotle rejects both. He says the solution is for him that there are certain first principles that are self-evident, that you can grasp as true immediately, directly. You don't need to worry about—they don't need deeper foundation. One of Aquinas' arguments, candidates for this kind of axiom in moral philosophy is, "The good ought to be done and evil ought to be avoided." "Bonum prosequendum [est], et malum vitandum." The good is something to be pursued, and evil is something to be avoided.
- 2.47 You might think, that sounds so basic. Of course. But no, this was actually— this is yes, it is obvious, but it's obvious in a very interesting way. It's obvious in that that sentence

doesn't rely on any other principle beyond mere dictionary meanings of the words. It just seems to be a first principle. The good is something to be pursued. What you do with somebody who says it's not, you say, "You haven't understood the nature of good, and you haven't understood the nature of evil. Your desires are overwhelming your reasoning," and so on. So, they're not arbitrary, and they're apprehended by the mind, not by stuff, by mind.

- 2.48** So, a first principle might be a moral one, as we've just seen, or it might be a mathematical, a geometric one. "Triangles are three-sided plane figures"—that's a trivial first principle. It's true because it correctly defines most of the essence of a triangle. "A human is a rational animal"—that's something that's not demonstrated. We'd have to do that by meeting some human beings, and so on and so forth.
- 2.49** Some of these first principles could be hypothetical. So it may be that we're not actually sure for now whether they're true, but they're very useful to posit; they're hypothetical axioms, hypothetical posits. "Numbers exist," for example, "mathematics exists"—there's no way we could prove that through science because that's claiming that there's a world beyond science. There's non-scientific truths, there's non-scientific domain. But it's a very reasonable first principle for scientists to use when they're exploring the world and trying to understand more about it.
- 2.50** So we can start to think now about the way Aristotle's logical universe fits together. At the bottom level, you've got facts, facts about the world derived from individual observations or from a priori reasoning. Then, you've got the middle level, which is all the principles that you can demonstrate from analyzing the facts, and also from analyzing and applying first principles, and using the syllogism, using reasoning and argumentation to support your point. That builds up a body of episteme, a body of knowledge, scientific knowledge. And at the top level of Aristotle's logical universe, you've got the first principles, the archai, A-R-C-H-A-I, and these are the definitions and the axioms, the hypotheses, and they're not arbitrary, but you can't actually demonstrate them, you can't prove them.
- 2.51** So why is this so important, just drawing to a close on the part of the lecture focusing on logic? Why is it important? Well, as I said at the beginning, it's the first time anybody had tried to put together how human beings reason and think. No one had done that before. It's Aristotle's tool for building up an organized and systematic body of knowledge in many, many other areas. It helps not just with grasping the aitia explanations, but it helps us in pursuing the explanations to develop an understanding of the world. And it enables us also to predict why certain things are going to happen in the world and to explain why they're going to happen.
- 2.52** And so this sets the stage for his turning with a toolbox, as it were, the toolbox in hand, to go off into nature, into the natural world, and to explore it and to understand it. The main focus here is, the main text to focus on for this is his Physics, ta Physika, his work, his treatise is simply called the Physics.

- 2.53** That work opens with a question: What makes something natural? What is it that makes something part of nature? And by contrast, what sets something apart as an artifact, as artificial? Artificial in Latin simply means "making art" or "making skill," something that's been produced by a work of skill, human skill, human ingenuity. So, a tree is not a table. A river is not a canal. We think there's a strong intuitive distinction between what's natural and what's artificial. So what is it at the philosophical level? What is it that sets them apart?
- 2.54** Aristotle's insight, or his claim, is that what makes a tree different from a table and a river different from a canal is that the tree and the river have natural intrinsic internal principles of change, a set of internal explanatory principles that account for the look of the tree, the behavior of the tree, the location of the tree. Everything that we want to be able to say about the tree is by reference to the fact that it is a tree, the essence of a tree, and it exhibits the particular properties of its own species.
- 2.55** Whereas a table will also be an object. It's a substance. But it's an artifact. It's not part of nature because its principles of structure and explanation are imposed on it from without, from the outside, from some other—from the furniture maker who's got an idea of what the table is going to look like and so on and so forth. So that's an artifact. We can say that the table is made up of natural substances, but as an object, the table is an artifact; it's not a natural thing.
- 2.56** This becomes a very important distinction to make, particularly when we are looking at debates, all kinds of different debates, but certainly around technology and AI—and we'll come on to how Aristotle applies this idea to human beings as being natural rather than artificial things. But if you think of artificial intelligence, where we're trying to make robots resemble human beings, or transhumanism and neuroenhancement, where it seems we're trying to make human beings into robots, the questions of what's natural and what's artifactual become much more, become philosophically salient and urgent.
- 2.57** Think of debates in the late 90s, the big cultural debates in the late 90s and early 00s over intelligent design, the theory of intelligent design in Christian apologetics and among some Christian philosophers and philosophers of science. The debate there turns on whether or not there's clear evidence for species, and the example they pick is something called a bacterial flagellum. The argument is that the mechanism for this bacteria to work is somehow grafted onto it by divine handiwork, by intelligent design, and it's imposed upon it, as it were, scripted into it.
- 2.58** That's a very new way of understanding biological function in the context of a theological framework, a theistic framework. This is not at all how Aristotle thinks, it's not at all how Aquinas thinks, it's not at all how most Christian theologians think up until the 17th century. Because the bacterium on the Aristotelian view has not had God swing in and instill a bit of design, impose a bit of design. It is a natural thing, and all natural things for Aristotle emerge from a certain internal organizational hierarchy and

architecture, structure, which is there in virtue of the kinds of things that they are. God is at work much further upstream if there is God at all. He's not swooping in to correct His mistakes, which is the sort of caricatured picture of the intelligent design movement.

2.59 So there's a very interesting debate in both philosophy of biology but also philosophy of religion as to how to understand this distinction. And Aristotle moves on in Book II of the Physics to say that we do not think we know a thing until we have grasped its "why," until we have grasped its *aitia*. Earlier, I said that *aitia* is best translated as explanation rather than cause. But you could also say, even better, you could translate it as a "why." An *aitia* is a why.

2.60 Aristotle says, when we're trying to answer the question "why," completely and comprehensively of any particular thing, there are at least four non-competing, independently necessary and jointly sufficient to understand what a thing is, what an X is, four dimensions, four angles. It's easier to use the example of an artifact if we just take a bronze statue, which is the standard example. In the modern world, we've got a single scientific explanation as to what that statue is, how it's come about, all of it in terms of material, physical, and efficacious processes that we understand in terms of a very reduced conception of good old cause and effect.

2.61 Aristotle thinks that that's only one of the four ways we need to understand something. We need to understand, have a full explanation of why something is what it is, why something has happened in the way that it's happened. First of all, we've got to understand the material explanation, the material cause, the material why. In the case of the statue, it's bronze. That's the matter, that's the stuff, that's the *hylē*. He says that you can't miss out the stuff that something's made of in your explanation. There's got to be a material cause. The bronze statue is bronze. For a house, it's bricks and mortar and so on. Human beings: flesh and bone, the underlying stuff that persists through change.

2.62 And then, Aristotle says, but that's not enough either, because if it was just the bronze, it would just be a lump of bronze, and it wouldn't be a statue, wouldn't be what it is. And so we have to explain why it has the form that it does, why it has the shape that it does, why it's arranged in the way that it is. And this, says Aristotle, is a different kind of cause. It's a formal cause. It's the cause that explains the form, the shape that it has in the world. For that, we're going to have to go and ask the guy who designed it, the guy who made it. Maybe he's got a blueprint, little sketch in his workshop, or he could do a sketch for us so he could explain what he had in mind and why he designed it that way, or why he chose that figure, and so on. So the form is what makes the matter into a specific thing.

2.63 Then, says Aristotle, yes, we do also need your modern version of understanding of what cause is, the only way of understanding what cause is, which is efficient causation. So how did that lump of bronze and what was the process by which the lump of bronze

and the blueprint in the mind of the statue maker, as it were, forged themselves together into a statue? What's the process? What's going on in the factory? What's going on with the hammers and the molten bronze that they would have put into the different shapes and so on? That's efficient causation, the efficient explanation, you might say, pure scientific explanation. So, those are the first three causes, the first three "why's."

- 2.64** And the fourth one, which modern science also misses out, but is, for Aristotle, the most important of all, is the biggest why of them all, which is: Why, ultimately, is this bronze statue here? What is its purpose? What's the goal? What's the ultimate point of this? And for that, Aristotle argues, every natural thing has its own purpose, which is determined by its own internal principles of organization, and every artifact will have some goal or direction or purposiveness laid onto it by somebody else or something else.
- 2.65** So the table is turned into a table. We can explain it in terms of the wood. We can explain it in terms of the design of the table. We can explain it in terms of the table factory, which the table came out of. But this final explanation, why is there this table here at all, we might explain it in terms of the guy making tables because he wants to make a good business, he wants to put money on the table. There might be personal reasons and personal explanations which for Aristotle are valid in the artificial world, but you can also ask them of nature. What is it for?
- 2.66** A classic example: an acorn. What is it for? Well, it's going to become an oak tree. That's its internal principle of design is to becoming an oak tree. That it's part of the explanation you've got to give for the acorn and why it's there or indeed of the oak tree when it's there. What's its purpose? Where is it headed? What's its direction? These are the four causes or four kinds of explanation that have to be held together as one.
- 2.67** Aristotle lays on to this very interesting explanation of what change actually is when you analyze it. What is change? And the theory that he comes up with is this distinction between something that exists in possibility or in potentiality, and something that actually exists actually. He says that all change is effectively a transition from potency to act, from what could be into what is. Potentiality is *dunamis*, or "capacity" or power, where we get our word dynamic from. And actuality is *energeia*, or *entelecheia*—*energeia*, literally "to be filled with energy," "work," *ergon*; energy is work, activity within. Or *entelecheia*: "purposefulness from within," directionality, purpose, momentum, fulfillment, realization, activity.
- 2.68** So, you can imagine, you're a student. There's potentially learn it, then actually learns—something other than him makes him actually learn, maybe a teacher, a school, parents, whatever it might be—and then, there's that actuating principle that turns the potency for being learned into an actuality, and so that the student undergoes change, and so on and so forth. Motion, similarly, he thinks of motion as the actualization of potential.

- 2.69** So he builds up this whole conceptual framework through which to understand modern science, which was the understanding of science up until early modern science, I should say. The theory that he comes up with as to how to analyze any natural thing, including the human person, is as a fusion of matter and form. That's how to understand what something is. There will be other explanations too. How did it get here?—the efficient causation. And then, the final cause: What is its essence? What is it for? And that will be determined by the form of a thing, just as the directedness towards an oak tree is part of the essence or form of what it is to be an acorn.
- 2.70** So we've covered an awful lot in this lecture, and well done if you're keeping up, because we've gone through two very complex areas of philosophy. I think things do get a bit easier from here, I think. But these are the cornerstones. These are the engine rooms of Aristotle's thought. If we haven't got a good sense of them, then it's going to be very hard for everything else to fall into place, and this is why I took the decision, especially with logic, to make sure that we start with that, that we understand that clearly in a way that very few other courses dare to do. So, logic is what gives us the toolbox, the ability to reason correctly, to move from what we do know to what we can maybe only infer, the syllogism, or remember the laws of thought and how to make sense of those, how to map them out.
- 2.71** And then, with the shift to nature, we looked at how reasoning about the natural world and particularly science and scientific demonstration, applies these logical tools to understanding the world around us. We've got this comprehensive system that Aristotle offers us in the Categories and then again in the Physics with that very full-blooded, granular conception of what explanation consists in philosophy. So what's happening is we're seeing the emergence, really for the first time in the history of human thought, of a complete, comprehensive, and integrated and coordinated vision of nature and of the human place within nature and of thought and of reasoning itself.
- 2.72** And this is only the beginning. We'll see that this spools out into many, many other different areas, in particular, metaphysics itself, that is to say, the study of being as being, is how Aristotle defines it. We'll turn to that in our next lecture.
- 2.73** I've been trying to break down this question, as it goes down into human development with the laws of thought. When we're born, we're unable to articulate our thoughts. A newborn can't tell you what they're thinking. So, is there a certain age where we say logic is formed, or is there a universally accepted first logical thought that most humans would have?
- 2.74** That's a great question. There's a lot of debate in the 20th century between Philosophers led by Chomsky, Noam Chomsky—I think he's still alive. Chomsky argued that human beings are born with a universal shared grammar, that there's almost like a shared linguistic frame that every human being is born with. Logic may be like that, too. So the question is, maybe the way to think about it is— for Aristotle, a child has the essence of being a human. It just so happens that the child is at a particular temporal

point in what it is to be a human being. And so, just as you could say of the acorn that it has all the powers and capacities to be an oak tree, but it's not actually an oak tree, so you could say of the five-year-old, that five-year-old is a human being, it has all the capacities, all the internal organization for it to be normal, totally normal, or predictable and expected, that this organism is going to be able to do logic, is going to be able to reason logically.

2.75 Now, there may be all kinds of things that disrupt that process. I'd have thought logic is just so basic that you work it out for yourself; it's not really something that you're taught. Now, what we're looking at is logic in terms of: How do we make sense of reasoning? What form does reasoning take? But most people just reason, and children reason from a very early age. They don't need to be taught to reason. They're not going to probably naturally learn to do thought about thought. So teaching logic to a child is quite difficult; even though they're logical beings, they act in very logical ways.

2.76 So it does seem to be part of what it is to be human that we have a capacity for reasoning. This is something Aristotle—we'll see in a future lecture—that's how he defines what it is to be human. We are the only animals that have a capacity for logic, have a capacity for rationality. It may be that that's impeded in some way, but that doesn't affect what it is to be human. It doesn't affect what a normal instance of a human being is.

2.77 You might say it's also an essential property that all human beings have 32 teeth. What we mean by that is that a normal instance of a human being is going to have 32 teeth. If you lose a tooth, does that mean you cease to be human? No, it doesn't. It means you are defective to the tune of one tooth with respect to this satisfying, this essential property of what it is to be human. Similarly, Aristotle thinks it's the same with logic, the same with understanding, that it is an essential property of what it is to be human. It doesn't mean you can't lose it, or you can fail to nurture and cultivate it, but it's there.

Lecture 3: Aristotle's Metaphysics

At a glance — Aristotle's metaphysics — substance, form, and the study of being.

- 3.1** Welcome to Lecture 3 in Aristotle: From Logic to Life. In the first lecture, we looked at a little bit about the background of Aristotle's own context, his own life, and the scale of his achievement. In the previous lecture, Lecture 2, we covered an awful lot of material. We covered his logic, the Organon: the six tools that make up that toolbox. And then, we turned to consider his philosophy of nature, his understanding of causation, of explanation, of motion, of change.
- 3.2** And so equipped with these two approaches—the logical and the scientific, you might say, the life of the mind and the life of nature— together with these, as it were, these two engine rooms, we can move up towards considering metaphysics itself, all the way up to the top of the mountain, what Aristotle calls First Philosophy: Metaphysics. As I said in the first lecture, it's called the Metaphysics simply because it was the book that they thought they would put in the library after the Physics. Ta meta ta physika, means the stuff after the physics.
- 3.3** But it also means meta in our sense of it being connected to how we understand the physical world, but also in a way that's meta, that transcends it, because the question that metaphysics asks is not so much: What is this? What is that? How is it that we can think like that? What's a justification for reasoning like that? The question that metaphysics asks is: Why anything? Why not just nothing? Why anything? Why this rather than that? What does it mean for anything to exist? Why does anything exist? What is being? Being itself, what is it to exist? Is there such a thing as non-existence, a state of non-existence? But a state of non-existence would be a state with certain properties. Can we even think of nothing? Can we even conceive of it?
- 3.4** These are the questions of metaphysics that are much, much more speculative much harder to, as it were, shape into conclusions than with scientific inquiry or indeed with logical or mathematical inquiry. Because those forms of inquiry do at least yield truths. They yield truths that can be demonstrated, beliefs that can be true and that can be known, especially in the case of logic and mathematics, where the truths seem to be necessary to be true no matter what. But also to some extent with scientific inquiry, because there we can reach premises, scientific conclusions that if not necessarily true, true in the way that $2 + 2 = 4$ is true; nevertheless, we can assign a credence to it, we can assign a level of probability to it that it's being true and so on and so forth.
- 3.5** With metaphysics, we're on a much higher ground, and it's much, much harder to make sense of what a good metaphysical theory might look like, let alone how we might go on to show that a particular metaphysical theory was true. But Aristotle, as with so many divisions in human thought, is the first to develop a treatise specifically on

metaphysics, even though many of Plato's dialogues are shot through with metaphysical questions. It's always done in this dialogue form.

- 3.6** We don't even know if it's Plato because Plato doesn't appear in any of his dialogues—well, he's present in two of the dialogues, I think, the *Apology* and the *Phaedo*, so two of the last days of Socrates's dialogues. But he doesn't say anything in either of the dialogues. He doesn't describe himself as saying—he refers to himself as being present in the third person, but there is no character, Plato, in any of Plato's dialogues. So we've got this conundrum, this interpretative hermeneutic conundrum. What did Plato think? What did he believe?
- 3.7** You might say he believed whatever Socrates, the character Socrates, was saying. That's probably what he believed. But we're pretty sure that he believed everything that Socrates is reported as believing in the dialogues, because sometimes Socrates signs up to different things. In the *Parmenides*, a later dialogue, Socrates loses. He loses the argument. In fact, towards the end of the dialogues, the figure of the character of Socrates recedes more and more, and it's very difficult to pin Plato down. What did he really think? We've got a good sense of what he thought, but all of it's refracted through this dramatic genre, this context of the writing of a dialogue, of a conversation.
- 3.8** Whereas Aristotle is much—in a way, with Plato, we've got this highly polished philosophical genre, that is to say, a philosopher not writing directly about his own thoughts, but just describing philosophical conversations among friends. And then, that's polished down into what might have been a historical conversation. We do think that Plato's early dialogues probably were records, roughly speaking, of actual his conversations, which happened, into the more formal, elevated stylized dialogues of Plato's later period. But everything's very, very polished, very sophisticated, very, very well-structured.
- 3.9** And with poor old Aristotle, what we've got is the raw mess of his students' lecture notes, which are pretty good lecture notes as they go. They certainly transformed Western thought. So good note takers, but it was note-taking. We've not got any real examples of Aristotle's prose, of Aristotle in full flight in the way that we only do with Plato. And so, the few quotes that you would have heard from me so far have that slight bland directness in a way that's almost never true of Plato.
- 3.10** He starts his work, the *Metaphysics*, by thinking about the question of being as being. And he says, is there a science that can investigate this question, just being as being, what it is to exist. And Aristotle says, yes, this is the first philosophy. *Metaphysics* is the first philosophy. It's a universal science because it studies everything that exists. It studies the question of: Why does anything exist at all? It's the first philosophy because it comes upstream of physics, which studies natural beings, or mathematics, which studies quantities, psychology, that studies mind, and so on and so forth.

- 3.11** So it's a first philosophy. Being, he says, can be said in many ways. Different things can be said to exist in different ways, and everything comes back to this question of substance. Everything is to do with this question of primary substance, this particular thing, individual things: this man, this horse, this statue.
- 3.12** In the Metaphysics, he seems to develop his idea of what a substance is beyond what we find in the Categories, but it is still absolutely primary. To be a substance—a substance is any entity that can exist basically independently or separably. It's a definite individual; it's a this. You can attribute things to it. X is green, X is an animal, whatever it might be. Those are the building blocks in the Metaphysics. He says that there are substances. Substances are made up of form and matter—remember hylomorphism from our discussion of philosophy of nature in the second half of the previous lecture. And the form is—we've discussed it already when we were talking about formal causation—it's the essence of a thing. It's what makes a thing what it is. It's that in virtue of which any X is an X because it has that form, that essence, that substantial form.
- 3.13** To define X is simply to define the form that it's got. Is a form something that is universal, or is it something that belongs to this particular thing? If I look at an apple and I say that it's roughly spherical, that apple is roughly spherical, I want to say that it's spherical. Part of the explanation as to why it's spherical is that that object has within it, inscribed within it, the form of being an apple, an apple essence, if you like. That's why that particular object is spherical.
- 3.14** But separately, we also think of being an apple as a universal application. So anything that satisfies that plus a number of other criteria is automatically an apple, is definitionally an apple. So there's this tension between the particular and the universal. How can one particular thing carry within it something that is completely universal? There's a tension here.
- 3.15** Aristotle says what individuates a particular substance, that particular substance, that particular apple, is the particular matter that it's made up of. It's that lump of stuff that it's made up of, not that lump of stuff. So even if there's a universal form that lots of different things can exemplify, lots of apples everywhere, multiply instantiating or containing within it the form of being an apple, what makes that apple, that apple, and not any other apple, is that it's made up of that stuff, that particular stuff, with those spatial and temporal locations. That's what individuates the apple; it makes it an individual, not just a universal form.
- 3.16** The point here is that the relationship between form and matter is, for Aristotle, so intertwined that he gets away from the problems that he thinks that Plato has of having this soul caught in this meat cage—trying to get out, never really that comfortable; the body is basically not exactly accidental, but just not, should we say, material to Plato's philosophical vision. What matters is the soul and its embodiment,

and the way in which it's woven into nature is much less interesting, much less of an interesting or urgent philosophical problem for Plato.

3.17 So he's very happy with this two-tiered ontology, this two-tiered metaphysics of the world of the cave, cave light, and the world of sunlight outside. That is to say, the world of concrete, scientifically observable nature, but that we're always making mistakes on, because nature's fickle, it's always changing. And then, the world of the abstract sunlight, which is the world of mathematics, of pure logic, of truths that are true no matter what, truths that are eternally true.

3.18 Now, Aristotle collapses that down, you might say. He affirms both of Plato's intuitions. He affirms both of the tiers: cave light and sunlight. But he collapses them into one. He brings the world of the Forms down into the world of matter. He brings the sunlight down into the cave to dispel the cave light, if you like, and by fixing Form and matter together in the hylomorphic conception of natural things, natural objects.

3.19 Towards the end of the Metaphysics, particularly in Book XII of the Metaphysics, he turns to the question of: What is it that makes the world as a whole work, function? What is it that makes it turn? It can't turn itself. So how do we make sense of it? If we can say of any principle of change or causation in the world, "Okay, we analyze it as you want us to analyze it, Aristotle." So we've got something that's potential, that there's an actualizing principle that turns the potential thing into the actual thing. The acorn into the oak tree, the child into a man.

3.20 But we can then ask ourselves: What brought the actuating principle from potency into act? You've got to explain that. It's one thing to explain how the child becomes a man or the acorn becomes an oak tree, but then you've got to explain the actualizing principle that brings that about; you've got to explain that. Presumably, the actualizing principle is an output of some prior potentiality, something that just possibly existed, was brought into being, and then it became the actuating principle for the acorn and the oak tree. So what's the explanation of that? Well, then another explanation is given, and so on and so forth, the causal nexus of events that led to the acorn being sown and watered and put in the right place and so on and so forth.

3.21 But you can see quite quickly how we could be off on an infinite regress of explanations. We want to explain that actualizing principle, "That was brought into being this way." Well, okay, what brought that into being? Very soon, you can see you're off to the races, as it were. It's this infinite regress of explanations as we go all the way back.

3.22 And Aristotle says that's got to stop. That chain has to stop at some point. In other words, there must be something which actuates potency into act, into actuality—what is possible into what is real—that is not itself where the metaphysical buck really stops. There has to be something that is self-actualizing, that actualizes without itself being actualized, something in which there is no shadow of potency, you might say, no

shadow of possibility, something that is pure act, pure *energeia*, "fully realized," complete. There's nothing it could become that it isn't already.

- 3.23** So for Aristotle, there must be such a thing. There must be something that moves the world, that moves the world from possibility into actuality, from possibility into reality, that is not itself actualized or caused or moved. There must, in other words, be a *kinēton akinēton*, "a mover that is unmoved," a mover that is the source of all originating actuality with no shadow of potentiality. Aristotle says that this can't be a material thing, because a material thing is, by definition, something that is in a state of potency and could be molded and changed into anything else.
- 3.24** So it must be something that's pure form, says Aristotle. It can't become anything else. It is just, it is what it is. Bronze could become a statue. A bronze statue could be melted down, turned into a shield, et cetera, et cetera, et cetera. That's material things. You can do that with material things. Aristotle's answer is that this actuating principle at the beginning of everything is not itself material. It's a form, but it's not material.
- 3.25** You could think of it as, really, the fact that there's pure form at the top, at the peak of the summit of Aristotle's universe. You could see that you can contrast that because at the bottom of his universe, you've just got pure matter, unformed matter, matter with no form at all. It's just pure stuff, pure potentiality, you might say. And then, at the top is pure actuality. Aristotle says it must be immaterial. It must exist necessarily. It must exist no matter what because it is actual, it's fully actual. There was no possibility of its not being actual. It has to exist no matter what. It's a principle. It's never in a state of possibility, this actuating principle.
- 3.26** The unmoved mover is never in a state of possibility, and therefore, it is necessary that it exists. It is necessary that it exists. It was never merely possible. It's not possible for it to have come into existence and not possible for it to ever go out of existence. Not possible for it to change in any way. There is no potency in it at all, in this being. So, what does this thing do? It must be very boring being this thing. This unmoved mover, this form floating at the top of Aristotle's universe, forever, necessarily.
- 3.27** Aristotle's answer is a very interesting one. In many ways, it's a very platonic answer. We've already got to quite a platonic picture here of immaterial, it's pure form, it's necessary, it's unchanging. This is the way Plato seems to put things. You can tell he's inherited his master's impulses in a lot of respects. So what does the unmoved mover do? Aristotle's answer is: he thinks. He contemplates. What does he contemplate? Himself. He contemplates himself.
- 3.28** Oh, well, you'd have thought, maybe there'd be something a little bit more interesting than that, but Aristotle's view is that, no, no, anything inferior to himself is less worthy of contemplating than himself. He can only contemplate himself because he is the most — the unmoved mover is the highest principle and the most perfect fulfilled principle in all of reality. So why would his attention be drawn to anything else, anything else,

which by definition will have within it some kind of potency, will be inferior in at least one crucial respect to the unmoved mover, namely being possibly something else, being mutable, being capable of being changed into something else.

- 3.29** Perfect being just thinks about what's perfect. If there's any one perfect thing, then that's all the perfect being is going to contemplate. We've got a cosmic narcissist who sits up there eternally contemplating his navel, eternal navel gazing. No awareness of particulars, no awareness of the cosmos, just eternally, timelessly absorbed in his own perfection. This is the highest form of existence for Aristotle.
- 3.30** That thinking, thought thinking itself, or in the Greek *noûs*, *noēsis*, *noēseōs*—thought, the thought—how does that go? *Noûs*, *noēsis*, *noēseōs*. Yeah, the thought of the thing that is thinking thought. The thought thinking itself is the highest form of existence for Aristotle, the purest, most eternal form for Aristotle. It is the explanation for him, remember, of how everything else happens, how all chains of causes and effects downstream are moved.
- 3.31** But Aristotle is careful to point out that this isn't done, can't be done through scientific means of push and pull efficient causation. It can't be done that way. Why? Because the being has no physical contact with the cosmos. It's an immaterial being. The immaterial being isn't going to swoop down and make breakfast for you or stop a tsunami. This is not fitting for the perfect being. There's no causal contact or traffic with the world, with the real world, with the natural world.
- 3.32** So you say, we thought that the unmoved mover was the explanation for why anything exists at all and why anything develops and why it comes into existence and goes out of existence and undergoes change. Aristotle's answer is that what moves the world is a deep metaphysical desire and yearning for thought, thinking itself. The world is directed towards this being, this unmoved mover. It's very, very interesting.
- 3.33** There's a line of Dante that goes something like, "L'amor che move il sole e l'altre stelle." This is the love that moves the sun and the other stars. And the answer that Aristotle gives is that this desire that the world, what he calls the sublunary world, the world below the moon, what gives it a yearning for pure thought, is desire. It's love, and it produces motion; this cosmic narcissist produces motion in the world by being loved, by being lovable, by being loved.
- 3.34** This is again a very Platonic idea. We have this idea in Plato's, one of his possibly most famous dialogues: the Symposium. There are some incredible, remarkable speeches in that dialogue that put a primacy on *eros*, which in Greek means "desire," desire for possession, yearning. And that idea of what is most lovable, what is most to be desired in Plato, is that which is most perfect. And for Plato, that which is most perfect is that which is least vulnerable to change. So it's gotta be something outside the world of space and time, everything within which is vulnerable to change and decay and rust. So,

eventually, you get to the picture that we have in *The Republic* and elsewhere with Plato.

- 3.35** But notice with Aristotle, you've got something very close to this. You've got an immaterial—you've got the centrality around divinity, a kind of God, which Plato is much more allergic to advancing, though there are moments where he does seem to be quite theistic, that is immaterial, that exists necessarily and timelessly, and which can have enormous effects on the way the world moves, the way the world is affected. All of this is something that you could imagine quite a lot of agreement with Plato, with a Platonist, about.
- 3.36** So Aristotle develops this very elaborate theory of lots of different circles. There's some wonderful medieval representations of this, of Aristotle's map of the universe, but not just of the universe, but the whole of reality. The universe, for Aristotle, is just one portion, one ladder, one link in the great chain of being, the great chain of being that stretches from pure stuff, undifferentiated potency, all the way up to peak purity, peak perfection, and immateriality, and that which activates all of reality downstream, further down the chain, further down the great ladder, of being, the great hierarchy of being.
- 3.37** He does think there's this hierarchy; he thinks there is a genuine ladder. He thinks there's a genuine structure with the unmoved mover at the top, and then celestial objects above the moon, and then sublunary substances, which are mixes of actuality and potency below the moon. And then, you get to the bottom where he thinks it's just prime matter and everything strives upwards towards actuality, pure actuality and pure perfection.
- 3.38** This, if you like, this figure thought thinking itself in the metaphysics becomes a bridge into how we can start thinking about Aristotle's ethics because he thinks that part of perfection, part of the purity of the unmoved mover, is also an ethical purity. It's a form of some ultimate explanation of why there's goodness and value in the world.
- 3.39** In fact, right at the end of the *Nicomachean Ethics* that we're going to look at in our next lecture, right at the end of that famous book, in Book X, he talks about how the highest aspiration any human being can have is the life of contemplation. It's the contemplation of deep questions, the contemplation of nature. That's really the highest form of human activity. So, actually, you might think not to be particularly active, but this is for Aristotle the most perfect form of life. This is what happiness or *eudaimonia* consists in, ultimately: an activity that's in accordance with the highest virtue, a rational activity, an activity of reason.
- 3.40** The highest virtue for Aristotle is, well, what he does: theoretical wisdom, or *sophia*. So the contemplative life is the highest for human beings, and the way to approach that, the way to approach the divine, the way to contemplate the divine is to contemplate eternal truths, and eternal truths are what is grounded in the divine, and that we as

human beings can in some way participate in that divine life, can be infused with it to some extent, even though not to a full extent.

- 3.41** Why? Because we've got bodies, we have desires, we have needs, we have emotions. We can't ever attain that state of pure intellect, at least not in this world. And Aristotle thought this was the only world there is. But we have got rational souls, so in contemplation we can, as it were, we can exercise the muscle that gives us some access to divinity, some access to that higher plane of existence, that higher plane of life.
- 3.42** And to contemplate is to become more like God. This becomes a very standard insight and claim in mystical traditions, particularly in Christian mystical traditions, in Vedantic Indian mystical traditions, sometimes in very radical forms. The famous Indian phrase is *tat tvam asi*, "thou art that," that the true endpoint of contemplation is to realize that we are one with ultimate reality and that our sense of personal identity is actually an illusion, and that we can learn that through contemplation and through meditation, and absorb ourselves into an undifferentiated being that is a single substance, if you like.
- 3.43** You get this language too, even in some Christian mystical traditions like Meister Eckhart, Julian of Norwich, Teresa of Avila, John of the Cross, all of these medieval, late medieval mystical writings. There seems to be a slide between absorption into one and the loss of personhood or an intensification of personhood, an intensification of the inner life where the mystic is caught up into a very intense relationship with the divine, but remains himself or very often herself in the course of that religious experience. But the idea that it's contemplation that makes us like God, it's contemplation and it's reason that makes human beings the particular kind of beings that we are. It's what distinguishes us as the kinds of being that we are.
- 3.44** And so this theology of Aristotle, if we can call it that, obviously provides fertile ground for creationist philosophical traditions to emerge, which we find in Judaism, obviously Christianity, and in Islam. We see it first in a character like Philo of Alexandria, whose dates are roughly 20 BC to 60 AD. Philo is a Jew writing in Alexandria with access to Aristotle, with access to a whole range of Plato, a whole range of classical texts, pagan texts, but also he's got the Torah at his fingertips, he's got Hebrew scriptures at his fingertips.
- 3.45** So you see in Philo's writing, for the first time really, this extraordinary attempt to fuse Hellenic thought—Greek thought—with Hebraic thought, with a thought, as it were, for the reason and faith to come together, or at least Greek philosophy, ancient philosophy, to fuse with the theology and ideas of Second Temple Judaism, you might say—with early-to-late Israelite religion, modified, of course, and changed and transformed in all kinds of ways that we don't have time to go into with the Christian revolution in the first century AD.

- 3.46** So the question is—Aristotle is both a friend and a foe when it comes to the creationists or Abrahamic monotheists—is the unmoved mover personal or impersonal? For Aristotle, as he describes the unmoved mover, you probably have to say impersonal. This being, this stuff is not—there's no awareness of the cosmos, there's no awareness of you or me, and no providence for the cosmos, no sense of providential care for human beings as we get in the Abrahamic traditions.
- 3.47** There's no question of praying to this god and asking this god for things, as would have been perfectly common, would have been done every day. Aristotle would have done it every day with Apollo and with Athena and with Poseidon and before every journey, before every theater performance, the whole theater festival itself was a religious festival to the god Dionysus and so on. But it's pretty clear that you can't have liturgies or prayer in the form that Aristotle would have, in the form of Greek popular religion of Aristotle's time.
- 3.48** This god doesn't know anything beside himself, remember? He refuses to contemplate inferior things. So this is a god that doesn't know anything about change, doesn't know anything about causation, doesn't know—there's a lot this god doesn't know. So again, there's a problem there. If your God is a creator God and creator of everything distinct from himself and the source of ultimate intelligibility for everything distinct from himself, then Aristotle's not gonna help you out.
- 3.49** And then, there might be questions of how many unmoved movers there are. There's a passage in the Metaphysics that suggests there might be 55, one for each celestial sphere. But then, he also talks of "the." He talks in the singular of the unmoved movers, so that could be a little bit—there's an ambiguity there, which unsurprisingly was resolved in the monotheistic direction, not the polytheistic direction, by the great monotheistic traditions.
- 3.50** And then, there's the question of: How can an immaterial cause bring about motion or material effects? This, if you like, is right at the heart of the question of the relationship between mind and body, and I'd urge you to buy, beg, borrow, or steal your way to the introduction to Philosophy of Mind delivered by yours truly for the Peterson Academy. And there, we explore across eight lectures this great question of how an immaterial mind can have an impact on the physical world. These seem to be two entirely different kinds of things.
- 3.51** Aristotle's claim is indeed that this unmoved mover has zero contact with the physical world. It's just that the physical world is moved from desire for it, orexis, "a desire" for it. But the unmoved mover doesn't initiate anything; it's not aware of the existence of the sublunary world or what is moving, and so on and so forth. So that's a key challenge, and that's a challenge that monotheistic philosophical traditions have had to wrestle with.

- 3.52** What you can say in favor of a qualified comparison of Aristotelian theology and Abrahamic theology, or Abrahamic philosophical theology, is that in both cases, God provides an explanatory, a total explanatory power, a comprehensive explanatory power. It completes the metaphysical system, you might say.
- 3.53** It explains why there is anything at all, it explains why there is being at all, why there is motion, why there are causes, why there are substances and properties and so on and categories and so on and so forth. It explains purpose, purposiveness. It accounts for the direction and the dynamism and the momentum of the natural world. Yes, Aristotle doesn't have a doctrine of providence, but there is still this idea that there is movement in the world that is directed towards a particular goal, and there's an explanation for why it's directed in a particular way towards that particular goal.
- 3.54** The other thing that Aristotle's theology does, which Abrahamic theology also seeks to do and tends to do very well, is that it provides an explanation of how physics sits with metaphysics and how metaphysics sits with ethics and how ethics sits with politics. It provides an anchor, to mix my metaphors, for the cathedral. It provides foundational buttresses for the cathedral to stand up. That's a lot harder to do in the modern world, in modern secular reasoning.
- 3.55** One of the reasons that so many universities today are becoming multiversities is that the original vision of the university, namely that it was founded according to one single integrating horizon of human inquiry. Obviously, in the medieval period, that was framed in terms of God, but also truth, goodness, beauty, character, service, and although there were lots of very different disciplines and subjects and faculties within the medieval university, there was a shared universitas, a shared tilting towards a single horizon—it's possibly not quite the correct etymology, but it'll do for the purposes of explanation—versus a multiversity where you've lost that sense of an organizing horizon that we all broadly share, we exist in.
- 3.56** That's been effectively completely atomized. So it's not always clear what physics is for, except maybe there are certain pragmatic ends. It can help us with funding this, funding that, it can help us build that bridge and so on. But there's no sense that all of human knowledge fits together according to one nice architectural plan.
- 3.57** Theology has got that unifying power. It's not that you should be invoking God when you're doing physics any more than when you're doing mathematics, or any more than when you're doing literary theory. That's not the explanation that theological explanation is. Theological explanation is what happens when you get right to the bottom. You get deep down to those questions about the nature of being.
- 3.58** Why is there something rather than nothing? Why is what there is so intelligible to us when we might have predicted it with a far, far more probability of being completely unintelligible to us, and so on and so forth? Why is it that we seem to live lives with a kind of experience and an engagement with reality that suggests that we are both in

the world but not quite of the world, that we sometimes feel at home in the world, we sometimes don't feel at home in the world? This is a very strange phenomenon for something that should only be understood as existing in the world, and so on and so forth.

- 3.59** So that is why this top piece, as it were, of Aristotle's cathedral, the unmoved mover, is important in terms of explanation, in terms of connecting human thought together, and also, I think, setting out natural theology. What reason alone can—how far reason alone can get to God? It turns out that Aristotle has got no access to any revealed texts. He's got no access to the Hebrew scriptures. The Old Testament is probably being completed a few years before he's born. It's probably the final bedding down, the last text to be written.
- 3.60** If we say Ezra and Nehemiah, the late fifth century. Daniel is a bit of a puzzle. Some people would date Daniel to the third or the second century BC, but basically, everything that we would read about in the Old Testament has happened and has been written about, and has just about started to bed down, and we're entering into the intertestamental period in the history of Judaism and Christianity. So, roughly speaking, from about 400 BC to the 30s, 80s, that's the gap between the Old Testament and the New Testament in terms of both events and actual people sitting down to write them down. So you've got this big stretch of time.
- 3.61** There's one important process that does happen, which is in the third century BC: a group of 70 scholars sits down in Alexandria to translate the Hebrew scriptures into Greek. That's called the Septuagint, and that's a response to Alexander the Great's conquest. Everything is Greek now, so we've got to translate these Hebrew scriptures into Greek. That's done allegedly by 70 scholars, which is why it's called the Septuagint, literally the 70.
- 3.62** That's a very important moment because it brings ideas from the Israelite religion and the whole world of the Hebrew Bible into the world of Greece and Rome. So suddenly it's there in a very beautiful Greek, very well translated, a very accurate translation for its time, unbelievably accurate. And you start to see this fusion of the two, the fusion of the Hellenic and the Hebraic.
- 3.63** One important feature of this is to think about and focus on the metaphysics of the human person, the metaphysics of you and me. What are we? How does Aristotle define us? How does he understand us? Well, here we'll move from his work, the *Metaphysics*, to his work called simply *On the Soul*. For some reason, the Latin title has persisted, so it's called Aristotle's *De Anima*, which simply means *About the Soul*. But in Greek, it would have been something like *Peri Tēs Psychēs*, "About the Soul." *Psychēs*—*anima* is the best Latin translation of the Greek *psychēs*.
- 3.64** And when he analyzes the form-matter composite that is a human being, he says that, yes, that being has a soul, it has a *psychē*, but soul is probably the best translation

we've got, I suspect. But what it really means is something like the principle of activity, the source of life in a being, in the human being, the reason it is a human being and not some other kind of being, because the soul that it's got ties it essentially and definitively, necessarily, to the particular category of human beings, particular species, particular kind of being, and that's the form, that's what we call the *psychē*, what we now call the soul.

- 3.65** Now, the soul—the trouble with the word soul is that it's an old, first of all, it's an old Saxon word, so it doesn't have any of the classical Greek or Roman resonance in it. But secondly, also, obviously, it's a theologically freighted term. We talk about the salvation of our souls, or we talk about our soul's destiny, and so on. So it's still, even in our secular, post-religious world— or at least large parts of it, post-religious—the word soul activates theological nuances, which is not true of the word *psychē* in Greek thought and Aristotle's thought.
- 3.66** So it's the form of the living body. It's not a separate substance, as Plato said. It's just a formal principle. It's an organizing principle. It's fused with matter in a way, and the relationship between form and matter is like the impression, like the relationship between seeing and the eye. Effectively, that's what the soul is to the body, as seeing is to the eye. They're not two separate things. And what it is to be a human person is to be a soul-body composite.
- 3.67** Now, this creates lots of complications later on. Many people draw the conclusion that Aristotle, therefore, did not believe that there was life after death in the way that Plato did. For Aristotle, to be a human being, to be a human person, is to be a form-matter composite, and if the matter dies or you undergo biological death, then you undergo death. That's it. That's the end. Your personhood is dissolved.
- 3.68** Now, various Christian theologians try to work around this, including Thomas Aquinas. Thomas Aquinas said that yes, at biological death, you lose your body, but it's not death. You continue to exist in this intermediate soul-like, detached soul state, awaiting the final resurrection of the dead, awaiting your, as it were, re-embodiment. But that was a difficult legacy of Aristotle for believers in postmortem existence.
- 3.69** So he develops this treatise and what's so interesting about it, the *De Anima*, is that rather than tentatively wondering, how could we make sense of a soul occupying or being within a human person. What he does is he says that soul is absolutely everywhere. Everything has soul, or every living thing has soul, which can be quite startling for us today, because why talk of the soul, talk of the psyche, talk of mind, consciousness? It feels immaterial; it feels like something that's not ever going to be scientific. We prize science today; we prize science as the benchmark of reality, the benchmark of what's true.
- 3.70** Whereas Aristotle, the great father of all these sciences, is saying that everything is soul, everything is ensouled in some way. All living things—the plant kingdom and the

animal kingdom—have a nutritive soul. That is to say, they have a principle within them of organization, of capacities that allow living organisms to breathe and breed, to exist, to sustain themselves, but also to reproduce and to bring new forms of themselves into being: nutrition, growth, reproduction, the most basic capacities of any living thing. And that's present in all living things, including plants. So plants have souls.

- 3.71** And then, the next layer up is what he calls the sensory soul. This is the capacities that some living things have—all living things within the animal kingdom have to perceive the world, have to be in sensory contact with the world. The five senses, touch is the most basic for most animals, but also everything that comes with sensory perception and being able to feel things: desire, pleasure, pain, locomotion, moving, imagination, maybe. You might say that animals have mental images of some sort.
- 3.72** And then, finally, the third tier, the highest tier, is the rational soul. So we've got the nutritive soul, then the sensitive soul, then the rational soul. This includes the previous two layers—so it includes the nutritive soul, it includes the sensory soul—but humans only, humans uniquely, have this third kind of soul, this rational soul. And that has two aspects. It's the reason that we apply to our praxis, so our behavior in the world, how we conduct ourselves in the world. That's a practical reason. That's a reason to do with how we do stuff, praxis in Greek, meaning action and doing things.
- 3.73** And Aristotle says there's a whole kind of knowledge and logic and philosophy that shapes questions about what's valuable, what isn't valuable, what should I do in this particular situation, what should I do in that particular situation, how do I become a better character through cultivating that virtue? You think that's a completely different domain of inquiry from theoretical reason, from the Greek *theoria*, meaning simply "contemplation." *Theoria* is to contemplate, to see. It is connected to the word theater; *theaomai* means to simply "watch" or "observe."
- 3.74** Contemplation, theoretical reason, is the kind of reason that we can undertake only in a pure abstract way. It's got nothing to do with us. Nothing to do with how we conduct ourselves in the world or how we behave. It's just more to do with the world, leaving us to one side and our actions to one side.
- 3.75** This gives us a sort of very broad-brush picture of how Aristotle's metaphysics operates as the capstone to his work in logic and in physics. We've pressed the very peak of that metaphysics by considering the unmoved mover, the *noûs*, *noësis*, *noëseôs*, thought thinking itself. And then we've used that as a springboard to move from metaphysics into psychology, into his theory of: What is the soul? What is the *psychê*? What is it that psychology claims to be about? What are we?
- 3.76** So you can start to see, in the last two lectures, we've laid out this vast roadmap, this blueprint for thought that Aristotle gives us in this small handful of texts. And I think what we can now turn to is from the psychology, from an understanding of what it is to be a human being, we can then move from theoretical reason into practical reason.

That's what we're going to be doing in the next two lectures, as we turn to Aristotle's ethics, that is to say, how individuals should cultivate their own lives, and then the politics, which is an account of how individuals together in a polis, in a city-state, can work together to achieve the common good.

Lecture 4: Aristotle's Ethics

At a glance — Aristotle's ethics — virtue, the mean, and human flourishing.

- 4.1 Welcome to Lecture 4 in the series Aristotle: From Logic to Life. In the last two lectures, we've been covering some very difficult territory, thinking about logic, thinking about the philosophy of nature, thinking about metaphysics itself, thinking about psychology, what it is to be ensouled. These, you might think, are very speculative, difficult questions, and indeed they are.
- 4.2 What we're turning to now is both more straightforward in some ways, but also a lot more theoretically challenging in how we understand what it is for Aristotle to have practical reason. I mentioned earlier, remember the toolbox, the Organon? The distinction that he makes in one of those texts is between practical reason and theoretical reason. Theoretical reason is to do with *theoria*, so reflecting on the world, speculating about the world, often speculating in ways that are never going to be adequately demonstrated because they are neither mathematical truths nor are they scientific truths. They're truths that transcend science if they are truths at all.
- 4.3 And, on the other hand, we have practical reasoning, which is to do with—it's not being good at plumbing or good at DIY or anything like that. It's to do with just *praxis*. In Greek thought, *praxis* is "all action," all behavior, ways, manners of conduct. The practical is the *praktikos*; that's the adjective formed from that, and that's the one that Aristotle uses: *praktikos*, that is to mean, "that to do with human action," the whole scope and sphere of human action.
- 4.4 Aristotle says there's a different kind of reasoning that governs the questions: What ought I to do in this particular situation? From the theoretical domain, where the questions are not "ought" questions, but "is" questions. They are questions about describing the world accurately or speculating about it. We don't use the language of ought in theoretical reasoning. That's only in practical reasoning when we're thinking about our obligations, our duties, what it is for us as subjects, not just as natural organisms, as subjects who are free, who are ensouled, are minded in some ways, and so there's a whole different corner of philosophy devoted to these questions.
- 4.5 So that's what we're going to be looking at in this lecture: Lecture 4. We'll be looking at ethics, Aristotle's ethics, and indeed, we get the word ethics from Aristotle, *ta ethika*, which comes from the adjective formed from the noun *ethos* in Greek. *Ethos*— not a million miles away from our contemporary word today, *ethos*, but it doesn't quite capture this notion of personal character. So *ta ethika*, literally "the things to do with character," things involving character, and that name has stuck. Ethics is really the study of character, what it is to live a good life, live a flourishing life.
- 4.6 Character is right at the center of Aristotle's whole picture of ethics, as we'll see. He wrote two treatises on ethics. One, the *Eudemian Ethics*, which very few people read,

but it's an interesting and absorbing text. There's some questions about its authenticity, but stylometric analysis—done by Anthony Kenny and others—suggests that it was Aristotle. Of course, it's very difficult because—is it Aristotle? No, it's just that one of Aristotle's students has a very different style from another of Aristotle's students from the lecture notes. So, actually establishing authenticity when we don't even have a benchmark of what is authentically Aristotle is very, very difficult.

4.7 Still, from Aristotle's School, we can say that these two treatises emerge. One is the Eudemian, and the second one, the most famous one of all the ethical treatises to have come down to us from the ancient world, is the Nicomachean Ethics. Nicomachus is the intended addressee. This is advice; the genre, the context is advice to a young man who is a scion of a great Athenian family destined for great things in public affairs. This is almost like an advisory manual.

4.8 Many people have argued, in fact, that the end of the Ethics, we have this fascinating passage in Book X, where Aristotle, having given us this detailed guide to how to live well and what to do in difficult situations, how to reason about friendship, how to reason about weakness of will, how to reason about character and virtue and how to avoid vice and so on, at the end of all of this, he turns and almost as an aside says, but the highest good, the highest goal of all human beings is the contemplative life. That is to say, right at the end of the Ethics, he moves, he says that that's practical reason, but the highest end, the most godlike pursuit, is theoretical reason and contemplation, and he comes over all Platonist just in these last paragraphs of Book X of the Nicomachean Ethics, the final book.

4.9 So it's always to be remembered that there are these textbook splits, or textbook contrasts drawn between Plato and Aristotle. Very often, every philosophy textbook pretty much has a picture of Raphael's famous School of Athens, which you see just before you step into the Sistine Chapel. And it's got a who's who of ancient pagan philosophers, and in the middle, you have Aristotle and Plato walking down. You have Plato with one finger up into the heavens and Aristotle with one finger down to the earth. That does crudely, but accurately sum up a real distinction between them.

4.10 Plato's head in the clouds thinking about other worlds, thinking about transcendence, thinking about eternal forms. Whereas Aristotle is fascinated by the cave. He's fascinated by and takes it seriously; he doesn't think that we should mistrust nature simply because it's contingent and fickle and changing the whole time. The nature of change fascinated Aristotle, and not just the nature of change, but the nature of stability across change, because then we start to ask, what is changing? There must be some underlying subject of change that does not itself change.

4.11 All of these distinctions, those textbook distinctions, are valid to some degree. But at the end of this work, as I said, Aristotle takes on a much more, almost acknowledges that it's the domain of theoretical reason, which is the higher one. And many have argued that the Ethics is to be read as a prequel to the Politics, which we'll be looking at

in Lecture 5, *Ta Politika*, which is an extraordinary document, much longer than the *Nicomachean Ethics*. And if you like, it's a work that's plainly addressed to somebody who's read the *Nicomachean Ethics*.

- 4.12** The idea is to get your own house in order, clean your room, as Dr. Peterson would say, and work on your own character and what it is for a person to live a virtuous life and so on and so forth. And then, once you've digested that, you're ready to think about the grander things of politics and the life of the polis and what the right constitution is and so on and so forth, or what the justification for a polis is. We'll talk about that in the next lecture. That might make sense to us, but it's worth noting in passing that it's the reverse of what Plato proposes, at least in *The Republic*, the great political text that Plato produces, the long dialogue in 10 books.
- 4.13** In *The Republic*, you have this fascinating exchange with Socrates where he says that we want to work out what the just soul is, but that's too difficult. We can't even make any inroads yet with that question. We can't understand what it is to be a just soul, but we could perhaps try to work out what a just city might look like. And so Plato comes at this from the opposite direction. He says that we need to think about what a flourishing and functioning community would look like, and then that will give us a clue into what a well-ordered, just, flourishing soul would look like. It's very interesting.
- 4.14** So Plato has his whole theory about the body politic. The people in the lower working classes are driven by baser appetites. Then, you have the army and the policemen—the factory workers, you might say, would be the thymoeidic citizens, that they would be the chest citizens. And then, you have the philosopher-rulers at the top who are equated with the mind, with reason and order. And so this city-soul analogy goes all the way through Plato's *Republic*. And Aristotle says, "What a strange way to go about things," in effect. He's implicitly, I think, saying, "No, no, no, no. Just start with the basics, move up, and as we get bigger and into outer concentric circles,"—as he talks about when he opens the *Politics*—"that's how communities are formed." But communities reflect the individual members that they are made up of, so it's fine to start with the individual.
- 4.15** A quick preview, then, of Aristotle's ethics. We're going to look at various ideas that are not strange exactly, but in fact, they might appeal to people who've already read a little bit about ethics and thought about the good life, but it's still a minority view, or it's a view with relatively small support in the Secular Academy. Moral philosophy is always a little bit nervous of Aristotle. It's far too old. Anything that's old is probably not true or probably not correct. This is what C. S. Lewis calls chronological snobbery. The older a text is, the more suspicious we should be of it.
- 4.16** I tend to take the opposite view. I think the longer a text has been around, the longer an idea has been around, the better it's likely to be because ideas age in reverse. We get weaker as we get older, but ideas get stronger. It doesn't mean that an idea that's been around for a long time is true automatically, but probably, the longer it's been

around, the longer the text has been around, acknowledged as a serious text, the longer a figure has been around, acknowledged as an important figure, the more the burden of proof is on you to say that it's not, that it's not a good idea.

- 4.17 So, yes, ideas age in reverse, and I think nowhere is that more true of the ideas of Aristotle. And we're seeing, as I mentioned in an earlier lecture, Aristotle's revenge in all corners of Western philosophy in the academic domain. What's so great about Aristotle is that he keeps things very simple, and he begins from the ground up. We'll see this next in the lecture on the politics.
- 4.18 And here, in the lecture on the ethics, the Nicomachean Ethics, Book I, he opens by simply saying that we want to know what the good life is for us, for human beings. We want to know what that is. We want to know how to live it. We want to know all the techniques that we need to try to become a more virtuous person. Aristotle says that yes, that's the right question, but there's no point asking the question if we don't have some prior idea of what a human being is.
- 4.19 We can't answer the question: What does a flourishing instance of X look like?, if we don't know what X is. We don't have a good granular understanding of what it is. Only then, says Aristotle, can you start to ask questions about what's good for it, what's bad for it, and so on and so forth. He insists that once we've got a clear picture of human nature, then we can start to think about what human nature is for. Once we've got a sense of what human nature is for, we've got an organizing horizon against which we can then make particular judgments about how to behave virtuous ways, how to avoid behaving in vicious ways, and so on and so forth.
- 4.20 So he says, let's think about the highest good. Is there a highest good that is aimed at just for its own sake, and not for any other reason? For Aristotle, there is. The highest good is eudaimonia, "a state of flourishing," you might say, eudaimonia. It's often translated as happiness, which is not helpful. Happiness is a very new word in English. It has strange etymological origins. It's certainly not etymologically connected in any way with any Greek or Roman idea or word.
- 4.21 A state of flourishing or almost a state of blessed flourishing because you eudaimonia, in that word, you can probably hear daimōn, you hear the word daimōn. And for the Greeks, Socrates believed he had a daimōn. This is this idea that you would have almost your own personal angel or your own personal spirit or invisible interlocutor. These are mysterious beings, but broadly benign and very smart Greek philosophers believed in them.
- 4.22 And you might say that daimōnios is to have a spirit of divinity or a streak of godlikeness. Eudaimonia does have within it a notion of there being some divine element as well, like a state of divine flourishing and blessedness, you might say. There's no English equivalent really for it, a very hard word to translate. But this is the highest good for Aristotle. This is the ultimate horizon against which we can start

working backwards from, when we're deciding, trying to work out the virtues and how they fit together and how to cultivate them.

- 4.23** So what is, Aristotle asks, the highest good for human beings? What is eudaimonia for human beings? What does that look like? Could it be pleasure? Could it be a life of pleasure, as many contemporary philosophers think, as utilitarian philosophers think today? Or certainly in the 19th century, they did. And Aristotle says that no, human beings are equipped for far higher ends than mere pleasure. Pleasure is something that is distributed across the animal kingdom. Even cattle take great pleasure in their lives, we can assume. So it can't be pleasure, even if that might be some ancillary benefit.
- 4.24** Could it be honor? Could honor be the highest good for human beings? Aristotle rejects that, too. He says that honor is downstream of having done something that's worthy of honor. And also, it depends on the judgments of others, and those judgments might be mistaken. We don't ever do something to seek honor. We pursue a good; honor is conferred on us because we have pursued some other good.
- 4.25** Could it be money? Could it be wealth? Aristotle rejects this pretty forcefully. He says that no, chrēmata, money, stuff is purely instrumental. It's only useful—in fact, the word money in Greek, chrēmata, is connected to the word chrēstos, meaning "simply useful." Chrē- conjures a sense of obligation, money, and credit and so on. So useful things are useless if we treat them as something that is intrinsically good, not just as instruments. So he says it can't be that. It can't be that wealth is the benchmark for happiness and flourishing. It's got to be definitive, intrinsic, not instrumental, not something that leads to something else. It's got to be self-sufficient, and it's got to be worthy—it's got to have an intrinsic worthiness.
- 4.26** So what does he do? He then develops something that's called in the textbooks the function argument. A function argument. So to understand what's good for human beings, we need to understand what human beings are. What are we for? What is our function? We can ask: What is the acorn for? Its function is to become a flourishing oak tree. So what could the human being function be? The Greek word for function is ergon. We have this in the ergo machines, with the rows. So ergon means "action," "function."
- 4.27** So it can't be mere life, says Aristotle. The plant kingdom has life, the animal kingdom has life. It can't be life that sets us apart. Nor can it be sensation because all animals pretty much have some kind of sensation. And here we've got the De Anima in our minds, hopefully, whether you remember the three-tiered level, the three tiers of souls of ensoulment: nutritive, sensory, and intellectual, rational at the top.
- 4.28** Here, at this point, Aristotle says that there's one thing that we have which neither the plant kingdom nor the rest of the animal kingdom has, and that is the hegemonikon: "reason," logikon, the thinking faculty. The human function, the human eudaimonia, flourishing for Aristotle, is the activity of the soul. The soul is at work, our distinctive

soul, in accord with reason, in accord with reason. And that's, if you like, that's a very high calling, that's the highest calling that any living thing has in Aristotle's world.

- 4.29 The other thing he says is that we have a tendency, what's distinctive about us, is that we project into the future. We can make plans far into the future. This is a very distinctive thing about us. We're driven by a desire to understand the world, says Aristotle. He says that this is a curious feature of us as a species. We're the only species that will attend or download or watch lectures on moral philosophy, for example. This is an unusual behavior in the animal kingdom. It's a unique behavior in the animal kingdom, but Aristotle thinks it gives a very important clue into the kinds of beings that we are.
- 4.30 Notice that this claim comes up out of—so we're grounded in the plant kingdom because he says all living things have the nutritive soul. So we share with plants that principle of habit formation towards new life and towards sustaining ourselves. And then, the sensory soul, we're grounded in that too, in virtue of having perceptions and sensations and so on. But finally, we've got this one unique characteristic, that is to say, the capacity to reason, which is what must be involved in our ultimate flourishing, in any account of our ultimate flourishing.
- 4.31 Notice how different that is from Plato. Plato doesn't talk about our groundedness in the plant kingdom or in the animal kingdom or anything like that. He's not terribly interested in those more biological questions, you might say. The soul just seems to float around in a sort of meat sack, and then the meat sack dies, and the soul heads off into the next one.
- 4.32 So that's his understanding of flourishing, the activity of the soul in accord with reason. That's our function, and we need to make sure that the activity of the soul is in accord with reason and then also therefore with virtue. The state of flourishing is—maybe a state is the wrong word to use because it's more of an activity. It's an *energeia*. There's dynamism, a dynamic quality to *eudaimonia*. It involves action, *praxis*.
- 4.33 He then starts to discuss what virtue is. He starts to get into these long discussions about different kinds of virtue. A virtue, he says, is an excellence of one's character, an excellent character trait, or it might be an excellent intellect. And he says that just as there's practical reason and theoretical reason, there's moral virtue and intellectual virtue, and we acquire it through habituation. We acquire it over time. We become just by doing just acts. We become brave by doing brave acts.
- 4.34 We need to consider a person's life as a complete life, knowing that there will be—in the process of forming habits towards a particular goal—there'll be many failures. It'll look as if no progress is being made at all. Aristotle comes back more than once to this point that one swallow doesn't make a spring. "As it is not one swallow or one fine day that makes a spring,"—he writes—"so it is not one day or a short time that makes a man blessed and happy."

- 4.35 It's that longitudinal perspective, very different from a tendency in some corners of moral philosophy today to simply take one act or look at one problem, one obligation or one moral scenario and then try to extrapolate a great deal from that. Aristotle is going to think about the whole trajectory of a person's life, and it will always be possible to look at particular instances or events within that life and form a very misleading picture about the overall achievement of flourishing and blessedness and virtue in that person's life.
- 4.36 So what's crucial, says Aristotle, is that we cultivate virtues from within ourselves. That is not something that we are doing through external coercion. There's got to be a proper internal state that is directing our virtuous behavior. But still, he's got this idea that virtue and good behavior is something a bit like learning an instrument. The constant practice of the piano will make you a better pianist; constant practice of courage will make you more courageous. We'll come on to discuss that and why that has been challenged in due course.
- 4.37 But for now, let's understand that the connection is that the virtuous person enjoys virtuous acts. It's not the virtuous person is the person who most faithfully conforms or obeys to some external authority, even if those external authorities, as we'll see, Aristotle takes law very seriously indeed. He thinks law is an antidote to a lot of political problems.
- 4.38 The law definitely has a function, but just as you hope that your child will learn not to steal from his sister's breakfast plate over time, and not just because you have to threaten him with capital punishment or something, you hope that they learn. You want them to get to the point where they're able to make their own decisions and exercise their freedom well. So you might say that Aristotle takes a view of law, the relationship of law to the virtuous life as similar to the relationship between training wheels and being able to ride your bike freely through town.
- 4.39 As he likes to do, he comes up with shopping lists of the different virtues and how they fit together and what the methodology is to implement them in the right way. So he develops this idea of the doctrine of the mean, the golden mean, you might have heard of it. And what he says here is quite an interesting and not uncontentious point. He says that a virtue is always a golden mean, a middle way, between two vices, and you need practical wisdom and practical reasoning to work out how to walk that tightrope.
- 4.40 So courage, he says, is a tightrope walk between cowardice on the one hand and rashness on the other, excessive rashness and excessive risk-taking, or maybe somebody with a death wish. And so Aristotle says that courage is working out what is neither cowardly nor rash. What is the neither cowardly nor rash behavior in this situation?
- 4.41 Temperance—prudence, temperance in one's appetites, he says, is a mean between intemperance—a completely indifferent debonair life—and insensibility, which is a

refusal, a Puritan refusal to be aligned in any way with the joys of life, the joys of creation and God's gifts in the theological register.

- 4.42 Generosity, he says, is a balance between stinginess and wastefulness, wasting money. Again, the generous person is a moderate person in the sense that they're thinking moderately between the two evils, the two excesses of the two ways to pervert the virtue of generosity.
- 4.43 Then he had a fascinating passage on pride: what's proper pride, permissible pride, pride that is appropriate to the just person. He says—and the English are very often guilty of this—a false humility, excessive humility on the one hand, and vanity on the other. But he says that, no, there is actually a proper state of mind as to how we relate ourselves to our successes and our achievements that is neither false, inauthentically modest, inauthentically humble, nor vanity on the other, where it all goes to your head and the other. He says, there's a middle way there, and that middle way is proper pride.
- 4.44 He goes on and on, he talks about truthfulness, finding that mean between self-deprecation and boastfulness, et cetera, et cetera. It's said moderation in all things is the mantra to take away from this. That's not quite right. It's more the metaphor he uses is hitting the target, hitting a target. He says that the moral life is a bit like that, with every moral decision we make, we're trying to aim for the target. We're trying to get the right virtue cultivated in the right way. It's delicate, it's fragile, tiny little inflections or changes in one's environment or decision-making could force us to miss the mark.
- 4.45 But the moral life, the virtuous life, is a constant game of archery. You're constantly firing at targets, trying to hit them. And so it's not as if—it's very easy to miss, very difficult to hit, but it gives you that sense that the moral life doesn't involve the precisions and the clear definitions and boundaries of theoretical reason. Human life is much messier than geometry and arithmetic and astronomy, the whole world of theoretical reason.
- 4.46 This is one of the reasons why Aristotle thinks there needs to be a completely different domain of thinking about obligations, what we ought to do and what's right and what's flourishing and what's valuable and what's evil, et cetera, et cetera, because, particularly when it comes to forming moral judgments, there's a randomness, there's a vagueness, there are situations where there is no right thing to do. There are moral dilemmas where even if you come down to the view of one side, you'll never be able to do that without hesitating or without a second thought, without running the counterfactual in your mind, "I know I've done the right thing, but there was a cost to it." The cost was not being able to do that or not being able to behave in that way.
- 4.47 What Aristotle is very good at doing is explaining that there is a radical, moral luck that comes within a lot of these situations, and that it's rarely precise. It's not like

arithmetic, as I said. It doesn't have that precision. And in some ways—this is a famous argument developed by Bernard Williams, the great Cambridge philosopher, and Martha Nussbaum, a great American philosopher, wrote a very good book called the *Fragility of Goodness* in the mid 1980s, where she actually argued that, and Bernard Williams himself also argued, that if you really want a lesson in the moral life, you shouldn't be reading philosophy, you should be watching Greek tragedy.

- 4.48 Nussbaum's argument is that actually it's the tragedians who understand the nature of the quality, the phenomenological character of the moral life, far better than any of the philosophers because they understood that sense of loss, that sense of complete incommensurability of being completely caught in a dilemma.
- 4.49 So, I don't know, Clytemnestra in Aeschylus' *Oresteia*, murders her husband as he's having a hot bath that she's run for him after he's come back from 10 years winning the Trojan War. Because, in order to get the fleet out towards Troy, he had to sacrifice their daughter, Iphigenia, to get the fair winds that took them, Clytemnestra, Iphigenia's mother, has never forgiven him. And she's also taken up with a guy called Aegisthus and is having an adulterous affair with him. But the point with Clytemnestra is that she's got this extraordinary love for her daughter, and the horror, her sacrifice, has corrupted her or has led her towards this terrible dilemma between honoring her daughter's memory, avenging her daughter, and honoring her husband. That's a classic dilemma.
- 4.50 There are many all through the Greek tragic canon— in Sophocles's *Ajax*, for example. *Philoctetes* and Euripides's *Medea* is a great tragedy about dilemmas, moral dilemmas. There are no neat answers, and the tragedians understood that.
- 4.51 So back to this question of character and forming positive stable character traits over time, which is Aristotle's thesis, and also the thesis of, I would say, quite increasingly widespread popular literature, looking at questions of self-improvement, character. You see them a lot in airport bookshops. There's quite a lot of academic work now being done on character, particularly in Oxford and at Wake Forest in the United States. Christian Miller at Wake Forest is doing fantastic work on character. Michael Lamb, a former colleague of mine, is also doing terrific work. So there is a lot of academic interest, and there's a lot of popular interest and appetite for these questions and how to understand them.
- 4.52 There've been a number of critiques, a number of reasons to be suspicious of a reworked or revived Aristotelian understanding of virtue and character, which I think are worth flagging. One is the label for the umbrella of critiques to character theory, which comes from the so-called situationists. The situationists think that, in fact, tiny changes to a moral agent's situation or scenario or external environment actually have non-trivial effects on the moral judgments of that agent. But if the character formation over time theory was true, we shouldn't see that. We should expect the character of

the agent to be resilient to external, frankly, trivial tweaks in the environment, which lead, it seems, to non-trivial effects in the moral decision-making.

- 4.53** One experiment—this is a battle, really, within social psychology—but a famous study called the Good Samaritan Study was undertaken in 1973. I think a group of ordinands, that is to say, theology students on their way to priesthood—I think the seminary students, I think it was Princeton Theological Seminary—were told that they were divided into three groups. They were all told that they would be heading to a lecture on the Good Samaritan. They were told that each group was released at different times: one was in a hurry, the other not in very much of a hurry, the other walking very, very leisurely to the lecture theater.
- 4.54** Outside the lecture theater was a paid actor who was pretending to be a homeless person, just lying on the street outside. What was so striking was that there were massive differences in the responses of the three groups, depending on how late you told them they were for the lecture.
- 4.55** The group that said you have all the time in the world, it doesn't start for ages, just go and get yourself settled in. How did they respond, as they, remember, were going to a lecture on the Good Samaritan? How did they respond to the homeless person lying at their feet as they walked in? The people who were not rushed, 63%, that's a pretty good rate—63% helped the homeless person in some way. The next group that were going, where things were a little bit tight, around about 35-40% helped. And the group that was said that if they don't run, they're going to be late, 10%, only 10% helped the homeless person.
- 4.56** So what's the point of this? The point is this was one, pretty good sample size, one group randomly divided into three, with roughly similar backgrounds, roughly similar vocations, theologians, moral theologians, many seeking to become priests, all divided arbitrarily into three groups. And then, you have these wildly disparate 63% down to 10%.
- 4.57** The situationists say that these people are literally devoting their lives to learning how to be more virtuous and to be upstanding members of their community and to be pastors to their spiritual flock, and so on. How could it be that just one variable— the time that they were getting there—could lead to such radically divergent moral decisions?
- 4.58** Another one—there are quite a few of these, and they're not without their problems, but they alert us to some important vulnerabilities in character theory, virtue theory, near-Aristotelian ethics that need defending and shoring up. Another experiment was the dime in the phone booth experiment. It turned out that if somebody found a dime in the phone booth, that would increase helping behavior. You're more likely to help in the next hour or two—I can't remember the exact time frame—just one, just a dime.

- 4.59 So again, these are situations where it seems as if the social psychologists are telling us that character is too easily manipulated by tiny, trivial factors. We're not as in control of our moral decisions and our moral life as we tend to think.
- 4.60 There are lots of other interesting studies. One, there's an Aristotelian claim that the virtues have a unity. The idea is that a person who's developed courage is a person who has also developed temperance and so on and so forth. These studies are of kids taking math tests and spelling tests, and there is temptations being put in their way. It turns out that one and the same kid will be happy cheating on the spelling test when offered a way to do so, but wouldn't on the maths test. You'd see all these variations that wouldn't make sense if this child was a virtuous child who knew that honesty was the best policy. No, he said, "Spelling? I'll cheat there. With the maths, no, I think I can do it. I can do it myself." All the results reflect this.
- 4.61 So there isn't cross-trait stability in the sense of the unity of virtues that Aristotle insisted. That's the challenge. Good character has got to be something that's cross-situationally stable, quite plausibly. It's got to integrate different virtues, at least as he understands it. But the claim is that Aristotelian ethics rests on an illusion, a mistake, namely that character traits can be unified, can be stable, can be developed across time, and can be effectively resilient or resistant to most external factors, and certainly not vulnerable to trivial ones. That's the challenge.
- 4.62 Some responses to this from Aristotelians, which I think are very good, there's some very good responses. They argue that being virtuous isn't just being consistent. The one swallow doesn't make a summer—a line from Aristotle. It will always be possible to come up with particular examples, particularly across a big group of surprising results, or results of a failure in virtue formation. There's nothing in virtue theory that insists that you're like on an escalator, you're just getting better day by day by day by day. It's more as in the stock markets, you look at the broader trends, you look at the broader through lines, you look for the signal in the noise.
- 4.63 Aristotelians have just returned to this insistence on the idea that virtue is something that requires education, is something that requires practice. Indeed, we see it in any home where children are being brought up. We see that moral formation is needed. We see that sometimes it works, very often it doesn't, but over time the through line is towards a fully formed, well and properly morally formed human person.
- 4.64 Aristotle isn't ignorant about the effect of variables across different moral scenarios. In fact, part of the point that he's trying to push is that the person with character is the kind of person who can respond well in surprising scenarios, who can respond well to different scenarios in different situations, who is attuned to different situations. It's part of the challenge of virtue formation and character formation to attune oneself to the situation, to the details and the moral scenario. So that's a fascinating debate that is raging as we speak within social psychology, within moral philosophy, between an Aristotelian virtue ethics on the one hand, and the situationist critiques on the other.

- 4.65 Let's go back now to think about the shopping list of virtues that Aristotle lays out. One of them is classified as a scientific set of intellectual virtues— that's the part of the rational soul that investigates the world and can access necessary eternal truths. And then you've got the calculating part, which is more to do with praxis.
- 4.66 He says there are different intellectual virtues. One is sophia, theoretical wisdom, so the wisdom that we were trying to apply in Lectures 2 and 3 with logic and nature and metaphysics and psychology. It's knowledge of the highest things, contemplation of eternal truths; it's the highest form of knowledge for Aristotle, sophia.
- 4.67 And then, there's epistēmē, E-P-I-S-T-E-M-E, which is simply scientific knowledge and investigating the world and inferring from conclusions about the world to scientific truths. We've also got, there's also intuitive reason, nous— we've come across that word before, N-O-U-S. There's an intellectual virtue involved in the person with great technical skill, a technē, T-E-C-H-N-E. A technē is a skill or a function or a purpose.
- 4.68 And then finally, the fifth intellectual virtue is the intellectual virtue and reasoning that we have when we are engaged in practical wisdom, the moral life, and that is called phronēsis, P-H-R-O-N-E-S-I-S. Phronēsis is not a technical skill. It doesn't make things. What phronēsis does is it clarifies the ends of human action and then works out and deliberates about the means for achieving those ends. It's something you can only develop over time. Aristotle thinks it comes with one's maturity, but you can't be virtuous without it. It's the essential mode or virtue in one's intellect, one's understanding. It is the enabling condition for being virtuous.
- 4.69 We can't conclude a lecture on Aristotle's ethics without stressing how important to his ethics, the idea of friendship was. Friendship, philia. We value our friends, we think about friendship, we have a good idea of what counts as a good friendship, what counts as a less good friendship, but it's very unusual to find, certainly in a moral philosophy, friendship having any central place, central focus. But Aristotle devotes almost two books to it, almost two of the 10 books to the virtue of friendship. So why does he do this? Why is it so important to him?
- 4.70 First of all, he thinks that friendship is essential to the good life. You cannot have a good life if you do not have friends. He says that no one would choose to live without friends, even if he had all other goods. He thinks they're most necessary for life. He says that having friends is even greater than justice. Friends don't need justice, says Aristotle, a very interesting line, that.
- 4.71 If you're friends with somebody—was that the end of John's gospel? Remember, Jesus says that now I call you friends and not servants because you understand my will, you do my will. You understand what is right and therefore almost justice, free from the law as it were, as St. Paul puts it. It's quite a proto-Christian idea. We don't need justice, we don't need law. Law, as Paul says in Galatians, law is just a teacher, that reminder of how regularly we fall short in Paul's view.

- 4.72 So friendship has got this extraordinarily high importance for Aristotle. He spends more time on this than anything else, on this one topic than anything else in *Nicomachean Ethics*. He says that there are different kinds of friendship, a classic Aristotle. What kinds of friendships are there? Can we divide them all up into different aspects? So, he says, there's a friendship of just utility, maybe a business colleague, basically based on mutual benefit, business relationships or political alliances. Aristotle says that this isn't truly friendship. It's not friendship in the true sense. It's unstable. It ends, it's got an end date when the utility runs out, and it's not friendship in the fullest sense.
- 4.73 Friendship based on pleasure, Aristotle says, is a little bit better, because it's based on the enjoyment of another's company, of the friend's company, that's not a bad thing—shared activities, humor, etc., etc. He says that's more stable, more stable than mere utility, but it's still fickle. Pleasures come and go, and so on. So he says that's not quite, it doesn't quite get there either.
- 4.74 Perfect friendship, *philia teleia*, is, says Aristotle, the friendship of virtue, character, where each friend loves the other for who they are. It's based on a shared virtue, shared character. To be a friend to somebody is to will their good, to wish for their good, for their own sake. Similar to, Aquinas picks this up in in the Middle Ages, this famous definition of love that emerges from the scholastics, that to love a person is to will their good, is to will their flourishing. That, with a five-year-old child, is going to mean doing things that the five-year-old child is not going to want to do and may appear less than loving, but because it's willing the good of the child, it is love in that it covers those very plausible, apparent counter-examples.
- 4.75 To love somebody is to will the good of the other. So if you have—a classic example would be a friend who's done something they need calling out on, or they need tucking off, or they need talking to about. It's a very difficult thing to do. But on the Aristotelian view, the friendship of virtue and character, the true friend is the person who's going to try and call them back to a life of virtue and to heal defects in their character.
- 4.76 This is how he develops this notion of friendship of virtue and character. He says that friends help us act virtuously in lots of different ways, but mainly by providing models for imitation. This is an idea in moral philosophy called exemplarism—the lives of great people, great men, all the lives of terrible people. I mentioned earlier this debate within social psychology about how to test these different conclusions.
- 4.77 In fact, the one model, I think, the most promising framework for character formation and for all of these character and leadership programs all across the states and increasingly now in Britain, has been this idea of exemplarism. It does seem to be the case that people who regularly conform their lives or have role models to follow and to conform their lives to in some ways, there's a statistically significant uptick in the strength of their moral judgments and resilience of their character traits to external factors and so on and so forth. This is the one area where it does seem there's some empirical evidence for character formation.

- 4.78** It's not an accident that in the ancient world, nobody sat around learning the Ten Commandments. Let's say in the Roman world and the Roman and Greek world, nobody sat around reading Commandments. From the first century onwards, they were reading, for example, Plutarch's *Lives*. Plutarch writes these incredible Roman lives and Greek lives, and he pairs them together. So he pairs parallel lives, so he pairs a Roman with a Greek, he pairs Caesar with Alexander the Great and then does a little brilliant little biography of Caesar, a brilliant biography of Alexander the Great. It's supposed to be instructive: "This is what a good man, this is what a great life looks like. This is what a terrible life looks like. This is all the failings and the flaws," and so on.
- 4.79** That really was moral formation in the ancient world. It's not what would Jesus do? It's what would Caesar do? What would Alexander do? What would Themistocles do? Well, I suppose, he was never in precisely this situation, but do you remember when he was exiled to Persia, and then tried to get back, and maybe we should be a little bit like that. Or no, you should be like Alcibiades was— it seems a messy way of doing ethics, a messy way of engaging in practical reasoning.
- 4.80** But human life is messy. There are never going to be exact, precise parallels. There's never going to be in any textbook of ethics, or how to do life, or how to flourish, that's going to tell you precisely what needs to be done in any given situation. The messiness of human life, because it's a property of every human life, will be in the lives of the great men whom Plutarch is writing about. It's a remarkable achievement, and he did it with a very clear moral pedagogical function. It had a very clear function. The end for Plutarch was to forge great men in the future.
- 4.81** So we've covered all the different—we've looked at friendship, the focus of Books VIII and IX of the *Nicomachean Ethics*. We've looked at, we've done a survey of Aristotle's ethics, the importance of ethics to him, how he understands that our ethical horizon, *eudaimonia*, can only be determined once we've got a good sense of what we are, what human nature is, and particularly the ensoulment, the rational ensoulment that we have. So the life of virtue will always be an activity of the soul in accordance with virtue as well as with reason. It's an activity, remember, an *energeia*, not just a state.
- 4.82** And as I said, at the end in that final passage of Book X, he turns to the contemplative life, and clearly thinks of the well-ordered, just person of caliber and character to be somebody who has integrated these two modes of thinking: the practical and the theoretical reasoning side of things. We looked at some of the objections, too, to the character view of virtue acquisition and virtue formation.
- 4.83** We're now at a position to turn away from the life of the individual and the lone moral agent, and to the life of the city, the city-state, the polis. We can think of that as a nation. We can think of it as any organized political community. Aristotle lays out and begins to help us think about how we should approach the life of the polis, how we should, as virtuous flourishing citizens, how we should structure the polis in a way that

we can, as it were, enable it to flourish more and to equip it to help us and future generations be formed with the same character destined for the same flourishing.

Lecture 5: Aristotle's Politics

At a glance — Aristotle's politics — humans as political animals.

- 5.1 Welcome to Lecture 5, Aristotle's Politics, humans as political animals, the fifth in this series on the life and thought of Aristotle of Stagira, Aristotle: From Logic to Life.
- 5.2 In the last lecture, we explored Aristotle's ethics, his account of virtue, friendship, the function and purpose of human beings, what it is to flourish as a human being. As I said, there's something of a prequel character to the Nicomachean Ethics, as if it's a prelude to this great work of politics. In many ways, this lecture will be completing the analysis that we began with the Nicomachean Ethics in the previous lecture.
- 5.3 The question he asks in the Politics is not what is the highest human good, how do human beings achieve that, so much as what community is required to enable citizens to attain flourishing, to lead flourishing lives, to cultivate habits of virtue. He goes about this—you probably won't be surprised by this stage to know—in a very evidence-based, logical and empirical way. He looks at 158 actual constitutions of Greek city-states all around the eastern half of the Mediterranean, all around the known world, all of those he was able to get to know.
- 5.4 Remember, he exiled himself twice from Athens, once in 347, around Plato's death, and then again right towards the end of his life. When things are getting difficult after the death of Alexander in 323, he goes into a self-imposed exile to Evia, to Euboea, Chalcis, to his mom's place, where he retires and dies. So he's doing a lot of traveling and would have been aware, growing up in Macedon, what it was to be in a monarchy. Then, moving to a radical democracy in Athens, the cradle of democracy, the place that invented it all. But then, he would have spent a lot of time in oligarchies or basic dictatorships in some ways. By going over all these different constitutions, assessing what's strong and what's weak, he develops this very fine-grain analysis of what a flourishing community looks like.
- 5.5 The roadmap for the lecture is to start, really, to follow Aristotle in his reasoning all the way through the Politics. He says that if you're thinking about human nature—we get this a little bit in the two books on friendship in Books VIII and IX in the Nicomachean Ethics, this idea that human nature and human flourishing is completely bound up with relationship, with friendship, with social beings, or rather, as he says famously, "We are animals,"—zōon, zōa, plural—"fitted for the polis."
- 5.6 We're suited, we're shaped for the city, the city state. We are a zōon politikon. We're an animal designed for the polis. Man is a political animal. Man is a political animal. You might have heard that quote, one of Aristotle's most famous, before. But most people, when they hear that, hear in the word "political" something very modern. People are very political, as if we all like doing things that politicians do. There's a note, a sense of maybe treachery or moral instability, possibly, or machiavellian behavior. But this is not

at all what Aristotle means by the word *politikon*—simply, very neutrally, we're the kinds of beings that flourish, that need community, need an organized community. We're community people. We're intrinsically social beings. "Man is by nature a social being," is probably a better translation, a more accurate translation.

- 5.7 We'll follow, as I said, Aristotle's reasoning as he comes to understand quite why it is that there is this tight connection between the polis and the individual. We'll look at some of the different conclusions he draws about the constitutions he examines. In the opening book, the opening passages of the first book— it's unfinished, actually, the *Politics*. It runs out, it breaks off in Book VIII, *On Education*. There was more that we think he wanted to write about education, but it's not a complete work, even despite its influence.
- 5.8 But he starts Book I of the work not where you might expect. He's not asking questions about the nature of democracy or the nature of oligarchy or how judges should be appointed in a community, how authority should be separated out, whether there should be voting, if so, how the voting should work. He doesn't look at any of these questions at all. What he asks, as he does in the *Ethics*, he goes right back to basics. "What kind of a being are we?"
- 5.9 He insists that we are at least animals, but we're animals that are social. We can use our reason. We're political, not just in the sense that we like getting on with each other. You could say that lions and wildebeests are social in that way. We are social in a political way in that we think about the architecture of our communities. We allocate different roles. We understand responsibilities. We have chains of command, which are unbelievably complex. Most of them we're not even conscious of, but they arise through convention and habit.
- 5.10 Why does Aristotle think this? He develops this argument along the lines of, what marks us out and what suggests that we are fitted, we are political animals, is that we have speech, we speak. We don't make noises. We actually have speech. We have logos. We have speech, not just voice. We're unique in having speech. We're unique in having logos. The point of having speech, what we do with speech is we discuss what is just and what is unjust, what is virtuous, what is not virtuous. We deliberate.
- 5.11 Aristotle says that this is not an accident. Nature does nothing in vain, he claims. There's always a purpose to every naturally arising thing, which human beings, we may be a lot more than animals, but we are at least animals. We're to be understood in a naturalistic context. As he says, "Nature does nothing in vain, and man alone among animals has speech." Aristotle says this capacity to deliberate, to reason, to engage in civil discourse is not an accident. Nature doesn't do accidents, is his view. It's a clue to our nature, says Aristotle. It's a clue as to what kind of beings that we are. We're suited for deliberation. We're suited for a discussion about how to organize ourselves in a practical way.

- 5.12** How does this arise? We don't dream up some constitution and impose it upon a people. This is a point made by the 19th-century French philosopher Joseph De Maistre. He says that there are no constitutions in the sense that it's not as if a constitution is the living wellspring of a moral community. It's almost always the case that a constitution is crystallizing or documenting a self-understanding of how that community already works, already exists.
- 5.13** When the American U.S. founders in the 1770s and '80s are reflecting on these challenges and problems, they're thinking about the nature of the people, the significance of the American people—what it is, how the constitution should be drafted depending on certain geographic questions, questions to do with population distribution, and so on and so forth. The spirit that animates the founding documents has a particular view of the world and understanding of nature and nature's God, and what is self-evident and what isn't. That doesn't create—it does, at one level, create something entirely new, but it's at least as much for Aristotle as a document of how a particular people understands itself at that snapshot in history.
- 5.14** It goes right back to the beginning. This is way, way before we were even thinking about constitutions, even before we know how to write. There are households, there are groups. We are sexually dimorphic beings. We are paired beings. That is to say, it's a pair that is the enabling condition for new life, a new life that needs ongoing formation for an unusually long period of time within the animal kingdom. Therefore, for that formation to be possible, for that paideia, that education to be possible well into the teenage years, the household has to be a stable place for the formation to occur.
- 5.15** This is different, by the way, from Plato's very radical suggestion in *The Republic* that—and this is something the Spartan regime believed as well—that really the children belong to the state. The children belong to the state. The family is an awkward bastion against state power, and really, the state should have a right to its future citizens from the beginning. Plato and the Sparta agree on that, which is one of the very few things they do agree on.
- 5.16** Aristotle doesn't take this view at all. He thinks that the formation can't be coerced; it shouldn't be coerced. It happens within the household, within the *oikos*. The way he thinks about this is that you need the household structure just for your daily needs, just to get by day by day. Basic protection, provision of food, learning, moral formation, entertainment, the life of leisure, work, all of this is contained within the *oikos*, and managing it is the *oikonomia*, the economy.
- 5.17** But then, Aristotle says, that's not sufficient because a household is going to be vulnerable to external threats. So what you're going to need is a *kōmē*, "a village," a collection of households. *Kōmē* in Greek means "village;" it's where we get that word comedy from, literally village song, because all the satires and the comedies would start up in the hills outside and then come into Athens. The village provides a level of

security and resources, but it still doesn't quite have self-sufficiency. The village can help you with less than daily needs, but important needs, but not all of your needs. You need more than just a colony of families.

- 5.18** What you need, finally, says Aristotle, is a political structure, a political community, which he calls the polis. The polis, the best translation for the word polis, is probably a "city-state." There were hundreds of them all around the Mediterranean world, really beginning from the eighth century BC onwards. They are, if you like, self-sufficient, autonomous. Probably the best analogy would be Singapore, somewhere like Singapore or possibly Switzerland. They were quite small. Certainly, Athens at its peak was no more than 80,000-90,000 citizens. That's a generous estimate.
- 5.19** But they would have their own law courts, their own temples, their own founding myths, very often. Sometimes, they might be colonies of other Greek cities, particularly the Greek colonies in Sicily and Italy, and even the south of France and North Africa. These are daughter cities. There's a lot of colonization happening in the eighth and seventh centuries BC.
- 5.20** He thinks we need a polis, and that's what gives us autarkia. It's what gives us self-sufficiency. The city provides not just economic exchange, the possibility for markets, but also military defense, education, justice, and so on and so forth, all of the conditions you need for a noble leisure to live a life of flourishing, to live a life of virtue. For Aristotle, this is the key aim of having a well-ordered polis so that we can live well: *tō zēn*, "the living well."
- 5.21** There are two words for life in Greek. There's *zoē*, and there's *bios*. *Bios* is the life that we might think about in biology when we're studying life as a phenomenon, what's organic, what's inorganic, etc., etc. *Zoē* is a different sense of life. It probably has got a slightly more spiritual dimension to it, but there's a sense of it being almost uniquely human, uniquely human-spirited, reflective life. It's more than a mere animal life, more than mere *bios*.
- 5.22** This is the basic structure. He says, what kinds of beings are we? Well, we need one another. A man needs a woman, a woman needs a man, and then children come into the world. Then, that changes the conditions in such a way that we need to ensure the formation of children over time. What does that mean that we need? It means we need to be more than a household. We need to maybe have our homeschooling network or whatever around the village. But even that was still vulnerable to those evil Thracians who come down from the north randomly and terrorize us. So we need some city walls, we need an army, we need a protective capacity to engage in diplomatic relations with the Thracians and all of that. So there, we need one level up, and there we get to the city-state.
- 5.23** But that's how he moves. You see, it's from the bottom up, starting from what actually do we need? What actually makes our lives better or makes it easier to be better, to

have the freedom to do what we ought to do, not just the freedom to do what we want to do? So it's very empirical. It's hard to resist the logic of it. Rather than coming up with a grand scheme, which he then will claim to be universally applicable to any particular civilization, this is a very natural way of thinking about how we should organize ourselves.

- 5.24** It's got a very clear sense of what the point of it all is. There is this highest good in the ethical life and the chief aim and the chief justification for setting up the city with all the trade-offs that that involves, all the surrenders of freedom, all the constraints that it involves in being part of a social contract and being subject to the laws of a city or a nation, all of that is justified by Aristotle's claim that this is all fitted for the highest, towards the highest good. This is all designed to enable human beings, enable the citizens of the city to lead maximally flourishing lives.
- 5.25** So he's very conscious that there is a highest good, that this is what it is, and that this is what the city should be pursuing. It's a much more robust conception of what more political communities are for than tend to be allowed these days when we're talking about ordinary, modern, contemporary politics.
- 5.26** So parties that have a very clear sense of what virtue is, of what the right thing to do might be, and that seek to impose them, particularly if they come from the traditional intellectual frameworks of the big religions, there is a feeling there that that's something that we should be agnostic about, that we should park our deep commitments about what the good is, about how God is involved in it, if at all. Our deepest convictions about ultimate reality, and certainly about the highest good, should be parked, should be domesticated, kept away from the public square when we're trying to justify certain public policies or all public policies, because otherwise there would be disagreement all across the public square, deep, deep, irreconcilable disagreement about the fundamental conception, the correct conception of the highest good.
- 5.27** This is a worry that we've had in the West, really, since the mid-17th century, the end of the great series of so-called wars of religion, which led to stunning levels of loss of life and damage to Christendom, to Europe. We're still haunted by that. Liberalism, which is the doctrine that emerges in the 17th, 18th century, is still haunted by the horror of people going to war against each other for their different conceptions of the highest good or understanding of God or whatever it may be.
- 5.28** We've developed in modern Western political theory views that insist on a strict neutrality when it comes to asking deep questions about the nature of the good in order to preserve civic peace among different denizens of different moral universes with different moral assumptions, different cultural backgrounds, and so on. The price of pluralism is agnosticism about what virtue really is. Because in any plural society, you're going to get wide disagreements about what the good is, what virtue is. It should not be the business of the state to be coercive on that front, to say that this is the

state's conception of the good, and it doesn't match with yours. The idea is that it's intrinsic to the freedom of the individual to be able to choose and disagree with and dispute any particular moral narrative or conception of the highest good.

- 5.29** Aristotle is saying that there is a common good, there is a certain way that all human beings are going to flourish. He, probably, at one level, is quite prescriptive, probably too prescriptive for the liberal mind. On the other hand, he's also insistent that he's not a fan of pluralism. So he doesn't like—there are various passages in the Politics where he says that you've got to be very careful—every city-state needs to be careful not to allow political leaders to welcome in people who are not already from that city-state.
- 5.30** Why? Because, first of all, it's a sign that the political ruler may be, or the tyrant may be, relying on effectively hired mercenary help. And that's a bad sign because it means that he can't command the loyalty of his own citizens, no doubt because he wants to do things which the citizens would not approve of, that there wouldn't be a consensus for. He says that when you have a lot of different—it's strange to read him say this because, of course, he's an immigrant. He's a foreigner. He never makes it to being an Athenian. He's exiled twice. He has this, presumably, very complicated psychological relationship to Athens, which gave him Plato, gave him so much, gave him so many opportunities, but never let him be one of them, despite extraordinary achievements. Really at the end of his life, things were getting so bad, he felt he had to just leave.
- 5.31** But Aristotle is clear, he says that it's got to be a relatively stable body of citizens who have a shared moral universe, shared moral norms, same language, same gods, probably related to each other—the parents, the ancestors go back and so on. In a city-state of 25,000-30,000, you can have a very stable and harmonious political community. But he says that can be disrupted, and when it's disrupted, the sense of that shared horizon starts getting disrupted, and then everything starts to implode.
- 5.32** Let's turn now to how he goes about this business of examining and sifting through, doing cost-benefit analysis of all these different constitutions. First of all, he's looking at the documents, he's looking at the constitutions not as something that is necessarily founding a city, but as something that documents the self-understanding of a political community, of a city-state. What he does is he comes up with this six-fold classification. He says there are three pairs, three main ways in which a city is governed, in which political authority is structured. There's a good way, and then there's a bad way, and so six altogether.
- 5.33** He says that early primitive forms of political authority are effectively tribal chieftains. They become kings, they become monarchs over time and rule well. But corruption is ever-present, and very often a good monarch can give birth to a terrible tyrant, as we see down the ages. What will often happen with a tyranny is that it will be overthrown by the great and the good, the *kaloi kagathoi*, the influential people within the city, the *aristoi*, the best men. And what will often emerge in the place of a tyranny is an aristocracy, where *kratos*, the power, is invested in the *aristoi*, the best man.

- 5.34** But they end up tending towards corruption as well. Eventually, the aristocracy turns into an oligarchy, which, for Aristotle, is not always a good thing. It's much more venal, tends to be much more corrupt. Aristotle, or at least many of Aristotle's students, would be having the oligarchy of 411 BC. This is a strange year in the Peloponnesian War when things got so bad after the Sicilian expedition that Athens switches back to oligarchy from democracy after nearly 100 years. It doesn't really work out. Gotta flip back to democracy. Then, again, in 404, when they lose the Peloponnesian War after the Battle of Aegospotami, the Spartans insist, as part of the treaty conditions, that Athens have to give up its democracy and become an oligarchy like Sparta, which it does, and then that all falls apart and it goes back to democracy.
- 5.35** A corrupt oligarchy will often be overturned by the people, and the demos will rise up, and then the kratos goes to the demos; it becomes a democracy. But democracy, too, can be corrupted. Democracy, too, has its shadow side, and that is what you might call mobocracy, or in Greek, ochlocracy. Ochlos means "crowd" or "mob" in Greek, O-C-H-L-O-S. So, ochlocracy—the word for the day—is the rule of the mob. I think I prefer mobocracy, but there we go.
- 5.36** So you've got this six-fold classification and the three broad baskets: rule by one, rule by a few, rule by many. That's it. It's monarchy, oligarchy, and democracy. Aristotle says that basically covers it. Any city-state can be ruled—political power will come from one person, a few people, or lots of people. It seems pretty, fairly comprehensive. Politically, what counts as good is what is done for the sake of the good of all. And what's bad or unjust is what's done for private aims, done for your own private enrichment without bearing the interest of the polis in mind. This is for the rulers.
- 5.37** But Aristotle is also clear that the real distinction isn't about the number of people in charge: one, or few, or many. He also understands that it's a question to do with wealth, with status. In the Greek mind at the time, democracy, radical democracy, was an experiment in relieving the poor, effectively. It was the poor finally getting their voice, getting their say in the great decisions of state. Whereas on the oligarchic side, the oligarchs tended to be the aristocratic, landed, well-connected gentry. So it was partly a battle over material resources, inequality, wealth and poverty, and so on. But it was more fundamentally a question of justice.
- 5.38** The two sides considered justice and applied what was just, weighed up what was just in different ways. They ranked them differently. The pro-democracy side would say that what justice really is in the end is equality for all free citizens. That's the goal: equality. Isotés in Greek, or isonomia, meaning "equality before the law," or isegoria, meaning "equal access" to the agora, equal access to the mechanisms of public deliberation and debate. That's what counts as justice: equality. We're all equally free, and therefore, everyone should have equal political power. That's the inference: equal freedom to equal power.

- 5.39 The oligarch side disagrees. The oligarch side says that inequality is not only fine; it's to be expected, and it's justice winding its way through society. Because our standing in society is always going to reflect our contributions to it. It doesn't matter if you can try legislating against it, you could try other means, but effectively, there will be disparities in status, in wealth, in income, in standing, in access to certain public goods, institutions, all across a citizenry of 25,000-30,000; what Aristotle had in mind, and for us, tens of, if not hundreds of millions.
- 5.40 There'll be randomness and arbitrary effects there, where you might have somebody born with a particularly good skill at X, and so throughout life, you say there's a radical inequality between this person's gift for the piano and everybody else's gift for the piano. But also, he's a terrible employee. He never gets his work done. In that respect, there's no equality there in terms of his contribution. And so it's very, very difficult to forge precise conceptions of equality.
- 5.41 The oligarch perspective would be that in creating an equal citizenry, that is, as it were, shaving off or limiting or constraining some who are contributing more or are able to contribute more in order to create an artificial plane of equality, says the oligarchic perspective or the anti-egalitarian perspective, is an unacceptable constraint on freedom. You can either have equality, or you can have freedom. You can't have both. You might say that if you aim for equality, you will sacrifice freedom. Others will say, actually, if you aim for freedom, you'll probably get a measure of equality thrown in. It won't be perfect, but freedom matters more than equality, etc., etc. It's fascinating.
- 5.42 This debate is a great debate that really tore apart the Greek world for most of the fifth century. It destroyed Athens. Athens was a wreck at the end of that, and Sparta was, too. The sheer loss of life and wasted genius of those decades is difficult to imagine. But the argument was effectively the argument that is still animating the Western political landscape today, namely between those who are drawn more towards a politics of equality, understood in where the equality that all human beings have in virtue of their intrinsic dignity, whether you've got a theological conception of that or a secular conception of that, that equality must be reflected in the distribution of socio-economic goods. If there are disparities in the distribution of those goods, then that's an indication that society thinks that some people are less endowed with dignity than others, are less morally worthy than others. That you might call the democratic side in Greek terms.
- 5.43 Then, the other side will stress freedom as a greater norm and as a more important norm than equality, and that in the pursuit of freedom, it will be the case that different capacities will develop, different talents will develop, different levels of industriousness will develop. And so you'll immediately start to see disparities in the activities that different people are doing.
- 5.44 Sometimes the inequality and socioeconomic goods that result from those processes can seem completely random. For example, if you're born in 13th-century England into

a blacksmith's family and you've got the genes that make you pretty strong, you've hit the jackpot. You're going to do pretty well. You may not have an amazing life, but then 98% of you don't, 98% of people are in absolute poverty in the 13th, 14th century. You're going to be pretty happy that your physical strength and the luck of being born to a blacksmith means that you're going to have a fairly good life.

- 5.45 But if you're born in England in the 2020s, having the genes for strength, having been born to an ironmonger, a family that runs a local ironmonger, is not going to help you at all. You're born into the same conditions, but society has changed so much. You could imagine a blacksmith in the 13th, 14th century, there'd be a lot of inequality between the blacksmith and much of the rest of the village in his favor, and it would be against him if it was in the 2020s, when we're in a knowledge economy, a services economy, certainly in Britain. That's all we seem to be able to do these days, just services, no more industry. It's no more hard, brawn, blacksmith-type work. It's all laptop work.
- 5.46 Is that unfair? Is it unfair that the kid born to the family running an ironmonger in the 2020s wasn't born in the 14th century and vice versa, whatever? It's impossible to form those kinds of moral judgments. It is what it is. Life is complicated. Life is messy. Life is randomly unpredictable, and you yourself have no choice over what access to social goods you will have before you come into the world. This is the oligarchic perspective. It's the politics of equality on the one hand and the politics of freedom on the other. You might say that the radical democracy is more left-coded, more progressive-coded, and the oligarchic perspective is more right-wing, right-coded, more conservative.
- 5.47 What is Aristotle's view on this? He says both. He says yes to both. He says this is not, in fact, a dilemma. Both are partially right, both sides are partially right, both sides are partially wrong. On the question of equality, he says that you can never just talk in isolation about equality. When you're saying that something is equal, you're invoking at least three terms. You're saying A is equal to B in respect of C, in respect of some standard. So, Terry is as good as Peter with respect to being a blacksmith, or Terry is as successful as Peter with respect to being a blacksmith.
- 5.48 So Aristotle says that equality isn't just this free-floating ideal. It's always going to be relating one person to another, one group to another, and then comparing those two against some benchmark, against some standard. So it's equality between whom in relation to what? That's the first question Aristotle says, which the democrats don't always answer. For example, democracy assumes that equal freedom, to be equally free, is to have equal access to political power. You could imagine circumstances in which, no, people are equally free, but they don't, in fact, have as much of a say as they would like in democratic debate.
- 5.49 Aristotle says, also, that you can't ignore contribution. What that means is you permit certain forms of economic inequality. But when you're forming a judgment between, say, the behavior of an aristocrat refusing to finance the Festival of the Dionysia that

year, so there aren't going to be any tragedies to watch—total tragedy—versus a worker working the olive trees outside Athens who gets a fraction of what the aristocrat gets, he says, you're not going to form the same moral judgment of these two people. You've got to compare like with like. Here, you've got an unequal relation between the aristocrat who could easily afford to put on this summer's tragedy festival, and we can't possibly expect this of somebody who hasn't got the resources.

5.50 When we're thinking about contribution, we're thinking about the purpose of the city. We're thinking about the telos of the city. If a polis existed primarily for military power, as was the case with Sparta, or for a military alliance, warriors would deserve more power, says Aristotle. If it was just for accumulating wealth, somewhere like Corinth, you might say that it's on these fantastic trade routes and gets very, very wealthy, becomes proverbially wealthy, then frankly, it's the wealthy, it's the traders, the merchants who are going to tend to have a disproportionate influence over the leadership and purpose of the city, and so on and so forth.

5.51 But Aristotle says the polis exists for the good life, for virtue and for eudaimonia. It's got to be that virtue should have the greatest weight in determining what's a legitimate political authority. Aristotle goes on to say: How do we come up with the right constitution? The democracy is onto something; oligarchy is onto something. He says that there are at least four different ways, and he loves dividing things up, doing his shopping lists. He says that there are at least four different ways we can think about how to come up with a decent constitution.

5.52 There's the ideal way. So, we just think to ourselves sitting in our armchair: What would be if I was President for a day or a year, how would I draft a new—what would be the best constitution in theory? Then he says, there's the practical way of thinking about what's workable, and that is: What is the best constitution I could come up with given the actual circumstances, given the circumstances that we're in at the moment, or the society is in at the moment? Then, he says, there's a hypothetical way of thinking about constitutions: What would happen if we designed this constitution? Then, finally, another practical element: How do you establish, how do you preserve regimes that have the best constitution for them?

5.53 What you have over the course of Books VI, VII, and VIII of the Politics is Aristotle's description of an ideal state: relatively small, pretty homogenous, citizens are freed from day-to-day labor to pursue virtue, contemplation, discussion, leisure— the Greek word for leisure is *scholē*, S-C-H-O-L-E, where we get our word scholarship from. Their sense of leisure was the reflective life of a high-minded citizen. But the focal point, really, of the whole of the Politics is Book IV, where Aristotle elaborates what he thinks the most suitable constitution would be, or rather the most practicable. It's not necessarily the ideal one. It's not a hypothetical one. It's what is the most practicable, what's most likely to work.

- 5.54 He says that the constitution that's most likely to work is a mixture of oligarchy and democracy. He says there should be property qualifications to entitle you to vote, but they shouldn't be too high. In fact, I think we in Britain had property qualifications, I think all the way up until 1928, if not beyond. Certainly, with the Great Reform Act in the 19th century, 1832 and 1867, part of the debate there was how to extend the franchise across Britain more fairly. At the time, they were very tight property. You couldn't vote if you were not a man with a certain amount of property, with certain assets to his name. That's the case right up deep into the 19th century in Britain.
- 5.55 Actually, it's a very common—until recently it was a very common qualification or common criterion. The reasoning being that if you're invested in the land, you're invested in property and assets in the land, you're going to have a greater stake, I suppose, in the future flourishing of the land, as opposed to if you are actually not particularly tied to it at all, and you could go off and be a digital nomad building up your bitcoin in Portugal or somewhere, or Belize. That's the thinking behind the property qualification.
- 5.56 Then, he says that some offices will be filled by election, but others will be done by lot. I guess we have that, too. Jury service, you're randomly selected for jury service; it's by election, by lot. Other times, you'll have to be elected properly, elected formally.
- 5.57 What else have we got here? Oh, yeah, fines—I like this. Fines for rich citizens who don't turn up to contribute to the legislative assembly and the decision-making process of the polis. You fine rich citizens for not going, and you pay poor citizens for going. You can work with the incentive structures. What Aristotle thinks is that this will be conducive to the emergence of a middle class. That is to say, a class that is neither the radicals that drove forward the democracy movement in the fifth century, tended to be from very poor backgrounds, nor the aristoi, the landed wealthy, either. It was the middle class that was, as it were, the hope of the state, the hope of the polis.
- 5.58 This idea of the middle class, he has some very bad, cruel things to say about the very rich. They tend to be arrogant. They don't like to be ruled. They're accustomed to commanding and being in charge the whole time. They lack the experience of obedience, says Aristotle. They don't understand how important it is to shut up and listen occasionally and to be obedient and deferential, to respect chains of command. These are virtues for Aristotle, which the wealthy are singularly ill-equipped to display, given their conditions.
- 5.59 The very poor, on the other hand, Aristotle says, have an overly servile—it's the opposite: they have an overly servile mentality. They're easily manipulated by demagogues, promising them riches because they lack property. So that makes them vulnerable. They lack education. That makes them vulnerable, for Aristotle. So on the whole, on average, and for the most part, citizens from this lower class will tend only to be willing or comfortable when being ruled rather than being in the driving seat and issuing political decisions. It's the people in between, the very rich and the very poor,

that should be the focus of the constitution, should be the focus of the architecture, should be the cornerstone of the architecture of the polis, because that is the middle class that prevents the polarization that yokes the very poor to the very rich in a single flourishing moral community.

- 5.60** Just to move into the final stages of the lecture, it's worth saying a little bit about the last book in particular, Book VIII, where Aristotle considers questions of justice and of law and education. The treatment of education is fascinating. In fact, he starts it in Book VII, but he says that education is the most important, but also the most neglected of the political skills, political topics that need to be properly addressed. He says that all citizens have a common end, the good of the polis, which is to enable the highest good of each individual. Because of that shared end, and it's a complex vision, Aristotle says that you can't have education that is sequestered from the city and from the city's goals and purposes.
- 5.61** Education must therefore be a public process. He says you can't have homeschooling, you can't have private tutors, you can't leave something as important as education to individuals and private families who may or may not agree with the horizon of the city, may not agree about what the city is for, whether to be proud of the city, whether to want to fight for the city, and so on and so forth. He says that's got to be something that's done in public. It can't be privatized.
- 5.62** He says, actually, Sparta gets this right. It's one of the only nice things Aristotle ever says about Sparta. At least the Spartans understand that you've got to get them when you're young, get them when they're young, three years old, four years old, baby boys, baby girls, toddlers, put straight into military training, into barracks, well into their teenage years. Theoretically, they're attached to a Spartan mom and dad, but really, from the very beginning, the state takes over. Aristotle says that the Spartans are not great in most respects, but on this, they get the importance of paideia for the polis, for the community. They get the importance that there has to be some shared process of educational formation.
- 5.63** Now, that doesn't map very neatly onto debates about private schools and public state-run schools. But it's still a live question when it comes to thinking about national curricula, so what should go into the national curriculum? We have a national curriculum in Britain, and I imagine there are things like that in the States, maybe at least at the state level.
- 5.64** He gets into what goes into it and the extent to which different schools, whether they're private schools or state schools, public schools, the extent to which they're required by law to deliver a certain minimal content of the national curriculum. It's not a question about private versus state education. It's more about the role that the state has, what appropriate role the state has in shaping the minds of the young.

- 5.65 What should be taught? asks Aristotle. Well, useful subjects, reading, writing, gym, physical training, liberal subjects, music, drawing, eventually philosophy, I guess. These are not for professional training, but for virtue, for the proper use of leisure, and so on and so forth. Then, the question is: How should things be taught, and what are the means for teaching things well?
- 5.66 One useful area that Aristotle touches on, takes very seriously at the end of the *Politics*, when it comes to education, is the role of music. It's worth thinking about this as an example of how Aristotle thinks pedagogy ought to work. He spends more attention on music than almost anything else, certainly when it comes to education, more than any other subject. Why does he do this? Because he believes that music shapes our ethos, shapes our character more effectively than anything else, shapes it in a unique way.
- 5.67 Why? Because he thinks, he's got this idea that music represents emotions and feelings more directly than any other art. The plastic arts, statues, paintings, these are forms of arts that interpose themselves between you and reality. Whereas he thinks there's something intrinsic, automatically active about music. You just hear the music and it's there. It represents deep emotions and character states in an immediate and direct way.
- 5.68 Then, he has these long discussions about different kinds of music, which are different, appropriate for different kinds of education. For example, he says that the Dorian mode promotes steadiness and courage—that's a particular set of musical keys, a musical mode, I think, is the Dorian mode. Good for steadiness and courage. There's the Phrygian mode, which is good for enthusiasm and ecstasy, maybe dance music or something. And the Lydian mode, which creates relaxation or even softness. He says that young people need to be exposed to these different kinds of music in exactly the right context so that they can have exactly the right effect; they can have exactly the right function.
- 5.69 But music, because it shapes souls, is the best example of what education more generally is. Education shapes souls. In fact, it's even there in the word *educare*, in Latin, "to lead out," *e-ducere*, to lead— *ex*, "out," *educere*, *educare*, *educate*. It's literally to lead the person out into the world and to form them and to shape them and to mold them. That's what music does more effectively than anything else. That's why music is the test case or the benchmark for what is being achieved through education. It's not about merely transmitting information. It's about shaping souls.
- 5.70 There, we've covered in just under an hour, one of the most detailed and significant works of political philosophy ever written. It's still probably up there with Plato's *Republic*, the most influential text on politics ever written. It's so foundational in so many different ways in how we think about the nature of authority, the nature of justice, the nature of equality, the nature of political and civic freedoms, the horizon towards which all moral community must tend to attain individual human flourishing,

how education and justice operates in that context, what the purpose of education is, the public function of education.

- 5.71** Then, right at the end, we looked at the way in which he thinks music is the most direct way of forming character, of shaping character. So that should be part of public education because shaping the soul, shaping the individual soul, is what the ethical life, the life of practical reasoning, is all about.
- 5.72** I want to know what your thoughts are on elected judges and what happens with a society that elects its judges that are not educated enough or qualified to do so or to apply law.
- 5.73** Yes, a great question. The selection of the judiciary is probably the most difficult constitutional headache that any liberal democracy, any constitutional republic, any constitutional monarchy ever has to face. The answer to your question is that there is no good answer. What's happened over the centuries is that different states with all the different constitutions have worked out a compromise that has worked, in some cases, worked quite well, in other cases, has worked less well.
- 5.74** What's the central problem? The central problem is that you need in the judiciary people who are properly formed, highly qualified, extremely well-educated, probably have practiced law for at least 20, 25 years—certainly, that's the case in Britain, before you can even get onto the bench. We're in the domain of expertise, in other words. We're talking about a profession. And membership of a profession or guild or an expertise is not something that can be left to a democratic judgment. It's something that only people within the field really have are qualified to form a view on.
- 5.75** This is why, certainly in Britain, judges tend to pick themselves. Judges choose the next generation coming up. There are elaborate processes, but it's basically internal to the profession. In Britain, of course, they're the king's counsels, so it's always the king who makes the appointment. It's not the people, it's not the judiciary, it's the king. So the way that a constitutional monarchy solved that is by saying that all power is in this one man, vesting it, exercising it on behalf of the people, and he picks the judges. He literally has to sign the paper, otherwise they can't become judges or they can't become king's councils, the top level of court lawyering in Britain.
- 5.76** That's the challenge. You can't pick. It's not something that seems open to election. And yet the judiciary, like every other aspect of the state, has to be accountable to the people because, as it were, it's exercising power on behalf of the people. More than that—it's governing, it's exercising power over the domain of public justice. It's a vital role. It's one of the three limbs of any state. You've got the legislature, you've got the executive, and of course, you've got the judiciary.
- 5.77** So how do you go about it? I think the solution that the founders came up with was probably one of the least worst solutions, because what you've got is the power invested in the presidency to appoint judges to the Supreme Court, for example, and

indeed a call across the federal judiciary, there is an indirect democratic link there in that the president would not have been there but for the will of the people, but for winning the election. That invests him with a certain degree of authority, limited to four years or possibly then subsequently to eight years, to exercise on behalf of the people the selection of the judges.

- 5.78** So you can say that it's not completely disconnected from democracy, but it's disconnected enough for the public to be reassured that there are experts making decisions about who should be considered and who should be put forward on a list to the president and so on and so forth. It's not ideal.
- 5.79** You think of the trouble that's happened in Israel before October the seventh. That country was very, very divided on the question of the judiciary. It was a very left-leaning judiciary, but a very right-leaning government because the people had voted the right-wing government in. It was judges versus the people. You get all these headlines which are very bad news, because confidence in the law, confidence in the judiciary is absolutely vital. Without it, society collapses.
- 5.80** In Poland, there's been big problems. In fact, that toppled government, you might say, the debates over the judiciary, how they're appointed, how they're selected. The executive can't have too much of a role because it's a crucial point in democracy that the executive can be held to account by the judiciary if it's going against the law and so on and so forth.
- 5.81** So, it's a great question. There's no easy answers, and probably the best answer is some mixed elements: an appointment mechanism with respect to judges that has some democratic justification, even if it's indirect, but that recognizes that law is a techne. It's a skill, it's a domain of expertise. Those who are not experts should not be making the final decisions about who are the most suitable people within that area of expertise to oversee public justice.

Lecture 6: Aristotle's Poetics

At a glance — Aristotle's poetics — literary theory, tragedy, and catharsis.

- 6.1 Welcome to Lecture 6 in Aristotle: From Logic to Life. We're going to be looking in this lecture at poetics, literary theory, tragedy, drama, mimesis—the Greek word for representing things in the world through drama or through art or through poetry. Over the last few lectures, we've been looking at some very technical aspects of Aristotle's thought: his logic, his philosophy of nature, his metaphysics, his psychology. Then, more recently, in the last couple of lectures, his ethics and his politics.
- 6.2 We're turning to what might seem to be a very different domain: poetics, literature, arts, and so on. But in fact, it's not really a departure as far as Aristotle's concerned. I noticed in the previous lecture, the extraordinary space that he devotes to musical education, more than any other topic. This is because Aristotle is committed to the idea that the virtuous person, the virtuous citizen, doesn't just need rightly ordered reason and a rightly ordered mind, but also needs to be able to calibrate and control his emotions.
- 6.3 It's in culture and music and literature and tragedy that we're best able to learn how to do that. These are processes that form us in learning how to control and direct and evaluate our emotions towards the right things, at the right time, to the right degree. The well-balanced soul is able to wield reason as well as he's able to wield and control emotion and calibrate emotion. So the business of politics and the business of education is not just forming rational judgment and instilling knowledge, but also emotional character, one's psychological disposition. And the arts for Aristotle are central to this, the central tool to achieve this.
- 6.4 There's another important context to Aristotle's work here, and it's called simply the Poetics, Aristotle's Poetics, *ta poetika*, the things to do with those that are made, those things that are turned into poems. That context, the context that has to be understood when we're considering Aristotle's Poetics, is the great attack that Plato undertakes against the poets, poets and artists, in his vision of the ideal city that is unfolded in that great work, possibly the greatest work of political philosophy ever written: The Republic, the 10 books of The Republic.
- 6.5 Towards the end of The Republic, Plato advances all sorts of reasons why poets should not be allowed anywhere near the city-state. They should be banished or forced to do something else, forced to get a proper job. All artists are to do this, and we'll go into the reasons why he thought that was important. I think the way to think of Aristotle, of Aristotle's Poetics, is a response to Plato. It's actually that no, poetry does have a place in a flourishing polis, and this is why, and this is how it should be applied. This is how it can be wielded well as a tool.

- 6.6 Tragedy can educate. He even says at one very famous point that art and tragedy purifies us. It's the word catharsis in the Greek, and there's a lot of debate as to what that word means. Does it mean achieving a psychological resting state, a state of detachment and satisfaction? Does it mean—does it have a spiritual element to it, a theological element to it? Is it morally purifying us? Could tragedy make us better people by witnessing certain horrific moral scenarios or heroic moral scenarios? It's not always clear, but we'll come on to discuss that at the appropriate juncture.
- 6.7 You might think of Aristotle's defense of poetry really as a defense of the role that the emotions play in the life of a human being, in the life of a human person. Emotions—it is quite a thin word in modern English, but the word pathos in Greek conveys more than just emotion. It's a feeling, total affective response to something. The word that used to be used instead of emotions was the passions. In the 17th and 18th centuries, we talked about the passions—the passions were everything that was not to do with the mind and not to do with reason.
- 6.8 Let's have a look at this lovely little work, the Poetics, and we'll go through it over the course of this lecture. Hopefully, by the end of it, you'll have a very good understanding of the first-ever theory of literature and the first-ever theory of poetry and tragedy ever advanced, and arguably has never been rivaled since, whether one disagrees with it or not. Aristotle begins, as he always does, right at the beginning, right with first principles, at the most basic starting point: What is art? Can we give a definition of art that somehow covers all the different kinds of art that would have been familiar to anyone in Athens in the fourth century BC?
- 6.9 You've got the oldest art of all, the Homeric bards, singing at night for hours and hours and hours, poems that they'd memorized, thousands and thousands of lines that they had memorized and sang to a beat which was set effectively by a lyre, a flute-like or a banjo-like instrument.
- 6.10 Then, you have the emergence of tragedy in Athens. The date is typically 545, 546 BC. The legend has it that a man in the procession to honor the God Dionysus, as the procession was making its way to the shrine of Dionysus, picks up a mask and begins to impersonate somebody from a myth, begins to pretend to be somebody from a myth. This is what Thespis does at a religious festival to the God Dionysus. That, legend has it, is the first time that drama occurs. The idea of pretending to be somebody else for public entertainment has never been done before, to our knowledge. It's why we call actors thespians. If you're a thespian, you park back to that one guy, Thespis, who picked up the mask. This is the 540s BC.
- 6.11 We know by the 490s BC, there's a flourishing and thriving theater industry in Athens, and increasingly all around the Greek world, but particularly in Athens. The religious festival remained the same. It ended in a celebration to the god, Dionysus, at a sacrifice of a goat, a tragos, and song and celebration around the sacrifice of this goat, an aoidē. So, tragōidia literally means a goat song. So tragedy means "goat song." It's quite

confusing, but it's good. If you know that, it will remind you that the context for this was religious.

- 6.12** It's all part of this elaborate religious festival that would happen for one week every year. There were competitions, and the plays were expensive to put on, and there would be a jury, and the top three— the winner would be chosen; there would be runners up and so on. This developed into a very sophisticated tradition over the course of the fifth century. The three greatest tragedians were Aeschylus, Sophocles, and Euripides—they're in that chronological order, and many would probably put them in that order of merit, too. There's a lot of debate around that.
- 6.13** About seven plays have survived of Aeschylus, about seven plays have survived of Sophocles, and about 18-19 plays have survived of Euripides, with one or two of those plays, authenticity is debated, but there would have been many, many, many more. This would have been part of— this would have saturated the cultural life and the public life of fifth-century Athens.
- 6.14** So, we've got epic poetry, we've got tragedy, and then comedy begins as well, a little bit later. But rival groups through the countryside, through the villages, through the *kōmai*, are also doing their own songs. But they stress the bawdy, the scatological, the irreverent, and it's often very political. The comedies, the only comedies that have survived are from Aristophanes.
- 6.15** Aristophanes has an incredible wit. He's got an incredible satiric edge and bite to him and got into a lot of trouble with the authorities in the 420s and the 410s. But one of his plays is called *The Clouds*, and it gives us this fascinating depiction of how ordinary Athenians actually viewed Socrates not as this great hero and this great mind who everybody revered and bowed down to, but as a very irritating, mad professor who kept getting in the way, saying awkward things, and dragging people off the straight and narrow on their way to become a better soldier or a better debater in the Ecclesia. It's very funny. You have these completely different perspectives from Plato.
- 6.16** But it's probably the Aristophanes's view, it's probably roughly the view that would have pleased and would have been familiar to most Athenians attending the play. Plato, don't forget, is an aristocrat. He probably comes from a very high class, probably very skeptical of democracy from the beginning as a rule of the mob, "Why do we want these people trying to run things?" Whereas Aristophanes is much more of a populist, much more grounded in the mood of society, the mood of the people.
- 6.17** You've got these three very different modes of artistic expression, each unbelievably sophisticated in their own ways. In fact, arguably, epic poetry has never been better, never been rivaled, never been improved on, certainly, despite Dante, despite Milton, despite Ariosto. In tragedy, Shakespeare is probably the only playwright who stands in comparison with the three great Greek tragedians: Aeschylus, Sophocles, and Euripides.

- 6.18** Then, comedy, well, comedy is much more contextual, much more tied to the particular circumstances. Comedy doesn't speak quite as much as tragedy or epic does to universal human aspirations. A lot more of it is to do with the local. As you'll see, if you're reading a comedy by Aristophanes, it's hard going because there are all these complicated references to different politicians and who's fallen out with whom. So it's an amazing slice of evidence for the social life, the inner social life of Athenian society. But it requires lots of notes and checking who is who and so on, which is not the case with tragedy and epic, that is, generally, to do with familiar eternal myths with fixed characters and fixed plot patterns.
- 6.19** Anyway, Aristotle thinks he's come up with a solution to what holds or what distinguishes these as human forms of expression. His answer is that in each case, we have mimesis. In each case, there is an attempt to imitate the world or imitate behavior in some way, or represent the world in some way, imitate it. Aristotle says it's not just when you're doing a painting of something or writing a book about something or doing a play about a topic, mimesis isn't copying. You're not just copying; you're not copying and pasting. You are creating, you're representing, and you're capturing and trying to discern universal patterns in what is being represented.
- 6.20** In putting on display patterns of behavior and circumstances that are universal or, in principle, universal to human beings, you are creating something valuable. You're creating something with pedagogical power, something with formative power. There are different ways you can imitate something, says Aristotle. There's a question of what you imitate with. Is it going to be music? Is it going to be words? Is it going to be rhythm? What do you imitate? It could be you imitating virtuous actions or vicious ones, ignoble ones.
- 6.21** Then, there's a question of how you do it. If it's epic poetry, it will be narration. Narration will be the mode. It'll be, as it were, god, narrator, explaining "there, at the beginning, being inspired by the muse," and then telling the story. But the whole epic is under his authorial command. Versus drama, which is more you convey the mimesis, you convey the representation through just dramatic enactment.
- 6.22** There are actually multiple—there's one playwright, but the playwright surrenders his authorial voice to a whole cast of different characters. You might say that the authorial voice lingers in the Greek chorus, this group of people who would originally have been participants in the religious delegation of the feast of the Dionysia. The chorus has a very interesting role in Greek tragedy. They are both us, the audience, but also they have intimations of what's going to happen, which only the author could probably have. It's a very interesting, dramatic function that the chorus has in a narrative and plot function that it has in all Greek tragedies. It's probably the thing that we're least familiar with when we go and watch a Greek tragedy, the chorus element. But it's both a hangover from the religious origins of tragedy, of the goat song religious festivals, but

it also provides such a useful role that it lasted well beyond the point it really needed to.

- 6.23** Just to backtrack a little bit, because contrast is the mother of clarity, and we want to understand why Aristotle is writing the Poetics, often in quite a defensive way. For that, we need to understand what Plato had against the artists and the poets. Why did he ban them? It's a lovely book on this by the novelist, Iris Murdoch, called *The Fire and the Sun: Why Plato Banished the Artists*, the fire being the world of the cave and the sun being the world outside.
- 6.24** The basic argument that Plato advances is that poets make it harder to unchain ourselves from the world of the cave that we're chained together in and forced to look at the flickering flames cast on the back wall and think of them as reality—this is what he thinks the poets are doing, effectively. Poets are conjuring up a cinema screen on the back of the cave and mesmerizing us, entrancing us into this world with all its contingencies, its transience, its instability.
- 6.25** The task of the philosopher is to release people from the chains and bring them up outside into the light of pure clarity, pure access to the good, to the true, to the beautiful, and so on and so forth, which is achieved through philosophical learning. But the poets are the ones who are sketching on the back walls of the cave. They are creating—the prisoners are mesmerized by the flickering flames or whatever the equivalent would be today, maybe Netflix screenplays, Netflix shows, that for Plato, this is a way the poets are complicit in creating an illusory reality for most people. They're creating a world of fiction, of illusion. Plato says that's bad. It's taking us away from what's true and what's real.
- 6.26** True reality, of course, for Plato is the unchanging Forms, illuminated by the sun outside the cave. The physical world is less than perfect. They're imperfect copies or instantiations of the Forms. They're in time, they're in space. If they're living organisms, they'll eventually die. If they're not living organisms, then they're inert, and they're always going to be changed. They can always rust; they always degenerate. And so this line emerges—
- 6.27** And then, when art comes in, when the artist, the representation kicks in, for Plato, it's a representation of a copy of an eternal Form. In Plato's system, he said, "Art is thrice removed from truth." Three times it removes itself from truth. Because on the Platonic view, you might have the eternal, unchanging Form of goodness or of courage or whatever it might be. It's then exemplified, or in some mysterious way, instantiated in a particular thing, a particular courageous person, a particular good person. That's, if you like, one remove. And then, the second remove is when the artist attempts to represent the copy through doing effectively another copy in Plato's view. It's another, as it were, veil placed between the ultimately real realm of the Forms and the knower. Then, the third time is the conveying of the representation to the audience.

- 6.28** So in Plato's view, you've got this constant erosion of contact with the real, constant undermining of our access to what's really real. Remember, this is why Plato's so insistent on doing lots and lots of mathematics and geometry, because he thinks if you've done years and years of that, you've got used to short-circuiting all of that and going straight to the Forms, going straight to the world of the timeless and the necessary, and and that which is without beginning and without end, namely numbers. That, Plato thinks, is a way of trying to get to real knowledge, which is philosophical knowledge, which, again, doesn't require any messy intermediaries in this "here today, gone tomorrow," concrete, physical universe, which is always unstable, always changing.
- 6.29** Plato's critique is that art deals with shadows of shadows, you might say, and it doesn't deliver the truth, the unvarnished truth, the unvarnished contact with reality. That means that artists tend not to have any knowledge. They don't have any *epistēmē* in Plato's sense. They're much better at trafficking in illusion and opinion, or the Greek word for which is *doxa*.
- 6.30** So he concludes that in any city dedicated to truth, which it must be, and Plato takes it for granted, that every city must be focused on and dedicated to truth. Poetry gets in the way. Poetry doesn't add any value at all. Quite the reverse, it undermines a shared pursuit, a communal pursuit of the truth. He will say, of tragedy, tragedy makes us weep, which is not good for Plato. It makes us sympathize with weakness, which again, Plato thinks is a bad thing. It feeds the irrational part of the soul. The emotions for Plato are irrational as opposed to non-rational. Comedy, bawdy comedy, makes us laugh at vice and normalizes vice. It leads us to lower our standards.
- 6.31** Then, epic, he doesn't like because it shows the gods are doing terrible things, doing things that are unworthy of gods: Zeus is adulterous, Zeus being hen-pecked, or Aphrodite having a tantrum on the battlefield in, I think, it's Book V of the *Iliad*. That's not good. It's not good for civic religion because we've got to have a respect for the gods because that's what upholds our moral universe.
- 6.32** What is Aristotle's response to this? The first obvious point to note is that he doesn't accept Plato's view that there are Forms up there outside the cave, outside, as it were, space-time, outside the physical world, which are then refracted down into this world. So Aristotle doesn't have that problem when he's analyzing artistic representation, the Forms are in the things that are being represented, that are being written about in the tragedy or painted about in the painting or written about in the novel.
- 6.33** Then, what Aristotle says—this is a very clever move. He says that what the artist is doing is not copying particular things in the world. What the artist is doing is extracting and representing the Forms or the universals that Aristotle now sees as taking out of Plato's heaven and putting in the particular thing. That's what art is focusing on. It's focusing on representing universals, things that we can recognize everywhere.

- 6.34** Poetry is not interested in showing us what did happen, but in what might happen, helping us to think counterfactually in imaginative scenarios. That's why he has this interesting line that poetry is more philosophical than history. With history, you've got to take what you're given. The facts are the facts. What happened is what happened. The events are just the events that occurred. We could try to make sense of them in some ways. We can try to look for patterns and so on. But poetry doesn't have any of those constraints. Poetry has all the limits of the imagination. It can conjure up different scenarios that can get our moral or imaginative juices flowing as we think creatively about different scenarios, different problems.
- 6.35** And so fundamentally, for Plato, the poet is a copier, somebody just copies stuff, imitates it badly. But for Aristotle, the poet is a creator, is discerning patterns. The good poet, anyway, is a creator. That's what the word means, *poietes* in Greek simply means "one who makes," one who creates. What the artist is doing, on Aristotle's view, is creating something distinct that is not simply a bland copy, but is discerning and representing universal features of reality, universal truths about the human condition. In that sense, Aristotle says art is closer to truth than, say, history. It's closer to the truth than those who are just involved in copying.
- 6.36** Aristotle then goes on to address this question about emotions and Plato's allergy and his deep skepticism and suspicion about the emotions. What he says is that you can get good emotions and bad emotions. Emotions by themselves are not corrupting. It's not something that needs to be completely suppressed. It's good, says Aristotle, that tragedy arouses our sense of pity and our sense of fear.
- 6.37** Why? Because he thinks what that brings about when we see representations of somebody in a terrible condition or somebody in a condition that is terrible, and that we think there's no obvious reason why I myself wouldn't experience that scenario, this combination of pity and fear, says Aristotle, brings about catharsis—is the Greek word he uses: *catharsis*. It's a purgation or a cleansing or even a clarification, perhaps. But it's something that happens in a controlled setting. You're dealing with—you're awakening and exciting powerful emotions of grief and terror and sympathy. But it's done in this formalized, ritualized context, a very socially specific context of different parts of the city sitting on different rows. It's an education in controlling and navigating intense emotional experiences. The idea is, for Aristotle, this is a good thing. This is educational. This is a way of forming the moral impulses of the citizenry.
- 6.38** He then argues against Plato that it's not that poetry and drama undermine the city, undermine the polis. It's quite the reverse. Because it's got that teaching function, it teaches us what practical wisdom is, what it looks like, or what it doesn't look like—reverse examples are just as effective. It provides that broad shared cultural education, which is so important in any society, certainly in any high-trust flourishing society at ease with itself. It, broadly speaking, shares a common culture. So, that's a little bit about the implicit exchange, the implicit response of Aristotle to Plato.

- 6.39** Let's move on to think more deeply about what's going on with mimesis and imitation and why Aristotle thinks it's so important. He stresses that it's central to human beings from childhood. We're constantly imitating. We learn primarily in the beginning just through imitating, through mimesis. That's how children learn language and behavior, skills. We're much more imitative, we're much more mimetic than any other animal. Even though other animals also imitate each other in significant ways.
- 6.40** There's a cognitive pleasure in imitation. There's a recognition, understanding, and even representations of painful things can give pleasure or can give that satisfaction. We can even enjoy realistic paintings of very ugly things, of gargoyles. And works of art—you think of those melting faces in Michelangelo's paintwork in the Sistine Chapel, of Adam and Eve walking off in their banishment from Eden. There's something hideous about what Michelangelo has depicted there, but also it's mesmerizing in its artistic power.
- 6.41** We delight in imitation. The question is: What is that delight? Where does the pleasure come from? It's not in the thing itself. A portrait of a very well-executed portrait of a corpse is not—the subject matter is disgusting, it disgusts us, revolts us. One is not taking pleasure in that. What we're taking pleasure in is the accuracy of the representation, the way that it has been depicted and, as it were, brought to our imagination through the interpretation of the artist who's discerning certain patterns that can be conveyed to us in a way that reality, just witnessing it, the corpse on its own, would not make possible.
- 6.42** There's a paradox here. There's a strange paradox in taking delight from, or taking pleasure from, sad films or tragic films or films that don't have a happy ending. "How can that be pleasurable?" Asks Aristotle. For Aristotle, what gives pleasure is the control that we can exercise over our emotions and over our emotional reaction to this weeping movie. Because we know we're at one remove, so there's distance, and the distance the representation affords us changes the experience. It allows us to control it, to keep it distant from impinging. We know that it doesn't impinge on our own lives. The cognitive framing—this is an imitation, this is a fiction, it's just a film—gives us the right context for us to allow our heartstrings to be pulled and our emotions to be manipulated and moved, but not to a degree that might be the case if the framing of the imitation was not already understood.
- 6.43** We then move on. Aristotle then moves on to talk about this big section on mimesis and representation. Then, he zooms in immediately on tragedy, a long, long discussion of what tragedy is. He tries to define it, tries to break down each element. His famous definition from Book VI of the Poetics is, "Tragedy is an imitation of an action that is serious, complete, and of a certain magnitude." What does he mean by all that? Well, "it's an imitation of an action," not of a person, but of action, praxis, things happening in the world, things that people do in the world. That's what action is: things happening that people bring about. It's the "imitation of an action,"—mimesis of an action—"that

is serious,"—deals with important concerns, life, death, justice—" that's complete,"—so beginning, middle, and an end, it's got an integrity to it. It's got a wholeness, a completeness—"and certain magnitude"—not quite sure what it means by this, but it's got to be long enough to matter, long enough to occupy our attention, not a YouTube short, but short enough for us to grasp as a single unity.

- 6.44** Anyone who's tried to read the Mahabharata, the great Indian epic, which runs to—I think it's about five or six Iliads long, it's nearly 50,000-60,000 lines. It's very difficult to keep your bearings when you're trying to read that. It can't be too long, but it can't be too short. So, the right magnitude, the right length. In fact, almost all Greek tragedies range from being 1,000 lines long to about 1,800 lines long. So it would have taken a maximum of two and a half hours, probably maximum, maybe two and a half hours per play. But then the plays tended to be formed in threes, often as trilogies. We've only got one trilogy that survived, sadly. So it would have been quite quick, like the length of a film, the length of a movie.
- 6.45** Aristotle goes on to say that the language of tragedy is going to have certain characteristics, certain unusual characteristics. It will be more poetic, it will be more embellished, it will have a higher register, more dignified. There'll be rhythm, there'll be music. There was a lot of music accompanying the choral odes.
- 6.46** The choruses would often break into song, and there would be an orchestra, which was the circular bit in front of the skene, in front of the main stage, around which the chorus would process in circles, sometimes going in one direction—it was called a strophe, where they do one verse of the ode—and then they'd do an anti-strophe, they'd turn around and they'd go in the opposite direction, and they'd be singing all these odes of foreboding about what's going to happen to this terrible hero: "Oh, I haven't got a good feeling about this," or, "She shouldn't have said that," or "Oh, the gods, you've got to come down and help." So they're guiding our response almost in advance and crystallizing the audience response.
- 6.47** But also, as an actor, sometimes the chorus is an actor in the play. It's going to have a dialogue with the characters. It's very interesting. So the language will be elevated. Then you'll have the choral songs. And then you'll have the dialogue. You'll have particularly stichomythia. Stichomythia is just line-by-line exchanges between characters. It can be very, very effective. The one between Clytemnestra and Agamemnon, as it's building up to his murder, is just astonishing.
- 6.48** Sometimes you'll have beautiful, longer speeches. Early on, it's very primitive. I mean, with Aeschylus—Aeschylus, I think, is the first to introduce, I think, a third actor on stage. For a long time, it was just two. You had the protagonistes, the first actor, the protagonist, and the deuteragonistes, the second agonist, the deuteragonist. For a long time, it was at most two people on stage at one time. I think it's Aeschylus who introduces a third. Maybe it was Sophocles. I should check that, fact-check that. But it gradually evolves into a richer and larger cast. But the chorus is always there.

- 6.49 So, you've got the language, you've got this variety between the dialogue, speeches, and choral odes. The function, the telos, the ultimate goal for Aristotle, again, is that through tragedy, we excite feelings of fear and pity that bring about catharsis. As I said, this is the purgation and clarification. Aristotle goes on to look at what counts as a good tragedy. We don't need to go into all the details there, but he focuses, in particular, on this idea of imitating action. That means that because tragedy is the imitation of action, the most important thing in a tragedy is plot. How does it go? How are the actions arranged? That's the most important thing.
- 6.50 If tragedy is imitating action, then the plot is the key thing that is coming out at the end of the process of representing the action in reality. He has these long discussions: What are good plots? What are bad plots? You can see that this is clearly somebody who enjoys going to the theater a lot. He's thought very, very carefully about it. So good plots, he says, they've got to be unified. They've got to all fit together. You can't have too many loose ends and too many subplots and so on. It's got to be one single focus, one action.
- 6.51 Some examples of this, he says, Sophocles's play, *Oedipus Rex*, *Oedipus the King*, is very good on unity. You've basically got one action: Who murdered Laius? It turns out to be Oedipus, and then everything unravels from there. But that's the central focus of the whole play. Everything is oriented around that one action. Also, in *Oedipus*, every revelation brings another revelation. It's like a domino effect. There's this sense of momentum. Everything unfolds almost as it has to. There's no randomness. There's this awesome predictability about what's going to happen. We know what's going to happen. We're told what's going to happen very often by the chorus, or certainly they intimate what's going to happen.
- 6.52 And it's got to make sense. The plot's got to have an ending that's not too wildly improbable, which certainly is the case in *Oedipus Rex*. We can understand Oedipus's obsession with reaching the end of his quest, but we can also understand his naivety and how he ends up where he is. But there's an organic unity. Everything is very tightly constructed. Nothing, not a line, is wasted. You compare that to a play or two by Euripides, his play *Iphigenia in Tauris*, for example, which is all over the place. It's got lots of different subplots. It's not clear what's unifying the whole play. It's not as tightly integrated as *Oedipus Rex*.
- 6.53 Then, long discussions, too, about what counts as a bad plot. Aristotle says, that's where you haven't got any necessary connection between the scenes. Things happen that are improbable, that don't fit, that don't work. This is what our intuitions would be about what counts as a weak plot. And he gives various examples of what plays that he thinks are terrible, where there's just a randomness in the plotting and a sense of improbability in the resolution and so on.
- 6.54 One can play a game. One can imagine which modern films best satisfy these different criteria: unity of plot, necessity, that is to say, things follow very naturally one on the

other, and then probability, you haven't got any wild, rabid out of the hat solutions that you couldn't possibly have anticipated, resolving all the tensions within the plot of the film. These are the thoughts that Aristotle explores as he's trying to pin down the nature of art and then specifically the nature of tragedy, and then what is it within tragedy that counts— what is it that makes a good tragedy and why?

- 6.55** He goes through this list of criteria, and he says that not only do you need a good plot, but you also need good characters, characters that can't be too good, they can't be too perfect. They've got to be plausible, they've got to be relatable. If something bad happens to a really perfect person, then that's shocking, says Aristotle, but not tragic. It shocks us, but somehow it's not a tragedy.
- 6.56** The characters, the heroes, are virtuous, high-achieving, often sincere, but there's some fatal weakness or something that their sense of honor has blinded them to, or some terrible fate which has been decreed, as in the case of Oedipus—the Oracle has spoken, and there's no way of, it doesn't matter if you exile yourself from your land and you try to get away from everything, it'll still come back to hit you as it does with Oedipus.
- 6.57** So character is important, and the way characters reason and argue is important because it shows and it models to the audience, to the people, to the citizens, how to go about arguing, how to go about disputation and reasoning and deliberation. Other things to get right, he says, is the melos, the music, the melody of the tragedies, is very important.
- 6.58** The spectacle is perhaps the least important thing for Aristotle, but it's important that there are visual elements, costumes, scenery, special effects. But Aristotle says these are the least artistic elements. He says that a good tragedy should work without any costumes, without any stage design, without any special effects. A good tragedy should not need those. That's the least important thing, the least important feature.
- 6.59** There are other, more general features of tragedy that Aristotle brings out when it comes to thinking about plot structure and catharsis. He says, simple plots, there are complex plots, but generally speaking, you've got two dynamics within Greek tragedy: one is reversal or peripeteia—everything gets blown up, everything turns upside down, peripeteia—and/or recognition, some recognition scene, which resolves all sorts of things or throws up all kinds of new problems; that's anagnorisis, A-N-A-G-N-O-R-I-S-I-S, anagnorisis: knowing, cognosco, and ana is "again," so "knowing again."
- 6.60** Simple plots might be Aeschylus's Prometheus Bound. Prometheus is in chains at the beginning. He's pretty much in chains at the end. He suffers throughout. There's no reversal of fortune. Life is terrible at the beginning of the play for Prometheus, and it's pretty terrible at the end of the play, and it just goes down and down towards eternal punishment. A simple plot. Aristotle likes that. It's just very simple, nothing complicated.

- 6.61** I was trying to think of an analogy to this, but I remember it was a film that didn't do that well when it came out. It was in the mid '90s, 1995, but I thought it was very powerful at the time. I think Nicolas Cage might have won an Oscar for it. It's called *Leaving Las Vegas*. It wasn't a blockbuster, probably because it had a very, very simple plot, which was an alcoholic writer who goes to Las Vegas and drinks himself to death. The film is about him drinking himself to death, and the pain that that causes his loved ones, a brilliant performance exploring the psychology of the alcoholic. But it ends as it begins, as with *Prometheus*. He's in a terrible state at the beginning; he's in a terrible state at the end. There's no moment of shock. We just sit back and just are in awe of the slow, simple, inexorable descent.
- 6.62** More complex plots would be ones that include a peripeteia or anagnorisis. What's great about *Oedipus Rex*, Aristotle's favorite tragedy, or the one that he thinks is the most paradigm of a tragedy, of a successful tragedy, *Oedipus Rex*, where, I think, you've got two reversals. You've got one where the honored king becomes the polluted outcast after the Oracle. Then there's another reversal when Oedipus discovers that he is the murderer that he's been seeking all this time, the murderer of his father. Actually, both happen simultaneously in the single recognition scene.
- 6.63** You do have this in modern films, moments where—an example that someone shared with me was another film from the 1990s, *The Sixth Sense*. Sorry to spoil the very big twist for you, if you haven't seen it already. It's a wonderful film. It is dated a little bit, 1999, it was. In effect, the film rests on a scene right towards the end where this child psychologist, I think he was, discovers that he is, in fact, not alive but dead. He's been working with this young boy who's got a sixth sense, a capacity to see beyond the land of the living.
- 6.64** The film is effectively a long, extended dialogue scene, an acting scene with this little boy, who, he thinks is suffering from some terrible condition, but he doesn't recognize, doesn't understand that the only reason the boy can talk with him and can see him is because he is able to see him as a dead person. It's an incredible moment right at the end of the film, where you have both this strange self-recognition, "Oh, my goodness, the reason he can see me is because I'm not alive, and everything else has just been—" everything else gets turned upside down.
- 6.65** It's quite an interesting example of an anagnorisis, an extreme moment of recognition. And then, the whole thing falls apart, like his whole life, everything falls apart, but also gets resolved. This is what makes plots complex. This is what makes him different from *Prometheus Bound* or *Leaving Las Vegas*. It introduces a complexity to the plot, something unexpected, changing towards an opposite direction.
- 6.66** There's other features, other general features, to mention. One that's very important for Aristotle is pathos, or the sense of suffering or emotional sympathy that great art can convey. Aristotle thinks that it's good for those things to be imitated and to be watched. Even if the action is very painful, it's like a wounding or a torture scene, it's

still important. You think of the effects of very graphic scenes in modern cinema. When I think of the opening twenty minutes of *Saving Private Ryan*, 1998, the D-Day landings on Omaha Beach in particular. That film would not be the same without it. It was necessary to watch. It was difficult to watch, but necessary in some ways to understand what war is like using modern technology as best we can to create that mimesis, to create that imitation.

6.67 One is enriched by watching those horrors, hopefully not too many times, but you get a sense of it in a way that gives you greater moral clarity about the significance of war, the horrors of war, the reality of war, but in a way that's controlled. Again, because this is drama, it's just a film, it's a cinema, it's a way of learning about emotions in a safe context, you might say. I don't really like using the word "safe" to apply to psychology, but it's a controlled environment, it's a controlled domain. It's a cultural form, and there are conventions around it. You know everything's going to end well because eventually you get up out of your seat, and you put your popcorn away, and you go home. Everything has that context. Because it's secure, we can then gaze into the human heart and human passions and suffering and horrors, unimaginable horrors. But because it's got that proper control domain, we can control and calibrate the way in which it affects us and the way in which it changes us.

6.68 Another example—I watched this over Easter for the first time in over 20 years. It was Mel Gibson's *The Passion of the Christ*. I gathered a few students in Cambridge to watch it. We watched it on Good Friday. I had forgotten how graphic the film is. It's extremely explicit, scenes of violence, terrible scenes. One of the students had to leave and felt very ill. There's a lot of debate about whether or not this was too much. Gibson and his historical advisors defended it. They said, "This is the best we can recreate it."

6.69 We have actually fairly good evidence of how the Romans went about crucifixion and scourging, in particular, the practice of scourging, and the number of times, and all the different whips that were used, and so on and so forth. What does that do? Was it too much? There were some theologians, some church leaders criticized it for saying this is focusing too much on the physical suffering of Christ, when the true suffering was a spiritual one, a disconnection with God, and so on and so forth. Nevertheless, there's no question that the depiction of ugliness, of pain and suffering, has a very powerful, in that case, theological function to play, to give a sense within the Christian imagination of the cost of the cross.

6.70 So, we've looked at a whole range of aspects of general theories, general ways or ideals that tragedy, not just tragedy, but all artistic forms, should seek to emulate. Aristotle's work in literary theory, artistic theory, and his study of tragedies, in a way, is one of the best examples of how he escapes from the shadow of Plato, how he takes on a very clear, unambiguous claim that Plato is advancing in his work about the proper place of musicians and artists within any society—that is, none. Aristotle is much more, I think, fully worked out and much more plausible conception of how art, how poetry, how

music, how drama can define who we are, can shape our judgments, and help us to lead better and more morally-attuned lives.

Lecture 7: Aristotle's Revival

At a glance — Aristotle's revival — the recovery and influence of his thought.

- 7.1 Welcome to Lecture 7 in the series, Aristotle: From Logic to Life. What we're going to do in the final two lectures of this series is examine Aristotle's impact, his afterlives, if you like, in subsequent philosophy. I said at the beginning of the series that in some ways, Aristotle's thought encompasses almost all of European philosophy in some ways. Aristotle's fingerprints are all over the subsequent history of Western philosophy.
- 7.2 What sets him apart as a philosopher is that his fingerprints are also on a wide range of other streams in different domains all through Western thought. In the natural sciences, in rhetoric, in logic—a very specific area of philosophy, in ethics and in politics, in poetics and literary theory, in philosophy of nature, in psychology—questions to do with the mind, in theology, and so on and so forth.
- 7.3 There are very few thinkers we can compare Aristotle to in terms of the scale of that achievement. Plato, in many ways, maybe he has the edge. There's that famous line of Alfred North Whitehead, the Cambridge philosopher of science who emigrated to the States in the 1920s, said: "The safest general characterization of European philosophy is that it consists in a series of footnotes to Plato." Footnotes to Plato—that's the estimation of Plato's impact on European philosophy.
- 7.4 But I think you could probably say that the safest general characterization of European thought, certainly in the humanities and in the sciences, at least up until the end of the 19th century, consists in a series of footnotes to Aristotle. In many ways, the story of philosophy after Aristotle is the story of how you deal with Aristotle. That's his legacy, not just in philosophy, but across all of these different disciplines. We'll come on to discuss the specifics, but Aristotle for a long time is lost to European thought for several hundred years.
- 7.5 When he's brought back—and I'll tell you the fascinating story of how the texts were moved across the Mediterranean and how they were transported and how they ended up being translated into Latin, which was obviously the dominant language of Europe at the time. Once that happens, in a few short decades, it has an explosive impact on European Christendom. Vast new universities—it transforms the universities. It transforms and threatens, in some ways, the church. It has an enormous impact. It unleashes scientific inquiry. It's the first time that the medieval mind has, as it were, had logic presented to it in ways that it can be formalized and understood. In rhetoric, commentaries on the Nicomachean Ethics are enormously important, and so on and so forth.
- 7.6 Remember that this is a time where there's no Plato, there's almost nothing, no inheritance, really, from the ancient world. So, just to observe the impact of that

explosive impact of Aristotle on the whole of Europe in a few decades is a sign of what an extraordinary mind and figure he really is.

- 7.7 In this lecture, we'll be looking, really, at the older afterlives of Aristotle moving through the fourth, third, second, first century BC, and then into the first millennium. We'll be looking at the emergence of Christian philosophy, of theologically confident philosophical appropriations of Aristotle, the tensions that Aristotle brings against Abrahamic monotheism and creationist metaphysical frameworks. Then, we'll move into the Middle Ages, where he really gets rediscovered after vanishing for 300, 400 years.
- 7.8 We'll also look at some fascinating things that are happening in Baghdad at the time. Baghdad emerges in the middle of the eighth century AD as the center of the Abbasid Caliphate, and it becomes an extraordinary hub for scholarship and for learning, building up libraries, and extraordinary scholarly communities. A lot of it fed, as it were—the engine room for Baghdad's intellectual efflorescence and its cultural efflorescence is really the texts of Aristotle that survive in Syriac and in Arabic. So some fascinating detours there.
- 7.9 Then, in the final lecture, we'll move into the 20th century and look at the impact that Aristotle's revenge is having on two big domains within contemporary philosophy. One is in ethics and in questions about virtue, and the other is in metaphysics—questions about causes and substances and forms and essences and so on and so forth. But we'll get to that in the next lecture.
- 7.10 For now, let's go back to the fourth century BC, and that rather sad moment when Aristotle died. We don't quite know of what, some stomach disease. Age—I think he was 62. He died a year after Alexander the Great in 323 BC, his great pupil. The anti-Macedonian backlash that followed Alexander's death is probably what accounts for Aristotle, as it were, going into self-imposed exile for the second time, a 100 miles or so to the east on the island of Euboea or Evia, as it's called these days, in his mom's place in Chalcis.
- 7.11 A guy called Theophrastus takes over at the Lyceum. He's Aristotle's successor back in Athens, his most brilliant student. He kept the research program going. He kept focusing on botany and so on. Then there's this fascinating story, a question as to: How does Aristotle's corpus of works survive? Or the bits that have survived, how did they survive?
- 7.12 Well, a lot of the works that were designed for public consumption have been lost to us, are lost to us, almost all of them. We've got virtually nothing. All we have is the more technical treatises designed really for internal use, probably within a library or within the Lyceum. Those are really the texts that we've got today: the Physics, the Metaphysics, the Ethics, the Politics, and so on and so forth. You can tell, just through reading them, that often it's repetitive, or the transitions are very abrupt, the way it's

structured and organized is sometimes a little bit confused. It reads more like a set of very informed lecture notes or transcripts. It doesn't have the polish of Plato.

- 7.13** It's certainly commentators, people like Cicero, who later on talk about the golden river, the golden wave of eloquence that you get when reading Aristotle. There's no text of Aristotle that survived, that we know of, that could bear that comparison. Cicero clearly meant what he said. It's a golden wave, how beautiful his style is and his philosophical eloquence. There's just no way you can look at the text that we have got and say that this is a golden wave, a golden tsunami of eloquence. Theophrastus takes over the manuscripts and so on.
- 7.14** The key context, I think, that explains the survival of Aristotle's text is, I think, partly the authority that, having been a tutor to Alexander the Great, he had invested in him, and crucially, also the emerging infrastructure at Alexandria—in particular, a Library and a Mouseion that opened up. This was called a Mouseion. That is to say, a place for the Muses, a place where the Muses can be, where one can take inspiration from the Muses. So Alexandria is a city. It is founded by Alexander in 331 BC after he has defeated all of Egypt. And in the early third century, in the 290s, 280s BC, a library is founded there, and the Mouseion, which is like an Institute for Advanced Studies at Princeton or like an All Souls College, Oxford. It's for elite scholars.
- 7.15** We're pretty sure that both the Lyceum—sorry, both the Library of Alexandria and the Mouseion were modeled in some way after Aristotle's Lyceum. We think that it's got a lot of overlap in the way it was structured, and the way it was understood, and the way it was managed. We know that Aristotle's works were aggressively collected for this library, and not least, I think the Alexandria connection would have been a very important motivating factor for that.
- 7.16** There were a lot of commentators as his work gets arranged. The key figure here is Andronicus of Rhodes, who, in the first century BC, for all sorts of interesting reasons—effectively, Sulla, the first great dictator in the Roman Republic, in 86 BC, marches on Athens and captures it. He captures a very important library, the library of Apellicon, and takes it to Rome. For the first time, Aristotle is available to Roman scholars, Roman thinkers, Roman eggheads, you might say. This is around about the time Cicero would have come into contact with him. Cicero is at his peak. He was beheaded in 43 BC. But before that, he would have been aware of Andronicus's work on Aristotle.
- 7.17** Andronicus is the first to do a systematic edition of the texts that certainly have made it down to us. He organizes them all. So he puts all those logical tracks to do with logic into the Organon, creates that toolbox that we talked about in Lecture 2. He organizes all Aristotle's natural philosophy—so the work on the Physics and causation and change and substance and so on. His work on Meteorology, De Caelo, On the Heavens. This is why a lot of the names are Latin rather than Greek, because it's Andronicus titling them. He's giving them the Latin version, Latin translation.

- 7.18** On Generation and Corruption of Animals—this is his work on animal embryology and so on and so forth. The work on psychology, the Metaphysics, ta meta ta physika, as it were, what comes after the Physics. Andronicus seems to have done some arranging there, including folding in some bits you shouldn't have folded in. Then, the Ethics and then the Politics, two treatises on Ethics and then Politics. As I was saying in the lecture on politics, it breaks off in the middle of Book VIII on this fascinating discussion about education, and then the Poetics and the Rhetoric.
- 7.19** This is what creates the canon, if you like, of Aristotelian thought. This becomes a pretty fixed, stable basket of texts, which really are the only ones, 30 odd, that make it through out of 150. Stylistically, they're definitely his—they're either not written by him, but by his students, or they're not written with any attempt to make them polished and fluid and fluent. But that's what's made it down.
- 7.20** The famous Oxford translation of Aristotle is in two big volumes, maybe, probably 800, 900 pages each, edited by Jonathan Barnes. You can have all of Aristotle in two quite fat volumes. You can have all of Plato in one fat volume, about 35 dialogues plus about 10 letters or so, only some of which are authentic. But that's probably about half the corpus. Plato's corpus is about half the length of Aristotle's corpus. Though we know that Aristotle's was five times as big as that. Quite extraordinary.
- 7.21** When you think of the challenges of getting things down and writing in that period. Whereas I think with Plato, there are a few lost dialogues, but not many. We're confident we've got most of Plato. That's the context, really, at the pivot between the first millennium BC and the first millennium AD. There's a preservation of Aristotle through the first century, the second century, some very gifted scholars emerging and librarians emerging in Alexandria, including Alexander of Aphrodisias, who's probably the most important ancient commentator on Aristotle. You have all these commentary traditions opening up.
- 7.22** Just to say a little word about commentaries. The function of the commentary was effectively to distill and extract and apply Aristotle's ideas to the particular intellectual context in which the commentator was. When you think of commentaries, it's almost like a translation. It's a way of trying to render Aristotle's thought accessible to your particular intellectual milieu. In 13th-century Paris, it's the Latin translations, and that's the primary focus, and the challenge is trying to reconcile Aristotelian ideas with ideas in Christian doctrine.
- 7.23** Probably the most famous point of tension is the discovery that Aristotle believed that the world was eternal and stretched eternally far back into the past. That obviously clashes with an absolutely central commitment within not just Christianity, but all three Abrahamic monotheisms, that time began, that the world comes into being in the beginning. God created the heavens and the earth.

- 7.24** And the argument is, does this mean a temporal beginning? Or does it mean God is the ultimate source of our eternally existing universe? Where you stood on those issues—was it more Aristotle or was it more towards the institutional authorities, whether it's within Christendom or whether it's within Islam or Judaism; all three monotheisms wrestle with this problem—where you land on that will determine how controversial you are, particularly in the 13th century, when condemnations of Aristotle start to emerge, formal condemnations.
- 7.25** There are obvious points of tension and collision, that's in the Latin context, but also in Baghdad. There are certain things that Islamic theology starts to wrestle with that are not immediately reconcilable with Aristotle. There are tensions that are sparked off there. One great Islamic thinker, Averroës, suggests this doctrine almost of two truths. There's Aristotle's truth, and then there's Quran's revealed truth. We've got to operate as they are, as it were, distinct domains.
- 7.26** That may sound odd, but it's worth remembering that the great—I think he's the great Harvard evolutionary biologist and psychologist, Stephen Jay Gould, used to talk about the relationship between science and religion in terms of we should need to think about them as NOMA: non-overlapping magisterial authorities. Science has its own domain, its own magisterial domain, and religion has its own domain, and they're not overlapping. Averroës has effectively tried to run something like this. He said that Aristotle's domain is one magisteria, and it doesn't overlap with revealed truth, revealed wisdom.
- 7.27** Aristotle turbocharges the Islamic intellectual enlightenment that follows the founding and development of the Abbasid caliphate in Baghdad in the mid-8th century. Lots of figures we could touch on here. Al-Farabi is probably the first major thinker who really shows Aristotle's influence, demonstrates Aristotle's influence, comprehensive commentaries on Aristotle, tries to harmonize Aristotle with Islamic revelation, argues for compatibility between Greek philosophy and the Quran, develops some very interesting reflections on God's necessity and the divine intellect, and effectively puts Aristotelian logic at the heart of Islamic lawmaking, jurisprudence, and Islamic theology. It really becomes—his commentaries become a foundation for later Islamic Aristotelianism.
- 7.28** Then there's Avicenna or Ibn Sina. Avicenna is his Latin name, Ibn Sina in Arabic—enormously influential. He doesn't just take up Aristotelian metaphysics. He develops it. He fuses it with Islamic theology and Islamic philosophical theology in a way that genuinely transforms it, makes new moves.
- 7.29** He develops a very interesting argument for the existence of God from God as a necessary being, something like a cosmological argument. He says that for every contingent created being, we can say that its essence is distinct from its existence. That is to say, "what it is" is different from "that it is." There's nothing to do with existence that is baked into what kind of thing it is. And so it might not have existed. It might not

have existed. There's nothing in its nature that makes it exist because of what it is, in virtue of what it is. That's the case for everything in space-time, everything in the created order.

- 7.30** Therefore, there must be some explanation. These contingent beings must be explained by something else because it didn't just pop into being out of nothing. There must be some source of origination which they're dependent on, or were dependent on at some point. You can go all the way back and conceptually—argues Avicenna—you get in the end, you must get in the end to a being for whom essence and existence are one and the same. The only thing that's going to stop the infinite regress is a being whose nature is to exist, a being where you can say that the fact that he exists, if he is what he is, the essence of God, the essence of this being, must be that he exists no matter what, that it's part of his being to exist, and that's what we call God.
- 7.31** At this point, it's just a philosophical argument to some necessary being, and that necessary being is certainly not the complete God of Abrahamic monotheism. It's really an Aristotelian God, a neo-Aristotelian God. But it's probably too thick a slice of God for the atheist digestive system. It's an argument for theism from Aristotle. Now, it's not an argument for Islamic theism or for Christian theism or for Jewish theism, but at this point, the monotheist will take it. It's like, "That's fine. We can deal with the specifics later. We're just trying to get theism on the table here, and this is a good way to get it on the table. And then, we can worry about the specifics later on. This is a good interfaith dialog. This is a productive interfaith dialogue," the only productive kind in my experience.
- 7.32** So important contributions from Avicenna, and there are many others that we could touch on. He is very committed to the idea of Aristotle's *De Anima* and this notion of ensoulment and reason being the highest form of ensoulment. There's some interesting arguments about how separable individual souls are from the body, which, of course, is a crucial tension that Aristotle throws up.
- 7.33** Remember with hylomorphism, what it is to be a human person is to be made up of the *hylē*—stuff, matter—and the *morphē*—the shape, like the bronzes with the sculptor's blueprint fused. So that made it very hard to make sense of life after death because if who you are is that embodied thing or that ensouled body, then the death of that body is the death of you. At least that's the strong implication of Aristotle's psychology or his account of human nature.
- 7.34** This presents an obvious problem to all Abrahamic monotheists who believe that the soul is separable from the body, that the human person survives biological death, that biological death is not death and has a conscious existence thereafter. Now, to reconcile that with Aristotle is a big challenge because Aristotle doesn't seem to leave it open that you can subsist as a person, continuing in a form detached from any underlying matter, uploaded into the ether, into the heavenly ether, waiting to be downloaded at the resurrection of the dead in the final judgment at the end of time.

It's awkward. He's an awkward arrival, in some ways, opening up enormous new avenues of human inquiry, in other respects, presenting a real threat.

- 7.35** What happens, just to go into a little bit more detail on what's going on in the so-called translation movement— historians give this term, the translation movement, to this process of the rediscovery of Aristotle. What's going on in 12th-century Europe, from the 1130s onwards, is that Christian forces are gradually retaking Spain from Islam, the Iberian Peninsula from Islam, a territory that Islam had dominated since the first half of the eighth century. They're moving in there in the 700s and are bedded down by the 800s.
- 7.36** But this process, the so-called Reconquista, the reconquest, doesn't conclude until 1492, when Ferdinand and Isabella expelled the last Muslims from the Iberian Peninsula. But it's beginning now in the 1130s. Crucially, in 1085, the city of Toledo— this is where a lot of the magic happens. This becomes where the translation factories begin to emerge. A Spanish Catholic king, Alfonso VI of Castile, captures Toledo in 1085. And so suddenly, Catholic Christians are in charge of a city that is packed with enormous Arabic libraries. It's got these enormous libraries of texts in Arabic. Toledo had been a major center of Islamic learning under Islamic rule. This is the point at which the translation exercises began.
- 7.37** So effectively, the new rulers realized that there was enormous capital in this knowledge and learning. Not solitary scholars, but collaborative teams of translators set to work on translating the texts. Typically, what you'd have was an Arabic-speaking mozarab, who's basically a Christian living under Islamic law, paying his jizya and so on, would orally translate the Arabic into vernacular Spanish. And then, a Latin scholar would simultaneously translate the Spanish into Latin.
- 7.38** So when you think about some of the exquisite delicacy and the complexity of Aristotle's treatises, and particularly Aristotle's Greek, we've got a work that's been translated from Greek into Arabic, either directly or through Syriac. Then these Arabic translations eventually make it, hundreds of years later, to libraries in Spain, in Toledo, probably transported there by Sicilian fishermen, tradesmen, and also some [texts] that have simply been captured in the Reconquista. The Arabic would be translated orally into vernacular Spanish at the time, and then the Spanish would be translated at the same time into Latin.
- 7.39** You've effectively got—you're trying to bridge, to get back to the original text, one, two, three—you've got effectively three bridges, three minefields where translation errors can creep in and no way of checking it. Nobody who reads Greek, nobody actually reads a word of Greek in these collaborative teams, it seems. Nevertheless, there were some great figures: Gerard of Cremona, my favorite. He was an Italian who came to Toledo specifically to be on one of these teams. He learned Arabic himself, very rare in those days, translated 87 of Aristotle's works, and had a whole school of translators working under him.

- 7.40 There were a number of others as well: James of Venice, William of Moerbeke. There were a whole lot of problems getting it right, getting the transliteration right and understanding the terms and the concepts and so on. But broadly speaking, it had an enormous impact, and the translation movement happened at an extraordinary pace, and they worked out how to do it very well. That was the Reconquista route.
- 7.41 There's another one through Byzantium. This is the Greek route, where, effectively in Byzantium, which was still Greek-speaking and Christian, they had preserved a lot of Aristotle's Greek originals, too. This was much, much better, of course, because here you'd have a direct Greek to Latin translation. You wouldn't have to worry about the Arabic and the vernacular Spanish and so on and so forth. James of Venice and William of Moerbeke are key figures here. They're working, actually, directly on the Greek. They managed to get hold of the text through diplomatic missions to Constantinople and so on and so forth. That's roughly how the process works.
- 7.42 Each text has its own particular story, its own particular history. But effectively, what happened is that a market opened up for these texts, a market in Bologna, in Paris, and then subsequently at Oxford and Cambridge, a little bit later. So all the universities are starting to discover that something is happening, that this bomb is about to go off. So this created this commercial manuscript industry, really, for scholarship all around Europe. This is how the text got multiplied and corrected and curated and organized and stored.
- 7.43 From the very first translations, around around the 1150s, to Aquinas really working his magic and devoting all his intellectual powers to them in the 1260s, 1270s, that's just one generation. It's one generation from, as it were, getting hold of these texts to really having a major transformative effect on European thought. It transformed in the 1200s, the university's curricular architecture in enormous ways. Suddenly, universities are teaching these comprehensive systems about nature, about ethics, about politics, about metaphysics.
- 7.44 Before that, before 1150, universities didn't really have much. Libraries would have a handful of texts. The biggest libraries would have a handful of texts, dozens at most. A lot had been lost. Some of it had been copied, some of it had persisted through, thanks to the monastic tradition. But really, before 1150, they're teaching this old, hand-me-down Aristotle, so the Trivium, which is grammar, rhetoric, and logic.
- 7.45 Then there were a few texts of Augustine, a few texts of Boëthius, and there was one text of Plato, the *Timaeus*, which is quite an eccentric dialogue against the backdrop of Plato's wider thought. But because it's got this figure of the demiurge, a creator God, that sold it to a lot of theists, the Muslims and the Christians, so it seems to have survived; there are big commentaries on it and so on. But that's all they had of Plato. They said, "I've got no Plato." They're aware of Plato, but they've got none of Plato's texts. They're not rediscovered until the end of the 1400s in Florence, mainly in Renaissance Italy—that's another explosion, but it's still centuries away.

- 7.46 You might say that there wasn't a focus on the world. It was a focus on life after death, salvation, and a platonic transcendence and otherworldliness. You see this in the writing, see this in Anselm, for example, Anselm of Canterbury. It's not an accident that he developed an ontological argument, that is to say, an a priori argument for the existence of God. An argument that, very unusually, does not look at the way nature is structured or certain things happening in nature. He just says that no, you can shut your eyes, sit in your armchair, and you can think through the existence of God without consulting any—you don't have to use experience at all.
- 7.47 This is partly those imaginative philosophical thought experiments and arguments. You can see that as arising very naturally out of a society or an intellectual culture that is highly literate in many ways and intellectually hungry, but in starvation mode. There are no texts, there's no real knowledge to absorb. There's some Augustine, there's a bit of Plato, but there's not much. The shelves are pretty much empty. Then this sudden explosion, this sudden rediscovery of an entire library. Yes, one man's mind, but still a whole library of completely new disciplines that have been completely forgotten. Biology and physics and meteorology and metaphysics and psychology and logic and politics and ethics and so on and so forth.
- 7.48 This has a revolutionary impact on the university, on the curricular architecture of the university, but also a very threatening one, because suddenly you've got this rival body, this comprehensive explanation of all reality that doesn't actually rely on God, at least not nearly as robustly as the revealed sacred texts of the Abrahamic monotheistic traditions that insisted the world was related to God.
- 7.49 Do you remember the cosmic narcissist up there, thought thinking itself? He's on his own and is totally indifferent to the order of the cyclical universe that he indirectly sustains by being this object of desire. All of that and all the tensions we've seen about whether the soul survives biological death, whether there was an original beginning of time or whether the universe has been existing eternally. All those tensions start to emerge as well.
- 7.50 We have our first ban of Aristotle in 1210 in Paris. Certain books of Aristotle on natural philosophy are banned. That's within about 50, 60 years of him, as it were, trickling back into the bloodstream of European thought. In 1215, the Pope confirms the ban and forbids any lecturing on the books. But crucially, the ban only happened in Paris. Oxford doesn't ban them, and students were desperate for them. It was just dynamite. It was too intoxicating, and it was impossible for Papal authority or the institutional authority of the Sorbonne to withstand this tsunami of interest in these new texts, in this new library, this new world that had arrived in these newly translated manuscripts.
- 7.51 And so effectively, the ban, as you get in the case with other digital networks of scholars and thinkers, it's pointless shutting down one node if you can't shut down all of the nodes. And so just because the Sorbonne had shut down the teaching of these texts, it didn't matter. Effectively, it just put Paris in the back seat. The effect of that

ban faded pretty quickly. Indeed, by 1255, you have to read Aristotle in Paris. The ban didn't last that long. You went from not being permitted to read or listen to lectures on the texts; forty years later, they're required reading in the curricula. The effect of this has completely transformed the curriculum, and we've shifted towards what you might call a Christian Aristotelianism, and all of the massive work that needed to be done to reconcile all the points of tension between Aristotelianism and Christianity.

- 7.52** Aquinas, who's probably the greatest mind, certainly of the 13th century and possibly of Latin Christianity altogether, writes enormous amounts, 10 million words in a relatively short life—he dies at 49. If you look at the extent of Aquinas's commitment to sifting through Aristotle, from doing commentaries on his texts—he does commentary on the *Metaphysics*, he does a commentary on the *Ethics*, he works very, very closely with all the texts of Aristotle, and effectively, tries to baptize him, calls him, as I think I've mentioned in an earlier lecture, simply *Philosophus*, the Philosopher. He rarely refers to him by name.
- 7.53** Aquinas died in 1274, but more condemnations came three years later. In 1277, there was a list of, I think, around about 219 ideas—these weren't texts that were being banned. It wasn't possible to ban the texts anymore, but ideas, propositions of Aristotle that were seen to be too naturalistic and that, as it were, triggered, exacerbated too many tensions with a theistic or doctrinal position. That was pretty aggressive, too.
- 7.54** But really, very quickly, to be educated was to know Aristotle, and the condemnations didn't, in the end, affect very much. Though Aquinas is worth saying, is canonized in 1323, but his intellectual influence does recede. It certainly is not commensurate with what we would expect it to be, given his achievements. Really, it's not until the end of the 19th century that Aquinas comes back in a big way, thanks to Leo XIII, Leo XIII's encyclical in 1879, *Aeterni Patris*. It's an extraordinary document.
- 7.55** I had the good fortune to meet the Pope the other day, and I said to him, "You've got to know your Holiness that Leo XIII is my favorite Pope." I thought, "Oh, goodness. I just told the Pope that he's not my favorite Pope." But I said that Leo XIII is my favorite Pope, and one of the reasons that he's my favorite Pope is that he wrote this. I'm not a Catholic, but I have favorite popes.
- 7.56** One of the reasons he's so good is that—he did a lot of different things, wrote nearly 100 encyclicals, but one of them was this one *Aeterni Patris*, "Of the Eternal Father," the first two words of the encyclical, which is a standard way of titling encyclicals. In 1879, he argues that really we've got to retrieve the genius of Thomism and of Aquinas's thought because it's got Aristotle in it, it's even got some Plato in it, it's got Augustine. It's just this entire cathedral of thought, and we need to recover Thomism and Aquinas because we need some heavy guns to respond to the attacks on the rationality of religious commitment that were well underway in the late 18th century.

- 7.57 In fact, Hume's *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*, 1779. Hume dies in 1776, and then Kant has his attacks in 1781 in the 1780s, and there are many others, but those are the two big skeptical attacks on the philosophical credibility of standard arguments of the existence of God. It only took 100 years, but 100 years later, Leo XIII decided we got to resurrect Aquinas because this has got all of this Aristotelian firepower within it.
- 7.58 This is going to help enhance and raise the intellectual credibility of Catholicism all across the West, which is what happened. That is indeed what happened. There are some complications there, but Thomism really begins to emerge as a serious contender, and Aristotelianism begins to return as well, as we'll consider in the next lecture.
- 7.59 What happens after the 13th century, after the dust settles on the translation movement, you have, moving into the later Middle Ages, the emergence of skepticism about Aristotle. It starts small, but it then gathers pace until the point at which it's not too much of an exaggeration to say that anti-Aristotelianism is the only thing all the many and various enlightenment philosophers and thinkers have in common. There's a huge range of, in many ways—I often tell my students in Cambridge, you always have to pluralize enlightenment. There's no such thing as the Enlightenment. There are enlightenments. There were enlightenments. If you insist on using that term, it's so self-congratulatory that I prefer not to use it.
- 7.60 We've been considering a bit of Aquinas. Aquinas is not living through an intellectually darkened age, as anyone who's ever tried reading him will realize. But the anti-Aristotelianism is what stitches together a lot of the critiques in metaphysics about causation and powers, questions about mechanism, evacuating science and the scientific method, evacuating all these unhelpful Aristotelian ideas from their point of view.
- 7.61 With Descartes and Newton in the 17th century, you get the first fully worked-out framework that is anti-Aristotelian, that is an alternative to Aristotle. Rather than the Aristotelian universe, Aristotelian nature, being made up of beings with their own essences, their own substantial forms, with their own purposes, and with their own principles of mechanism and causation, and that very bottom up, attuned to the natural world approach that Aristotle develops, instead of that, we have effectively a flat metaphysical landscape for Descartes.
- 7.62 You've got extended matter, stuff, extended matter, all of which can be mapped using geometry and maths, and geometry and maths is totally silent about all these different essences you talk about and all these acorns and flamingos and artifacts and natural objects. No, it's just stuff, and the way the stuff operates is not through these spooky powers and essences and dispositions, but mechanics, push and pull, cause and effect, mass in motion. It's just mass in motion.

- 7.63 We can have a mathesis universalis, we can have a universal understanding and knowledge and learning of all of reality because we can map it all out mathematically. It's like the person who thinks he has discovered Australia by drawing a map of Australia. There's that stuff, and then, of course, for Descartes, there's one other kind of stuff, and that is thinking stuff, *res cogitans*. That's what we are. We're just thinking stuff, thinking substance. That's it. We haven't got any essence beyond that. It's not natural or normal for us, for human beings, to have 32 teeth. That's just the bodies we happen to be in, and our personhood exists in this immaterial soul.
- 7.64 Yes, this was an explicitly, really an explicitly anti-Aristotelian manifesto. Instead of Aristotle's four causes or four explanations, four *aitiai*. Remember? Material cause: the bronze, the formal cause: the blueprint of the statue, the efficient cause: making the statue in the factory; and finally, the final cause, the reason why the statue is there at all: to decorate the temple or to earn the sculptor some money, to put some bread on the table, whatever it might be, the actual personal explanation, the human cause, the human explanation.
- 7.65 All four of those come under attack, and effectively, the consequences of the Cartesian Revolution is to get rid of three of them and only to have one, and that's efficient causation, the mechanical causation that happens in the factory. That's the only cause we're allowed in this new dispensation. We don't care about matter, we don't care about form, that's spooky talk, it's strange essences. Nature isn't personal. We're not interested in that as an explanation. The reasons why somebody does something, those are not mechanical explanations, not mechanical reasons. So we get rid of that, too.
- 7.66 It's a radical revolution, a very radical switch in the philosophy of science. It's reinforced also by Galileo in the early 17th century, whose findings did indeed undermine and demolish Aristotelian dynamics. Galileo showed that objects falling from the leaning tower of Pisa or whatever obey mathematical laws of motion. Objects are not seeking natural places or something like that. So there was certain areas, particularly in science, where Aristotle is indeed refuted; this doesn't work. The question is how much to take on and how much to leave.
- 7.67 Then, of course, Newton's *Principia* in 1687. This is the final blow against Aristotle because of these incredibly powerful arguments and theories that the cosmos operates according to mathematical laws, or mostly, Newton left some room for the miraculous. We won't go into that for now. But the point is there are no teleological principles. There are no end-driven, final purpose-driven explanations of the cosmos. The cosmos, you might say, in 1687 with Newton's *Principia*, becomes space.
- 7.68 We have a shift from quite an enchanted way of thinking about the world and reality in the Aristotelian universe with the Great Chain of Being starting with almost the nothingness of pure matter, going all the way up to pure thought and pure actuality at the top of the Great Chain of Being, all the way through with human beings at the center, other animals and plants below that, and the angels above that. It's this very

carefully worked-out, baptized version of Aristotle, and all of that goes very fast. Within a few decades of the 17th century, it's gone. First attack, you might say, with Descartes's *Meditations* in 1641, and then the coup de grâce in 1687 with Newton's *Principia Mathematica*.

- 7.69** It's at that point that Scholasticism and Aristotelianism begins to wane; its grip and its influence on European thought begins to fade. Certainly, by the 1700s, if you're reading Aristotle, this is why you're interested in medieval stuff. The word medieval is beginning to emerge at this point, which simply means the age in between, the middle age, the Middle Ages. Between what? What is it? Some strange historical sandwich with all that weird stuff they did in the Middle Ages, that we can just attach the word medieval to anything, and it discredits it?
- 7.70** Well, it turns out that it's in between the fall of pagan thought, Greco-Roman thought, and its death. And then, you have the Dark Ages and then the Middle Ages. Then you have the Renaissance, the rebirth, and the Enlightenment, these very self-congratulatory terms, which is part of that Aristotelian wave; the very way we periodize history still has the hallmarks of this idea that with the Enlightenment and the Renaissance, the European mind put away childish things, as St. Paul puts it— not in that context, but Aristotle was part of the toys we had to get rid of now that we were growing up.
- 7.71** What we see in the periodizing, in the Renaissance, what drives that forward is the rediscovery of Plato, and what drives the Enlightenment forward, you can say, is a backlash against Aristotle. But it's two entirely different ways of doing philosophy, doing metaphysics.
- 7.72** What we're seeing at the moment—and this will be the subject of the next lecture—is Aristotle's revenge. What we're seeing in Western philosophy at the moment is nothing less than a revolution in Western philosophy, where for the first time in more than 500 years, Aristotle is reemerging as a serious thinker and as a serious figure on the curricula of major universities across the West.
- 7.73** To some extent, this has been happening since the Second World War. It's been happening for a few decades, particularly in universities where classics is very strong and ancient philosophy is very strong, but certainly since the 1950s, we've had an enormous resurgence of interest in Aristotle as a source for moral philosophy—we'll be discussing some of the key figures there: Elizabeth Anscombe, Philippa Foot, Alasdair MacIntyre, and others.
- 7.74** More recently, in the last 15 to 20 years, a revolution in metaphysics, a revolution in the deepest questions of philosophy: on causation, on essence, on laws, and powers, and so on. In fact, my doctoral thesis was a small contribution to that revolution. That will be the subject of our final lecture: Aristotle's revenge, or we could say, Aristotle's

revenges. Is he back, or is he still this outdated museum piece that the Enlightenment tried to persuade us that he was?

Lecture 8: Aristotle's Legacy

At a glance — Aristotle's legacy across philosophy and science.

- 8.1** Welcome to Lecture 8, the eighth and final lecture in Aristotle: From Logic to Life. We find ourselves now at the end of the series in the 20th century at long last, and we can now stand back and consider the impact that Aristotle has had all across the centuries once we've explored his impact on the 20th century, and indeed the 21st in both moral philosophy and metaphysics.
- 8.2** Once we've done that, I'll be able to just reflect with you a little bit more about what we've covered in the previous lectures. What these lectures and the content of Aristotle's thought can help you do is to show you how things can be unlocked, new ways of thinking about the world and about ultimate reality can be unlocked. It's a wonderful example of the history of philosophy in a microcosm, within a single mind, and the impact and legacy that that mind has had.
- 8.3** Thinking about that legacy in the 20th century context, the first point to note is that the climate in the big universities and the big philosophy faculties in the West, particularly in Oxford, but also in Cambridge to some extent—the American universities are beginning to develop very effective and influential philosophy departments—but still, most of the really first-rate people are in England, are in Oxford and Cambridge. There's Quine at Harvard, and later Donald Davidson. David Armstrong emerges. So America becomes more and more important. Australia becomes very important. Some brilliant Australian philosophers start to come through, and some of them sustaining the orthodoxy, others coming in with an Aristotelian critique of it.
- 8.4** But really, what we have is the dominance of the picture of logical positivism, whereby statements are divided up into three categories. That which is analytically true, true in virtue of the nature of the terms used. That which is empirically true, so scientifically true, something that's inferred from some observation about the world. Those two statements are meaningful. Everything else goes into the third box, which is nonsense. "Non-sense," literally nonsense, there's no meaning to it. The idea that "God exists," or "Peter loves Jane," or "I like ice cream," these are technically not meaningful statements because they are neither a posteriori beliefs or truths or claims, nor are they a priori—nor are they analytically true, just true in virtue of the terms that are used.
- 8.5** That's a very reductive project. It's the kind of reductionism that we see beginning even with Descartes and Newton's mechanization of the world, evacuating it of the more enchanted picture—what C. S. Lewis calls in one of his last books, *The Discarded Image*. The image that is being discarded, Lewis argues—and that book is mainly about literature, not really philosophy, but just the impact on literature and the life of the imagination, the European imagination, it has big effects on that, too.

Lewis charts it by saying it's discarding the image of the universe and reality, the great chain of being, that effectively Aristotle bequeathed us as our Aristotelian inheritance.

- 8.6** In the wake of the Second World War, there was a group of women philosophers constellated around Oxford. Oxford, at the time, kept going in a skeletal form. But obviously, a lot of the professors, a lot of the students, were on active duty or on active service. The university did continue, but it was the women philosophers who were having to fill in a lot of the teaching, and they were the ones around at the time. That had created a unifying context for these quite different, but equally philosophically brilliant women to come together and spend a lot of time together, a lot of time in conversation together.
- 8.7** The ones I've got in mind are Elizabeth Anscombe—G. E. M. Anscombe, in terms of if you're looking for her author's name. Philippa Foot; Iris Murdoch, who is a novelist, very famous novelist as well as a philosopher. Mary Midgley, a brilliant cultural philosopher, philosopher of science. We have Mary Warnock as well, and a range of very interesting and engaged philosophical minds.
- 8.8** One of the most important documents that marks, you might say, the beginning of the recovery of Aristotelian ideas in anglophone philosophy, in Anglo-American philosophy, is Anscombe's famous essay called simply *Modern Moral Philosophy*. This was published in 1958, *Modern Moral Philosophy*. In it, she advances a number of revolutionary theses. The first is that moral philosophy should be abandoned in its modern form; we should simply stop doing it. Because, Anscombe argues, really, moral philosophy has been reduced to psychology, what's happening in the mind, in the brain, and we don't actually understand—we don't have an adequate philosophy of psychology. We don't have a philosophy of what the mind or the brain is.
- 8.9** She then argues that notions of moral obligation, moral duty, are incoherent once you graft them onto something other than a theistic law, divine law framework. The very notion of an obligation or of a duty carries within it a universalizing command that doesn't make sense in a purely secular, naturalistic, logical positivistic universe. And indeed, she's right. I mean, if we think of Ayer's three categories, "I have a moral duty to do X," or "I have a moral obligation to do X," that's neither true in virtue of the meaning of the terms. It's debatable in a way that saying that, "A bachelor is an unmarried man," is not debatable, or $2 + 2 = 4$ is not debatable.
- 8.10** Does it come in the second category? Is it something I could find out, establish—that is the moral obligation or moral duty—is it something I could establish through science? No, because science traffics in descriptive claims about the world. It can say what is the case. It can't say what ought to be the case. It's not that of—a moral duty and a moral obligation involves prescription. It involves ought, not just is, something that I have to do. So it can't be in the second category of meaningfulness, but those are the only two categories.

- 8.11** On the positivistic world, which these women are beginning to rebel against, the claim, the thought, "I have a moral duty to do X," is meaningless, just meaningless. It's like saying, "Doing this might give me pleasure." It doesn't have any meaning. It doesn't have any content because normative moral judgments like that, on this view, are noncognitive. They don't involve beliefs. It's just an expression of a desire or an attitude. This is the so-called Humean picture of moral obligation and moral judgment.
- 8.12** So Anscombe says, you just got to get rid of it, until we've got a better vocabulary, a better grammar for talking about these questions. Once you've got rid of the notion of a moral legislator, a moral lawmaker, it doesn't make sense to carry on talking as if the moral lawmaker was still in charge. It's as if the phrase "criminal"—as she puts it at one point, I think—that the criminal is still being used or retains, it still has a usage, even when we've abolished the law and all the courts and all the criminal courts. We still use the language of crime and punishment and so on. It doesn't mean anything anymore. There's deep conceptual confusion.
- 8.13** Now, her prescription is, in fact, to get rid of the whole framework of the idea of ethics as a form of obligation. And she tries to introduce, or reintroduce, Aristotelian virtue ethics, which doesn't require a legislator. In principle, there are a lot of things that a Humean wouldn't accept, but Aristotle's moral universe is still, remember, effectively an agnostic one, or it's not a theistic picture. You can have— all he requires us to sign up to is that there is nature, that there are other people.
- 8.14** But there's nothing in Aristotle's physics, or there's nothing in Aristotle's psychology, that requires us formally to sign up to the existence of God that is theistic—in a way that in many other positions within the theistic framework, you know you're in a theistic framework, that is the ultimate explanation. That's not the case with Aristotle. There was something quite attractive about Aristotle for philosophers who still want to insist that all reality is encompassed by science.
- 8.15** And the thought is you can still claim to be a naturalist, you can still claim to be committed to science, even with this radically different metaphysical picture, because it's not signing you up to spooky stuff. It's not signing you up to Forms in Plato's heaven or strange Cartesian souls or God from Augustine or whatever it might be. It's still quite austere. It's quite lean as a theory of reality. On the basis of Occam's razor, we're shaving away things that are harder to believe in.
- 8.16** Occam's razor is used quite a lot by philosophers. It's very difficult to use it well; turns out there are many ways of shaving with Occam's razor. But parsimony does count, as in good scientific theories. Generally speaking, a theory that requires you to sign up to fewer things beforehand as assumptions is, all other things being equal, preferable to a theory that asks you to sign up to a lot of quite complicated things. Even if both theories have comparable explanatory power, both explain what needs to be explained, maybe in slightly different ways, but you're going to tend to trust the simpler

explanation. It's not a law of logic, but generally speaking, simpler explanations tend to be more reliable.

8.17 So Anscombe's prescription is to return to this focus on eudaimonia: human flourishing, character development, virtues, practical wisdom. And so the question becomes more not, "What must I do? What is my moral duty in this situation? What is my moral obligation in this situation?" And more towards, "How should I live? How should I live? What kind of a person should I become? Should I be trying to become?" Not: what is the correct comprehensive shopping list of all the obligations; all the "thou shalt," and "thou shalt nots." It's a very different way of thinking about ethics.

8.18 On this view, the virtues that you want to cultivate are not just arbitrary impositions from a shopping list that's written by somebody who doesn't really know anything about us, to thinking about virtues as those traits or characteristics that we'd want to try to cultivate over time, often failing, but knowing what progress looks like. Traits that are grounded in who I am as a human being, what I am as a human being, that are consistent with activating my flourishing. That's the framing of trying to think about the moral life, which is a very big shift. This sparked a full, whole-scale revival in virtue ethics in the 1960s, '70s, and particularly into the '80s.

8.19 One of Anscombe's great friends was Philippa Foot, who wrote a very famous, very short but influential book called *Natural Goodness*. Her claim is that the idea that Aristotle's science, his biology, needs to be just put away and forgotten about, but that we can extract some interesting philosophical ideas from him, is actually contestable. What Philippa Foot says is that many naturalists insist that there is a gap between is and ought. You can't get an obligation from just a description of the way the world is. There's nothing in the world that tells you you ought to do X. This is, as it were, Hume's fork—well, it is an important dichotomy in Hume, an important division between the descriptive and the prescriptive.

8.20 What Foot argues, she says, "No, there are actually some forms of life or life forms," as she calls them, "that exhibit a characteristic pattern. You can't just think of them as a random configuration of atoms and functions." There's an internal principle of organization. We know what's something is for. Each species has particular behavior, has a particular life cycle, and so on and so forth. So Foot says, we know what a good specimen of a species is; we know how to distinguish that from a bad specimen or a defective specimen.

8.21 We can say that a three-legged sheep is defective with respect to having the full complement of legs that is normal for a sheep. We can talk about something being "normal" or something being out of the ordinary in terms of the basic biological, the life form, that an animal has. This would still be the case if some lunatic went around cutting one leg off every single sheep in the world. Would that make it the case that sheep are no longer quadrupeds? If there were, in fact, no four-legged sheep left because this lunatic had been going around amputating one leg from each sheep.

- 8.22** Well, how you feel about that question is going to determine whether you're on the Humean side or the Aristotelian side. On the Neo-Humean side, it will be, "Yeah, these objects are now three-legged objects. The total set of sheep on the planet is a set of three-legged things." The questions of what's normal or regular or patterned are not allowed. On the Aristotelian view, "Yes, of course, it's still the case that sheep are quadrupeds, even if there are at the moment, in fact, no examples, no direct evidence, as it were, that that is the case." Why? Because for Aristotle, even the sheep without—all the defective sheep are defective. They're defective with respect to what their substantial form, their essence, determines; namely, that sheep are quadrupeds and have four legs, that it's normal, it's normative.
- 8.23** And so what Foot argues is that you can, in fact, get something like an "ought" from an "is." You can say, "That sheep ought to have a fourth leg. He's missing a fourth leg. That's terrible. It's a tragedy." Foot says we can make sense of this. Why is that suspending natural sciences? Why is that returning to medieval science? Just to recognize what seems an intuitively plausible claim. There's at least one way in which we can look at nature, we look at natural things and see them as having a dimension of normativity. We can start—it may be not a moral ought, but it is an ought. It is a way of thinking about non-scientific or non-purely naturalistic phenomena. We can start thinking in terms of ought.
- 8.24** So Foot then turns to the problem of moral agency and human beings, and she claims that we human beings also have a life form. We also—life form is really her translation of Aristotle's substantial form, or essence. We are rational social beings, she says. We cooperate, we teach, we make promises, we pursue long-term projects. In all of those respects, we are unique in the animal kingdom. Orders of magnitude more unique and developed and sophisticated than anything else in the animal kingdom. We can also think about what it would be for the human life form to display courage, justice, wisdom, and so on and so forth. We can recognize genuine goods. Intellectually, we don't need just instincts. We can see the value in justice and cooperation.
- 8.25** And so what Foot claims is that we've got a philosophy or the beginnings of a moral grammar that is consistent with the sciences. It doesn't ask us to sign up to too much more. It's just a different way of understanding nature, you might say, a more enchanted or more philosophically rich way of thinking about nature. Even if people who want to shave with Occam's razor, which says we're introducing far too many things that we're not comfortable with.
- 8.26** But Foot concludes that moral judgments are not, in fact, as Ayer and others believe, expressions of emotion or attitude—just nonsense, meaningless utterances. They do mean something. They're objective evaluations that are relative to the particular life forms within the moral scenario, in particular, the human life form. We can form true moral judgments or false ones. It's not a question of what we prefer or what we like.

Those are not true statements. They're not claims to say that some moral judgment is true no matter what.

- 8.27** On this other view that the Aristotelians are going up against, there is no deep truth out there. There's no moral universe out there. It's simply one that we invent, and we modulate and calibrate according to how we feel about it, or what our tastes are, what our preferences are. But just as there's no fact of the matter about what is objectively the best ice cream in the world—or there may be some debate about it—because in a way it's hard to make sense of that. Anybody is free to walk away and say, "No, I do not believe that's subjectively the best ice cream in the world." In a way that a person is less free, walking away saying, "I don't believe that $2 + 2 = 4$. I don't believe this fact is true, even though I've got all the evidence for it." That's their claim. That's the claim that Foot is beginning to overturn.
- 8.28** The third in the trio of those who've revived Aristotle that's worth mentioning—not least because he died well into his 90s, in 2025— is Alasdair MacIntyre, whose trilogy of works over the 1980s, beginning with *After Virtue* and then moving into *Whose Justice? Which Rationality?* and then concluding with *Dependent Rational Animals*. That trilogy is a fascinating example of a very influential, very important 20th-century philosopher who begins in Marxism and in Freudianism, to some extent, in Marcuse in the '60s and '70s, and gradually moves away from Marxism towards Aristotelianism; publishes his most famous book, *After Virtue*, in 1981, and then moves towards Thomism. So the Christian adaptation of Aristotle, as encouraged by Leo XIII in *Aeterni Patris*, 1879. It's a fascinating intellectual trajectory that we have with MacIntyre.
- 8.29** If you read nothing else, read the opening chapter of his *After Virtue*, which is just a few pages long. It's a disquieting experiment, or thought experiment, where he asks us to imagine a post-apocalyptic world in which all of our scientific knowledge, all of our scientific technology, all of our laboratories, all of our universities, all of our libraries, have suffered a terrible nuclear attack. He says, "Well, imagine what it would be like to try and put science back together, like Humpty Dumpty." He said it would look, over the course of decades, some people would set up some schools, other people would focus more on different fragments and set up other schools. He says, in this intellectual universe of culture emerging, you would still continue to hear the jargon of the scientific pre-apocalyptic world. There will still be the names, physics and biology, and there's this theory and that theory, but there'll be these huge gaps, and there'll be a lot of confusion, and lots of fights between different areas of science that claim different things are in the gaps.
- 8.30** Then MacIntyre says, "When it comes to moral philosophy, and the moral life, the apocalypse has already happened." The apocalypse happened in the 18th century with the Enlightenment. What you have is, instead of an understanding of nature and physics and science imploding under nuclear attack, if you like, that's what happened to

questions of the good and of virtue and of moral philosophy and a theistically infused moral philosophy. All of that is just blown apart.

- 8.31** What we have in the aftermath is we've still got the language that was used before the apocalypse occurred. We're still talking about oughts and value and the good, or rather goods, more likely. This is very similar to Anscombe's point, that it's as if the law courts and the criminal law had been abolished, but people were still using the language of criminal and the language of penalization and so on and so forth, and guilt. So all the language still persists.
- 8.32** For MacIntyre, that's exactly what has, in fact, happened. He thinks that the whole fragmentation of moral philosophy is because there's been a shattering of any shared consensus that there is genuinely goodness out there that is refracted in different ways. That's why debates in modern moral philosophy don't go anywhere. They're fruitless.
- 8.33** What the Enlightenment tried to do is provide a rational, secular, clear justification for morality, but one that got rid of Aristotle's teleology—there's no human purpose beyond what science tells us is the purpose of human beings as a biological organism, which is going to be inadequate to sum up certainly a person's self-conscious understanding of what their purpose might be.
- 8.34** It's one that also insists there can be no divine command. There can be no place for revelation because that's not rational. It's not allowed. Can't have the Ten Commandments, can't have the Sermon on the Mount, or you've got to treat it very carefully because it's not part of what can be scientifically established or demonstrated, or demonstrated through logic. It goes into that third box for the logical positivist, certainly.
- 8.35** But the challenge is that without any teleology, without any Aristotelian final purpose, and without any divine law, then it's very hard to see how you ground moral claims, how you find a rational basis for them that survives a lot to the counter-objections that have arisen in response to many of these secular attempts to do just that. But the trouble is in pluralist societies, there's no rational, shared—there's no shared rational standard for adjudicating between different competing moral claims.
- 8.36** And what MacIntyre also suggests towards the end of this *After Virtue*, and then again, subsequently in the trilogy, is that the Aristotelian alternative can, as it were, heal a lot of the wounds in this project, and as it were, reverse some of the effects of the apocalypse, because it's a much more complete, and you might say explanatorily generous conception of reality. It's a moral philosophy that focuses on character, that looks at a human life over the course of their lifespan, as opposed to just isolating the consequences of one particular moral act—which is what utilitarians like to do—or assessing what the rational duty basis was for the duty that explains that particular moral act.

- 8.37** The Aristotelian approach is just to say, "What are the traits that we should be cultivating? What are the signs that it is being cultivated well? What are the signs that it's not being cultivated well? What's the basis in who we are as human beings that makes this a trait a sensible one to cultivate, and this trait a sensible one to try to get rid of with a clear horizon ahead?" It's also a philosophy that makes sense, that accommodates the role of feeling and the emotions and appetites in reasoning. It connects ethics to human flourishing. As I said, it anchors it in our essence.
- 8.38** More importantly, we might say—to bring this part of the lecture to a close—remember that crucial distinction that Aristotle makes between the world of practical knowledge, practical reason, and the world of theoretical knowledge, theoretical reason. It turns out that this is exactly the right— it seems to me—exactly the right distinction to make. Because on the theoretical side, you're dealing in precision, you're dealing in, "this is definitely true, definitely false." You've got logic, you've got demonstration, you've got scientific hypothesis and scientific evidence and so on.
- 8.39** Whereas in the practical domain, unless you think that human beings are just robots or just brains or just purely Darwinian animals, then you're going to realize that things are much messier when it comes to thinking about what kinds of rules should govern our praxis, our behavior. What should shape the practical life? In any given scenario, there's no prescription for it. There's no scientifically correct account or guide for you to determine your behavior.
- 8.40** Aristotle's revenge in moral philosophy is not yet decisive, perhaps, but it has been enormously influential, and it is now a very serious candidate within academic philosophy when it comes to ethics and meta-ethics and the study of the good and the study of the right.
- 8.41** We can now turn to the other battlefield that Aristotle's revenge has been making itself felt on, and that's not moral philosophy, it's not unconnected to moral philosophy, it's metaphysics—the study of first principles of being qua being. It's the first science, the first philosophy, as Aristotle calls it. Again, the context into which this revenge starts to unfurl itself is a very reductive context that goes all the way back to David Hume.
- 8.42** David Hume's idea that we think there's causation out there in the world, but we can't actually see it. All we can see is that billiard ball, that pool ball, knocking into that pool ball, and that happens regularly, but there's nothing we can see. There's no necessary connection between the two balls. There are no essences, no Aristotelian essences. There are no natural kinds. All that there is are the descriptions of the properties that we, when we're doing science, use to describe certain things in the world for our convenience or whatever it might be, or maybe because we think it's true. Everything is reducible to physics. There's no substances, even. You think that there's a table there, but actually, it's just a bundle of properties that together form a table, but there's no real table there. It's just the bundle, it's just the network.

- 8.43** This was really a dominant view right up through into the 1970s, until a brilliant young man, brilliant young American—who was really nothing less than a prodigy. Very rare indeed to get prodigies in philosophy. You get them in mathematics, of course, you get them in chess, but in philosophy, it's extremely rare. But this man, Saul Kripke, was indeed a philosophical prodigy, the most astonishing for centuries, I think, in terms of the arguments that he put forward and the influence that they had.
- 8.44** One of the things Kripke argued famously was that there are things in nature that can be said to have necessary connections, things in nature that are connected of necessity. Hume's wrong; we discover these connections, we don't invent them. He would point to the example of water. Water. He says it is a necessary property of water that it is H_2O . Its molecular composition is two hydrogen atoms joined to an oxygen atom. For many centuries, we didn't know that. We didn't know that it was the case that water is necessarily H_2O . If water was something other than H_2O , it wouldn't be water. If H_2O was something other than water, it wouldn't be H_2O . So Kripke says, now we didn't know that until we worked out what the molecular composition was of water. So we discovered something, through science, that was nevertheless necessarily true of water all along.
- 8.45** Similarly with, say, the atomic number of gold: the necessarily 79. That's the atomic number of gold. It's part of what gold is. Again, we didn't know that until we worked out that there were atoms and that different elements had atomic numbers. But once we'd worked it out, we realized we weren't inventing it. We were discovering it and properly classifying it, and that there is no possible world in which gold fails to have the atomic number 79, because in such a world, it would cease to be gold. Just as in another possible world, water would cease to be—if H_2O ceased to be water, then there would be no water. It would not be H_2O .
- 8.46** It turns out, says Kripke, we can certainly make sense—it's very plausible that Aristotle was right, that there are certain elements or organisms that necessarily have properties, properties that are essential to it, that they have an essence. It is an essential property of gold that it has the atomic number 79. It's an essential property of water that it has a molecular composition, H_2O .
- 8.47** What these arguments did, this famous book was called *Naming and Necessity*, 1980. What this book did, really, at a single stroke was to open up the whole of metaphysics to Aristotelian ideas. Really, that was a very important move, an enormously important development. Really, for the first time in 400 years, you might say, 400, 500 years, you've got a serious, a leading philosopher arguing for the return of Aristotelian principles and ideas that had been repudiated way back in the 17th century. It's an important historical moment, not one that's very well known about, not very well known, but it's an important historical moment in the history of Western philosophy.
- 8.48** And so in the '70s, '80s, and then into the '90s, it begins very slowly, but building in the '90s and then into the noughties—I can't remember what 'noughties' is in American, it's

the zero-zero, it's the first decade of the 21st century. Then, Aristotle's revenge really starts to build up a great deal of momentum. Just a few thinkers worth mentioning; there are so many. There's Brian Ellis, there's Stephen Mumford at Durham, there's Jonathan Lowe, who sadly passed away in 2014—he was a great figure in this movement. Kit Fine at Oxford, David Oderberg at the University of Reading, and many, many others were important pioneers of Aristotle's revenge and are happy to start introducing again into metaphysics terms and ideas that would have been completely seemingly banished.

8.49 Substances. No, that table is not just a bundle of table properties. There's a table there. There's an actual substance. It's an object. It's a thing. It's not just our way of composing all the different bundling, all those different properties together. There's a thing in the world that is that. We can say things about it, and we can describe it in metaphysics.

8.50 Also, another important development is the understanding of the way in which essences, the substantial forms of things, also have causal powers. They have dispositions to act in particular ways, and that the right way of thinking about causation is in terms of the powers that objects have to influence and impact the world, and not the Cartesian-Newtonian picture, which is that you've just got this blank landscape of stuff, and then a divine puppeteer who's moving all the puppet strings and animating and activating reality as we see it. As it turns out, the puppet strings get cut in the 18th century, so the whole Cartesian-Newtonian, Descartes's and Newton's picture of the world as still preserving God, just God as this divine puppeteer.

8.51 Hume just cuts the strings and says, "What's different if you just cut the strings? Just say there are no necessary connections between things because God is bringing them about, or God's laws are bringing them about; let's keep the laws and get rid of God. Let's just put the laws in our minds." And what we say, "All that's happening is that the mind," says Hume, "has a tendency to spread itself out upon the world, and to impose all of these different patterns and matrices and blueprints and laws, but they're not really out there in the world. It's just the way that we interpret them." We apply these relations in our mind to the data, the pixels that come in through sense experience, which we copy, through the copy principles, says Hume. And so there's nothing out there in the world that enchants it or connects it together or explains phenomena, and phenomena of regularity and law-likeness.

8.52 The Aristotelian picture completely overturns that. It says that no, all of that is real, but they aren't the puppet strings. Things don't need puppet strings to act. Things have got their own principles of action in their essences, in their profiles. You don't need to explain the acorn's development into an oak tree by appealing to complicated laws or gravity or anything like that. No, it's just part of the DNA. It's part of the organizing substantial form, the essence of the acorn, that is, all other things being equal, how it's going to end up. It's not an accident. It's perfectly predictable. We don't need to find

the external laws and purposes that are imposed upon it from without, because we can make sense of it as its own substantial form with its own profile and its own inclinations, its own dispositions, its own horizons, its own formal causation, material causation, efficient causation, and final causation.

- 8.53** On this view, the claim goes you've got a much more coherent metaphysical landscape that's populated by substances, by properties, by dispositions, by powers, by essences, by natural kinds. You can carve nature at its joints. You can come up with a taxonomy of nature that nature itself yields up to us. It's not one that we simply impose upon it. You can impose that structure. If you're satisfied, as everybody is, that it is a necessary property of gold that—as most people are, that it's a necessary property of gold—that its atomic number is 79, or that the molecular composition of water is H₂O, then you can start to form these taxonomies because you've got some non-negotiable anchor point.
- 8.54** Okay, if the atomic number of gold is 79, what's the atomic number of silver? What's the atomic number of copper? Then suddenly you've got a principle of organization and taxonomy that isn't just random, that isn't just invented or imposed upon the world, but actually reflects the structure and the interrelations and the possible chemical interactions between different elements.
- 8.55** It turns out that once we can spot something's essence, we can then start to organize the world in ways that Aristotle could and did. Whereas on the contemporary scientific picture, really, these are just roadmaps that are convenient for us. There's nothing out there in the world that organizes itself into neat hierarchies and patterns. These are just our ways of understanding the world, the ways in which we make the world intelligible for us.
- 8.56** Really, what it comes down to is this central question: Are you going to take the world as it's given to you, as you find it, or is the world that you find, the one that we simply mold and construct into our own particular model of it? Then eventually, one of those models will cease to be useful, like the Newtonian model of classical physics, that will cease to be useful, or the Aristotelian model of logic, that ceases to be useful, but we can just now ditch it and we'll pick up a better one. We'll pick up quantum mechanics or we'll pick up relativity theory, or we'll pick up non-standard logic.
- 8.57** This is nothing less than a revolution in metaphysics. It's still ongoing, but this new landscape—this new theoretical conception of objects and causes and laws and powers and so on, and explanations and purposes and teleology, and the integration of metaphysics and science and so on and so forth, explanations of change and persistence—all these ideas are back in a way that, as I said, has not been the case for well over half a millennium. So these are exciting times for people who like Aristotle working in contemporary philosophy.

- 8.58** So beginning to look back on what we've covered in this lecture, we've looked at the way in which Aristotle has an impact on two seemingly quite distinct areas of philosophy: moral philosophy, but also in metaphysics. And we've seen how one great attraction of it is that you can integrate Aristotle's moral philosophy and his metaphysics and his understanding of psychology, what it is to be a human person. All of it clicks together into a coherent whole.
- 8.59** Whereas when the reductive naturalists, the positivists, are working, are theorizing, you don't get that sense of interconnectedness. The metaphysics doesn't really illuminate the moral philosophy, nor does its theory of the self, its theory of personhood, its theory of psychology. Whereas within Neo-Aristotelianism, you do have plausible ways in which ethics connects to metaphysics and connects to our human self-understanding as being animals, at least being animals, but being considerably more than that because of our reasoning, our power of reason, and so on and so forth. I think it's that interconnectedness, which is a very striking feature of Aristotle's ideas and Aristotle's thought.
- 8.60** Over the last eight lectures, we've explored all the different nooks and crannies of Aristotle's extraordinary cathedral of thought. We've looked at logic, we've looked at the philosophy of nature, we looked at metaphysics and then psychology, and moved to think about ethics, and then the ethics of the individual life, and then the ethics of communal life in the Politics. Then we looked at his Poetics, literary theory, and so on and so forth. Then, over this lecture and the previous lecture, we've been covering all of the afterlives of Aristotle. We've shown the history of how Aristotle is received is a substantial history of philosophy itself with very few missing parts.
- 8.61** That's given us a sense, an integrated perspective of Aristotle's achievement that is not always easy to get hold of in a conventional university, partly because it's very rare that you'll get a lecture series that tries to cover all the different aspects of his thought and therefore how the different aspects might connect together. Typically, what you will get is a lecture series on Aristotle's ethics, or you'll get a lecture series on Aristotle's metaphysics, or his De Anima, the theory of his psychology will come in.
- 8.62** That's partly because, as you've probably gathered by now, we're covering such vast terrain in such a short space of time. Every one of these lectures could, in principle, have been a series on its own, looking in detail at the different texts and the different arguments and the different impact that those arguments had. But I hope that it's been a beneficial trade-off. I've designed it and intended it to be a beneficial trade-off so that what we've maybe lost in terms of really granular detail, we've certainly gained a great deal more in terms of the comprehensive overview, the bird's-eye view as opposed to the worm's-eye view. I think it's better to get a bird's-eye view first because then you can work out where the juiciest worms are.
- 8.63** We've got this idea, this sense of a systematic unity. The logic is what provides us with the tools for reasoning and in examining the world and developing the philosophy of

nature. The integration of scientific understanding, but also non-scientific understanding through logic. It helps us to do metaphysics and to think about metaphysics and fundamental questions of ultimate reality. Then that helps us to reflect on the question of soul and embodiment in the natural world and how the human person fits into the natural world.

- 8.64** Then we're ready to start asking questions about how should we live? What do flourishing human beings live like and how can we structure behavior towards obtaining that goal? Aristotle can answer that because he's already given an account of what the human person is. Just as you can only ask, "What ought this to do?" if you know what it's for. You can only evaluate a knife as a sharp knife, as a good knife, if you know that it's a knife or if you know what the purpose of it is. If you think that it's something that was intended for writing, then you'd say, "No, it's not good. It's not useful."
- 8.65** This idea of particular things having a purpose, and human beings have a purpose, therefore that is the life well-lived for human beings. What needs to be the case for that to happen at scale? You need to start thinking about politics and how large groups of people in a complex society are to fit together, are to be organized in a way that enables their flourishing, that is conducive to their flourishing, to their seeking and pursuing and attaining the highest good.
- 8.66** Some of the themes, many of which were rejected during the Enlightenment, of course, this sense of purposiveness, not just of human purpose, but of the purpose of all living things. The idea of the mean, of that tightrope walk between two vices. The task of finding the virtuous line is often the task of finding the middle road between two vices. Remember his definition of courage as something that strikes a mean, golden mean between cowardice on the one hand and rashness on the other. So both, as it were, are vices, and so the courageous person works out in a proper way that balance between rashness and cowardice and so on and so forth.
- 8.67** This idea of practical reasoning, practical wisdom has been something distinct from theoretical reasoning, and therefore messier and more open to impressionistic answers and solutions as opposed to precise geometric or scientific ones or logical ones, as is the case with theoretical reasoning.
- 8.68** His theses about political constitutions and structures and tensions between democracy and oligarchy, which we saw yesterday—well, we saw in the lecture on the politics—how those ideas, a lot of what's driving those ideas is equality for the most part for the democrats, and freedom for the most part—freedom and tradition, you might say—driving the oligarchs. Those political tensions that Aristotle describes from the 5th and 4th century [BC] have just as much salience and application to political debates today.

- 8.69** Then, of course, all these unusual ideas of form and matter as a potential answer to the mind-body problem, because it's not a dualism. That the soul is woven in is the animating, activating principle, the structuring principle of the human body. The mind is much more integrated in body and in matter than, say, Descartes has it, or Plato has it, where you have these two distinct substances.
- 8.70** We've covered an awful lot. We've opened up some new ideas. We've got this idea of this important vision of the systematicity of philosophy. I hope we've also got an idea in the last two lectures of the resilience of his legacy, the extent of his legacy, and the extent to which he always seems to be burying his undertakers. Every 500 years, every 500 to 1000 years, something happens, somebody comes along, or some revolution happens that just displaces him, or he's just lost by accident. But he's always burying his undertakers, he's always coming in through the back door and announcing himself in fresh, new, and generative ways.
- 8.71** I hope you've enjoyed listening to these lectures as much as I've enjoyed delivering them, and I would encourage you to treat these lectures as a jumping-off point, a springboard, into learning more about Aristotle than I could ever hope to teach you in the course of eight short lectures. But I hope you will already have a taste for that, a desire to learn more about Aristotle and his universe and the legacy that he left, because it's an achievement that really transcends any particular era. He's not just a monument to the past. He's a living, conversing guide for us in the present, and indeed, I think, long into the future.
- 8.72** So thank you for joining me on this journey through one of the most remarkable minds in human history.